

Anna Sen Mennä

A FOLK HORROR NOVEL

Seven Martin

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CHAPTER 1

The Drive Up

The radiator starts banging at four in the morning and that's the end of sleep. Aino lies there for twenty minutes listening to it, waiting for it to stop, and when it doesn't she gets up and makes coffee and stands at the kitchen window watching the parking lot fill with the kind of February dark that doesn't become light so much as it becomes a different shade of dark. She showers. She finishes packing the bag she'd started the night before and then abandoned. She carries everything down to the Subaru in two trips and by five-thirty she's on the road, an hour earlier than she'd planned, which is fine. Better than lying there. Better than listening to the radiator and thinking.

The interstate is quiet. She turns the radio on and off twice before leaving it off. There's nothing she wants to hear.

She'd stopped at the Pick 'n Save last night — peanut butter, apples, a sleeve of saltines, things that wouldn't go bad in her father's house because she didn't know what nineteen years did to a refrigerator and she didn't want to find out hungry. The bags are on the passenger seat. She'd eaten an apple for dinner in the parking lot before driving home and felt sorry for herself for approximately thirty seconds, which felt like enough.

Her father's name was Henrik Hietala, though no one had called him that. He'd been Hank since before she was born. He died six days ago in his kitchen in Kivijärvi, Michigan, at the age of seventy-seven, while making coffee. The neighbor found him in the afternoon when he didn't show up at the

bar. The lawyer told her all of this on the phone while she sat at her desk at work with a half-finished form on her screen, a request for medical records that was due the next morning, and she'd put the lawyer on hold twice — once to finish with the Social Security office and once because she'd needed a minute, just one, before she came back on and said yes, she would come, and when was the funeral.

Friday. The funeral is Friday.

She'd finished the form before going home. She doesn't know why she'd done that. Habit, probably. The kind of habit that holds you together when nothing else will.

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The snow starts around Wausau, fine and dry and not serious yet, just enough to make her turn on the wipers. The man on the radio — she's tried it again, settled on a basketball game because at least basketball has a score, something definite happening — is calling the game in that voice that sports men have, the big unhurried authority of it. She's not following. It's just a voice in the car. She's grateful for it.

She thinks about the coffee maker.

This is what her brain keeps doing. Not the big things, not the funeral or the house or what happens after, but the coffee maker — whether her father had still been using the old percolator or whether at some point he'd bought one of the machines with the pods. She doesn't know why this matters to her. It doesn't matter. But she'd been in his kitchen a hundred times as a girl and the percolator had always been there, the same dented aluminum one, and she wants to know if it was still there when he died and she can't ask anyone because it would be a strange thing to ask.

She'd been nineteen the last time she was in that kitchen. Nineteen. Her father would have been fifty-eight, which seems impossible now. He'd made her instant Folgers because she'd asked for instant Folgers, which she'd done because she was nineteen and contrary and she doesn't even like instant Folgers and she has thought about that cup of coffee with a regularity that is embarrassing, off and on, for nineteen years.

The truck in front of her slows. She slows. The snow is heavier now, the wipers earning their keep, and the road is going gray and soft at the shoulders. She backs off to forty-five and settles in.

She has not cried yet. She keeps waiting to and it keeps not happening. She cried at a commercial last month — a dog, a soldier coming home, deeply manipulative, she'd known it was manipulative while it was happening — but she has driven two hours toward her dead father's house and her eyes are dry and she doesn't know what to make of herself.

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She crosses into Michigan at four-eighteen. The sun is already going — February at this latitude doesn't fool around — and the sky has that bruised, purple-gray look of a winter evening on the range. She knows this sky. She'd forgotten that she knew it.

The trees change when she crosses the state line, or maybe she just starts noticing them. The pines up here are different from the ones in Wisconsin — older, denser, crowding close to the road like they've decided the right-of-way is an inconvenience they've been tolerating for a hundred years. Her father used to tell her that the white pines along this stretch had been here when his great-grandfather stepped off

the boat. *They were already big then*, he'd said. *Eino told his wife he thought he'd come to the wrong country*. She'd been in the back seat, eight years old maybe, and the trees had seemed enormous to her, cathedral-enormous, the light coming through them in columns. She'd believed every word.

The basketball game has ended. The same man is doing the postgame now, a detailed and apparently urgent discussion of what went wrong in the third quarter. She is not listening at all.

The radio cuts out.

Not static — silence. A clean, total silence, like someone reached over and turned it off, which no one did. The display still shows the station. The volume is still up. She glances at the signal bars and sees they're full, which they shouldn't be — there's never signal on this stretch, never has been, the hills or the trees or something kills it every time. She knows this road.

She doesn't touch the dial.

A dead spot, she thinks. They happen. You drop a station and pick up the silence between, and the display just hasn't caught up. Except the display has never caught up wrong before, not in nineteen years on this road, and the bars are full, and a dead spot is static, fuzz, the ghost of a station two counties over bleeding through — a dead spot is not nothing. The hills, then. The trees. Something between her and the tower, the dense pines swallowing it the way they swallow the light. But she'd lose the signal for that, lose the bars, and the bars are full.

She gives it the next reasonable thing. A fault at the station. A man at a board somewhere reaching for the wrong switch. That's allowed. That happens.

She drives. The silence holds. It is not the silence before she'd turned the radio on; that had been just quiet, the ordinary quiet of a car and a road. This is the other kind. The kind that is waiting for something. Like the quiet after someone asks a question — the room holding its breath for the answer. She counts. She doesn't mean to and then she's doing it anyway, the seconds, the way you count the gap between lightning and the thunder to know how far off the storm is. Four. Five. Six.

The man comes back mid-sentence: —*the kind of decision that'll cost you in March*. No static, no fade-in, just there again like he'd never been gone, like the gap had been hers and not his.

She exhales slowly. She hadn't realized she'd stopped breathing.

A sign comes up out of the snow, green and reflective, and her eyes go to it the way eyes do on an empty road, hungry for anything. *TAMARACK 11*. She reads it twice. She has no business in Tamarack — she's never had business in Tamarack — but the name sits there a beat longer than it should, the way a name does when you've heard it somewhere and can't place where. Then the sign is behind her and the road is dark again. She's forty minutes past the exit before it occurs to her that she should have eaten something. She eats an apple without tasting it.

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She's been in this part of the state before, obviously, but she hasn't been here in so long that it hits her strangely — familiar and not, the way a word looks wrong if you stare at it too long. She passes Bear's Bar, which she'd forgotten entirely until she sees it and then remembers it completely: the neon,

the gravel lot, the smell of cigarettes that had hit her in the face the one time her father had taken her inside at age eleven to use the bathroom. She passes the mine pits, which she had not forgotten. They're everywhere up here, filled with green water in summer — her father had called them by their old company names, the Cleveland-Cliffs, the Mather B, the Pewabic, ghost names for ghost holes in the ground.

The sign for Kivijärvi comes up at six forty-one. Population 711 — the number on its own little panel bolted underneath the main sign, the same sign she'd read from the back seat as a child, only then it had said 1,400.

She slows to thirty-five and the town comes up around her, what's left of it. The Lutheran church. The Finnish Hall, dark. The diner. Hakala's with two trucks in the lot. The gas station. The cross street at the bottom of the hill that goes to the lake.

She doesn't turn. She goes the other way.

The gravel road has been plowed, snow piled high on both sides. She follows it half a mile until it bends and the house appears in her headlights: the porch, the peak of the roof, the big Norway pines around it, and her father's truck in the driveway where it has sat since Wednesday and where it will sit until she moves it.

She parks and sits in the car for a moment. She's not sure what she's waiting for.

Nothing, she decides. She's not waiting for anything.

She gets out. The cold hits her immediately — not the temperature, which is twenty and not even bad for here, but the quality of it, that specific U.P. dryness that she'd forgotten, like the air is made of something finer than regular air. Her breath comes out in a cloud and disappears. The pines are perfectly still.

And then, from behind the house — down the slope, from the direction of the lake she can't see but knows is there, knows the way she knows her own name — there's a sound. A long, low crack, deep and resonant, rolling out across the ice.

Just the ice, she tells herself. The ice does that. She's heard it a thousand times.

She gets her bag from the back seat and goes to the porch. The light above the door is on — the neighbor, or the lawyer, somebody left it on for her — and as she reaches the bottom step it flickers. Once. A pause, long enough that she thinks it's done. Then again. Another pause, longer, the dark coming back and sitting there. Then a third time, and this time she's stopped on the step watching it, her bag in her hand, the cold coming up through her boots. Then it holds steady, the way it must have been holding steady all along.

Old wiring, she thinks. Old house.

She lets herself in.

The smell of him is everywhere, coffee and sawdust and the particular cold of a house that's been sitting for a week with no one in it. And underneath all that something else, something she can't name, something like the smell of a basement or a lake at the end of winter — dark and cold and patient.

She sets her bag down. She looks at the kitchen counter.

The percolator is there. The same one, the dented aluminum one, forty years old if it's a day. She crosses the kitchen and puts her hand on it. Long cold.

She hadn't known until this moment that she'd been hoping it would still be there. She doesn't know what it means that it is.

She sleeps badly, which she'd expected. The house makes noises. She wakes twice thinking she's heard something and both times it's nothing, just a settling board or the furnace, and she lies in her childhood bed under the quilt her grandmother made her and stares at the ceiling and doesn't sleep.

The third time she wakes it's nearly three. And this time it isn't nothing.

She lies still and listens. It's coming from outside — from the direction of the lake, half a mile through the trees. A sound she can't quite name. Rhythmic, with gaps. Not mechanical. She waits for it to make sense. It doesn't. After a few minutes it stops.

She gets out of bed and goes to the kitchen window. She doesn't turn on the light.

The moon is up and the yard is bright with it, the snow lit almost blue. The pines at the far edge are black. The yard between the house and the trees is smooth and unbroken except —

Except for the footprints.

They come from the tree line, single file, and they cross the yard and they end at the back porch. Small prints. Evenly spaced. Too small for an adult, too deliberate for an animal.

Aino stands at the window in the dark and looks at them for a long time.

Animal, she thinks. Has to be. Some animal she's not thinking of right now because it's three in the morning and she's exhausted and has been driving for thirteen hours and her father is dead.

She goes back to bed. She pulls the quilt up. She listens to the house.

She doesn't sleep.

CHAPTER 2

Hakala's

She wakes at seven-fifteen to gray light through curtains she made from a bedsheet when she was fourteen and which are apparently still doing the job. For a moment she doesn't know where she is — the ceiling is wrong, too low, the smell is wrong, too old — and then she does know and lies there with it for a minute before getting up.

The quilt goes back. Her feet find the cold floor.

In the kitchen she starts the percolator and while it heats she goes to the window. The yard is still bright from last night's moon, though the sun hasn't cleared the pines yet and won't for another hour. She looks at the snow.

The footprints are still there.

She'd half-convincing herself in the thin hours of early morning that she'd imagined them, or misread them, or that a wind had come up and softened them into something else. But there they are, crisp as they were at three a.m., a single line crossing the yard from the tree line to the porch. Small. Patient-looking, somehow, which is a strange thing to think about footprints but she thinks it anyway.

She stands there until the percolator is done and then she pours a cup and stands there some more.

An animal, she decides again. Some animal she's not thinking of. She is not going to stand in her dead father's kitchen catastrophizing about footprints in the snow when she has a funeral home appointment in Iron Mountain at ten o'clock.

She drinks the coffee. It's not as good as she remembered. It's not bad either.

The drive to Iron Mountain takes forty-five minutes on roads that haven't been plowed since yesterday, and she follows a salt truck for the first twenty miles and doesn't mind. The landscape out here in daylight is both exactly what she expected and strange to her — the pines, the sky, the flat white fields that open up between stretches of woods, the occasional farmhouse set back from the road with a light in one window. She had forgotten how far apart everything is. In Milwaukee you can feel the city around you even when you can't see it. Out here you can't feel anything around you at all.

The funeral home is on the main street in Iron Mountain, a brick building with a discreet sign and a parking lot that's been carefully shoveled. The man who meets her is named Gerald, fifties, the kind of careful gentle that people in his profession either come by naturally or learn so thoroughly it becomes the same thing. He has a folder with her father's name on it. He offers her coffee and she says no thank you and they sit across a desk from each other and go through the folder.

He says her father's name the right way. That's the thing she notices first, sitting down. *Hietala* — the *ie* short and clipped, the way her father said it, the way the old men in the township say it, not *Hy-tay-la* the way the bank and the school and the State of Wisconsin have said it her whole life. People who learn the name learn it wrong. Gerald didn't learn it. He has it. She files that away without knowing where to put it and lets him keep talking.

Her father had, it turns out, pre-arranged most of this. Left a list of preferences — no viewing, Lutheran service, cremation after. The plot in the church cemetery had been in the family since his grandfather's time; that part at least required nothing from her. Gerald says all of this with a kind of respectful approval, as though her father had done everyone a favor by being so organized about his own death, which Aino supposes he had.

The folder, though. The folder is wrong, or not wrong, but old. The intake form on top is dated last week, crisp, the toner still sharp. But underneath it there's an older sheet, the paper gone soft and faintly yellow at the edge the way paper goes when it's sat in a drawer for years, and the typeface on it is the gray, slightly broken gray of a machine that needed a new ribbon a long time ago. She can't read it upside down and doesn't try. Pre-arranged, she reminds herself. He set this up years ago; of course there's old paper in here. People plan ahead up here. People who've watched their parents die in February plan very far ahead. That's all it is. She signs where Gerald indicates and doesn't look at the old sheet again, and not looking at it costs her something small she'd rather not price.

She picks up a small envelope of information about what happens next, what she'll need to bring to the service, who will contact whom. Gerald is very thorough. She is grateful for his thoroughness because it means she does not have to think.

She is in the parking lot by eleven-fifteen, earlier than she'd expected. She sits in the car for a moment. Iron Mountain feels enormous after Kivijärvi — a grocery store, a hardware store, two gas stations visible from where she's parked, people walking on cleared sidewalks. A woman in a

red coat walks past with a dog. Ordinary world going on.

She drives to the grocery store and buys actual food. Soup, bread, eggs, a rotisserie chicken she's going to eat most of in the car. She eats the first leg in the parking lot before she's even started the engine and does not feel sorry for herself about it.

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By the time she gets back to Kivijärvi it's early afternoon and the light is already thinning. She puts the groceries away in her father's kitchen, which is the strangest thing she's done in recent memory — opening his cabinets, learning where he kept things, finding that the soup bowls are exactly where they always were but the mugs have moved to the other side of the sink. Small adjustments. Nineteen years of small adjustments without her.

She makes herself eat a bowl of soup and then doesn't know what to do with herself.

The house is very quiet. She'd forgotten this kind of quiet — no traffic, no neighbors, no ambient hum of a city doing its business. Just the furnace and the wind starting up outside and, very faintly, the creak of the pines. She cleans the kitchen, which takes ten minutes. She brings in more wood from the stack on the porch for the fireplace her father apparently never used anymore, judging by the cold ash in it. She makes a fire. She sits in front of it in her father's chair and lasts about twenty minutes before the silence gets to be too much and she needs to be somewhere that has other people in it.

Hakala's is four minutes away.

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The bar hasn't changed in any way she can detect. Same neon Leinenkugel's sign in the window. Same wood paneling the color of old tobacco. Same low ceiling, same eight or ten stools at the bar, same four booths along the wall. The smell is exactly what she remembered — beer and woodsmoke and the ghost of fifty years of cigarettes, back when you could smoke in a place like this.

She sits at the bar. There are three other people in the room: a man and a woman in the far booth who appear to be having a quiet argument, and an old man at the end of the bar who she clocks immediately and then looks away from.

Paavo Maki. He has to be eighty-something now. He was always thin and he is thinner, the way very old men get — papery, like the wind could rearrange him. He is drinking what looks like a brandy old fashioned and watching the television mounted in the corner, which is showing a hockey game with the sound off.

The bartender comes over. He's maybe thirty-five, dark-haired, a beard. She doesn't recognize him.

"What can I get you."

"Leinenkugel's," she says. "And a burger if you're still doing food."

"Kitchen closes at eight." He gets her the beer. "You just get in?"

"Last night. I'm Hank Hietala's daughter."

Something crosses his face — the particular expression people have in small towns when they're calibrating how much they knew the person and how sorry to be. "I heard about your dad," he says. "I'm sorry. He was in here a lot. Good guy."

"Yeah," she says. "He was."

She doesn't actually know if this is true. She knew her father for nineteen years and then she left, and the man who came into this bar regularly for the last nineteen years is someone she didn't know at all. But it seems like the right thing to say.

The burger comes. She eats half of it before she becomes aware that the old man at the end of the bar has turned on his stool and is looking at her. When she glances up he doesn't look away.

"You're Hank's girl," he says.

"Aino," she says.

"I know who you are." He says it without heat, just as a fact. "I found him, you know. Your father. I'm Paavo Maki."

"I know," she says. "The lawyer told me. Thank you for — " she's not sure how to finish that sentence. Thank you for checking on him. Thank you for going in when he didn't show up. Thank you for not leaving him there longer than you had to.

"He didn't suffer," Paavo says. "If that's something you want to know. It was fast."

"Thank you," she says again.

He nods. He picks up his drink and she thinks that's the end of it, that he'll turn back to the hockey game, and she goes back to her burger. But after a minute he speaks again.

"How long are you here for?"

"Through the weekend. Maybe a little longer. I need to get the house sorted out."

He nods slowly, looking at his glass. "You going to stay at the house?"

"That's the plan."

Another pause. The couple in the booth have stopped arguing and are now eating in silence, which seems worse

somehow. The hockey game goes on soundlessly overhead.

"Don't go out on the lake," Paavo says.

She looks up. "Sorry?"

"The ice." He doesn't look at her. "This time of year. It's not safe."

She almost smiles. She's been coming up here since she was born — or had, once — and she knows what the ice is like in February. "Okay," she says.

"I mean it." Now he does look at her, and his eyes are sharper than she'd expected, sharper than an eighty-something man sitting alone with a brandy old fashioned at five in the afternoon has any right to be. "Stay off the lake."

She holds his gaze for a moment. He means it, that much is obvious — but it's a strange emphasis to put on it, a strange way to say what he's saying. Not *the ice is thin* or *it hasn't frozen solid yet*. Just: don't go out on the lake. Like the ice is the least of it.

"All right," she says.

He turns back to the hockey game.

She finishes her burger. She has another beer. The couple in the booth pays and leaves. The bartender wipes down the bar and puts some glasses away and she can tell he's the kind of bartender who's comfortable with silence, which she appreciates. At some point Paavo Maki finishes his brandy and puts on his coat and goes out without saying anything else, and the door lets in a cold blast when it opens and swings shut.

She sits with her second beer for a while after he's gone. The bar is empty now except for her and the bartender and the hockey game. She watches the players move around the ice without the sound, which makes it look like something she

doesn't have a word for. Purposeful and silent and far away. The puck goes somewhere she can't see and they all turn at once and skate after it. From up here, with the sound off, they don't look like men playing a game. They look like something moving on ice for a reason she isn't allowed to know.

Stay off the lake.

She means to think about it the way she thinks about everything — turn it over, find the rational shape of it, set it down. He's old. Old men in towns like this carry a list of things that aren't safe and they hand the list to anyone who'll hold still. The ice is thin in February. People drown. He found her father; he's allowed to be careful about her. There. That's the explanation, sitting there reasonable on the bar in front of her, and it doesn't take.

It doesn't take because she can still feel where the second one landed. Not in her ear, where the first one had gone, the polite warning she'd half-smiled at. The second one — *stay off the lake*, his eyes finding hers, the brandy forgotten in front of him — that one had gone in lower, under the sternum, and it's still there now, a small cold weight she can't talk herself out of, the way you can't talk yourself out of having swallowed something. Her body believed him before she'd decided whether to. Her body is still believing him.

She thinks about the footprints in the snow this morning. Small and evenly spaced and unhurried. Coming from the trees, crossing the open yard, ending at the back porch. Going to the porch. Not coming from it. She hadn't let herself finish that thought this morning and she doesn't finish it now, but it's in the room with her, the way the warning is in her ribs, and the two of them seem to know each other.

An animal, she thinks. The ice is thin. She pays her tab and tips well and goes out into the cold.

The drive back to the house takes four minutes. There are two ways. The short way drops down the hill and crosses at the bottom, the cross street that runs along the shore, the one she'd grown up taking because it was simply how you went — past the boat launch, past the dark water you could see in summer between the houses. The long way climbs back through town and comes around on the plowed gravel road through the pines, the high road, the one that never sees the lake at all.

At the bottom of the hill she comes to the cross street and her hands are already turning the wheel before she's chosen anything, the long way, up and around, away from the water. It adds maybe ninety seconds. The headlights swing across snowbanks and the black wall of pines and there's no lake out there to see in the dark anyway, no reason on earth not to take the short way, and she takes the long way, and she keeps her eyes on the gravel where it unrolls white in the high beams and does not once look toward the shore she can't see.

It's the faster way home. She tells herself that, getting the words ready in case she needs them.

She doesn't need them. There's no one in the car to say them to. There's only the small cold weight riding along, and the gravel, and the pines going by, and the turn for the house coming up where it always has.

She doesn't ask herself whether the fast way is true. She knows it isn't. She drives the long way and lets that be the thing she doesn't examine instead.

CHAPTER 3

The House

She gives herself the morning.

This is what she decides over her second cup of coffee, standing at the kitchen window again, the footprints still there in the yard, the sun finally clearing the pines and throwing long blue shadows across the snow. She has nowhere to be until the funeral tomorrow. The lawyer's office isn't until Monday. She has a whole day in this house with nothing required of her and she is going to use it the way she uses days off in Milwaukee, which is to say systematically, starting with the thing she least wants to do and working toward the thing she least minds.

What she least wants to do is go through her father's bedroom.

She does it anyway.

It doesn't take long. He was not a man who accumulated. The closet holds work clothes and two dress shirts still in their dry-cleaning bags and a pair of boots so old the leather has gone gray. The dresser holds what dressers hold. On the nightstand: a glass of water gone flat, a library book two weeks overdue about the iron mining history of the U.P., a pair of reading glasses with a cracked left lens that he had apparently been wearing anyway. She sets the glasses down carefully. She doesn't know why she's being careful with them. He's not going to need them.

She strips the bed and puts the sheets in the washer because it seems like the right thing to do and because it gives her something to do with her hands.

Then she goes back to the kitchen and makes more coffee and looks at the rest of the house and thinks about where to start. The living room is fine — dusty, sparse, the couch and the chair and the television and a bookshelf full of paperback westerns and U.P. history and one incongruous copy of a Larry McMurtry novel she doesn't remember him ever mentioning. The bathroom is fine. The small second bedroom that was hers is fine, sealed in 1987 the way childhood bedrooms are, the Indigo Girls poster she'd tacked up at sixteen still on the wall, slightly crooked, the same way it had been slightly crooked when she put it up.

That leaves the basement.

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The door to the basement is off the kitchen, next to the back door. She's walked past it a dozen times since she arrived and not opened it. This is not intentional. She tells herself this is not intentional.

She opens it now.

The smell comes up first — sawdust and machine oil and something under that, something mineral, like wet stone. She finds the light switch and goes down.

The basement is two rooms. The front half is storage — the furnace, the water heater, shelves of paint cans and mason jars and the kind of accumulated household miscellany that takes forty years to build up and an afternoon to throw away. The back half is the workshop, and this is where her father spent his time.

She can tell because of the tools.

She knows tools. She grew up in a house where things got fixed rather than replaced, where her father could look at a broken thing and understand it the way some people

understand language. But the tools on the pegboard back here are not tools she recognizes. Some of them she can name — a drawknife, a froe, a spokeshave, hand tools for working wood, old ones, older than her father probably. But others she cannot place. Long-handled things with heads she doesn't have names for. A series of chisels of graduated sizes hung in precise order. A mallet with a head of dense, dark wood, the handle worn smooth in a very specific way, the way handles get when the same hand has closed around them ten thousand times.

She picks up the mallet. It's heavier than it looks.

On the workbench: a half-finished piece she can't identify, clamped in a vise. Cedar, she thinks — the smell is right. Whatever it is, it's carved rather than built, shaped from a single piece of wood rather than assembled. She can see where the chisel marks are still rough, where he hadn't finished. He had been in the middle of something when he died.

She puts the mallet down. She looks at the walls.

He's covered them — not covered, that's the wrong word, decorated isn't right either. Marked them. Small carvings in the wood of the wall studs, in the exposed framing between the drywall panels. She has to get close to see them. Not letters, not exactly, though some of them remind her of something. Runes, she thinks, or what she imagines runes look like, though she doesn't actually know what runes look like.

She reaches out and traces one of them with her finger, following the cut of it, the way you'd read a word in a language you don't have. The wood is cold. Not cool, the way wood is in a basement in February — cold, the way the percolator was cold, the way a thing is cold when it has been

holding the cold for a long time and means to go on holding it. She takes her hand back. The furnace is six feet away and running. She puts her finger against the stud beside it, the plain one, the uncarved one, and it's only wood, only the ordinary chill of the room. She tries the carving again. Cold. She tells herself the difference is in her, that a fingertip is a poor thermometer, that she's been down here twenty minutes in a basement and her hands have given up their heat unevenly the way hands do. It's a good explanation. It doesn't quite cover the part where she keeps her hand off the wall after that.

She takes out her phone and takes pictures of several of them.

She doesn't know why she takes the pictures. She just does.

On a shelf above the workbench, lined up with a precision that is out of keeping with the rest of the basement's organized clutter: forty-six leather-bound notebooks. She counts them without meaning to. The spines are unmarked. They're all the same size, the same worn brown leather, as though he bought them in bulk or made them himself. The one on the far right end looks newer than the others, the leather less cracked.

She reaches for it.

She stops.

She doesn't know why she stops. The notebooks are her father's and her father is dead and she is his heir and there is no reason she cannot open one. She picks up the newest one and opens it to the last entry.

January 8, it says at the top. Three days before he died.

Cold snap holding. Ice at 24 inches on the north end, softer toward the inlet. Quiet last night, quiet this morning.

She came up around 2 but did not knock. Stayed below. I sat until four. Went back to the house.

Tired.

She reads it again.

She reads it a third time.

She came up around 2 but did not knock. The basement is cold. It was cold when she came down and she hadn't thought anything of it, basements are cold, but she's aware of it now, a flat even cold with no edge to it, and her breath is going out of her in a thin visible thread that hangs there longer than breath should before it lets go. She's holding the notebook with both hands. She makes herself notice that — both hands, the way you hold a thing you've decided not to drop — and she sets one hand flat on the workbench instead, on the wood, which is the same temperature as everything else down here and tells her nothing. *She.* Not a name. Not the woman from the bar, not a neighbor, not anyone he'd have written down as anyone. Just *she*, the way you write a thing you don't have to explain to yourself because you already know what it is. *Stayed below.* Aino's heart is going faster than the moment calls for and she stands there and lets it, because there is nothing in this entry, nothing at all, an old man's ice measurements and a note that he was tired three days before he died of being seventy-seven in his kitchen, and her body has read it as something else and gotten there ahead of her, the way it got there ahead of her at the bar, the small cold weight settling in beside the one already there.

She closes the notebook and puts it back exactly where it was. She goes upstairs. She sits at the kitchen table for a while without doing anything.

Then she gets up and puts her coat on and goes outside, around the side of the house, down the slope through the

pinetoward the lake.

—

She's not going to the sauna. She just wants to see the lake.

This is what she tells herself, walking down through the snow, the cold finding the gap at her collar, the pines closing overhead. She just wants to see it. She grew up on this lake. She swam in it every summer until she was eighteen. She knows this lake.

The sauna is visible before the lake is — the dark shape of it at the shoreline, built on stones at the water's edge, the lower half extending out over the ice. It's bigger than she remembered. Or she remembered it wrong. It has the look of a thing added to over many years, the roofline not quite consistent, a newer section visible on the east side where the wood is a slightly different color even under the weathering. Her great-grandfather built the first version of it. Her grandfather expanded it. Her father replaced the interior the last summer she was home, and she knows this because she had helped him carry cedar planks down the hill before everything went wrong.

She stops at the tree line. She does not go to the sauna.

The lake is frozen solid, or looks it — flat white stretching out to the far shore, the pines on the other side a dark line against the pale sky. A couple of fish houses are visible in the middle distance, other people's, small dark rectangles on the white. The ice is quiet. No cracking, no groaning, just the wind moving across the surface and lifting a fine spray of snow.

The wind is at her back. It comes down the slope behind her, through the pines, and it should carry out across the lake and away, the way wind does over open ice, and it doesn't. It

dies at the shoreline. She can feel it pushing at her shoulders and she can see, twenty feet out, where it stops — the snow lifting and turning and settling, lifting and settling, going nowhere, as though the wind has reached the edge of something and can go no further onto it. The far shore is a mile off and perfectly still. Nothing moves out there. But it isn't the stillness of water frozen and left alone. It's the stillness of a surface that has turned its attention shoreward, that has gone quiet the way a thing goes quiet when it knows it is being looked at and is looking back. She has the clear and stupid sense that if she takes one step down onto the ice the whole white surface of it will know.

She doesn't take the step. She tells herself she doesn't take it because the ice along the shore is rotten this time of year, undercut where the inlet runs, and she has better sense than to test it in city boots with no one knowing where she is. It's a good reason. It's even true. It is not why her feet have stopped where the snow ends.

She stands there for a few minutes. The cold is working its way through her coat now, finding her shoulders, her ears.

There is nothing wrong with the lake. It is a lake in February. It is exactly what a lake in February looks like. She says it to herself in those words, plainly, the way you read a label aloud to settle an argument, and the lake goes on attending to her, patient, the snow lifting and settling at the edge of it, and does not agree.

She goes back to the house.

—

That evening she finds the photograph.

She's been going through the living room more carefully, looking for documents her father might have filed in random

places — the lawyer had mentioned a deed, an insurance policy, a few things she should locate before Monday. She's found nothing useful, only the usual drawer-junk of a man who lived alone: takeout menus for restaurants in Iron Mountain, a hardware store loyalty card, a pocket knife, batteries of every size, a small spiral notepad with a grocery list in his handwriting that she cannot throw away and so sets on the kitchen counter with the reading glasses.

The photograph is on the wall in the hallway, between the bathroom and the bedroom door. She's walked past it three times without looking at it. She looks at it now.

Three men standing on a frozen lake in front of a sauna. The sauna in the photograph is smaller than the one at the shore, and different — older, cruder, not the same structure at all really, though the placement is the same, the same stones at the water's edge. The men are wearing the heavy work clothes of an earlier time. The photograph is black and white and slightly overexposed and whoever took it was standing on the ice looking toward the shore.

The man on the left is tall and broad-shouldered and looks at the camera with an expression she can't read. The man in the middle is shorter, heavier, and is not looking at the camera at all — he's looking at something to his left, off-frame. The figure on the right is a boy.

She looks closer. Her father. Fourteen years old maybe, slight in his winter coat, his face not yet settled into the one she knew. But her father without question — the jaw, the way he stands, slightly turned as though he was about to walk away when someone called him back for the picture.

The tall man on the left, then. Her grandfather Toivo. And the man in the middle — her great-grandfather Eino, she supposes, though she has never seen a photograph of Eino

and cannot say for certain.

Three generations of Hietala men standing in front of the sauna on the ice. One of them still a boy.

She thinks about the notebook entry. *She came up around 2 but did not knock. Stayed below.*

She thinks about the mallet in the basement, worn smooth by ten thousand uses.

She thinks about Paavo Maki at the bar last night, the sharpness in his eyes. *Stay off the lake.*

She takes the photograph off the wall. She turns it over. On the back, in a handwriting she doesn't recognize, someone has written three names and a date.

Eino. Toivo. Henrik. February 1962.

February 1962. Her grandfather Toivo drowned in that lake four months later, in June of 1962, when her father was fourteen years old.

She hangs the photograph back on the wall exactly as she found it.

She goes to bed early. She lies in the dark under her grandmother's quilt and listens to the house.

The funeral is tomorrow.

She thinks about her father at fourteen, standing on the ice in February, being called back for a picture he didn't particularly want to be in. The way he's turned slightly, like he was already leaving. She knows that posture. She has seen it on herself in photographs her whole adult life and never once thought about where she got it from.

Outside, the lake is quiet. The house is quiet. Eventually, somewhere in the small hours, she sleeps.

CHAPTER 4

The Funeral

The church is on the main street, same as it always was, a white clapboard building with a modest steeple and a parking lot that was full when she was a girl and is half-empty now. She gets there early and sits in the Subaru for a few minutes watching people arrive. Old people, mostly. A few she recognizes and most she doesn't, which makes sense — she left at nineteen and the town has been slowly replacing itself with older versions of itself ever since.

The pastor is young. This surprises her, though it shouldn't. She doesn't know what she expected — the pastor from her childhood was a barrel-chested Norwegian man named Virtanen who had seemed ancient to her at eight years old and is presumably actually ancient now or dead. This pastor is maybe thirty-five, slight, with the careful manner of someone who has learned to move through other people's grief without disturbing it too much. He shakes her hand at the door and tells her he is sorry for her loss and that her father was a faithful member of the congregation. She thanks him. She doesn't ask how well he knew him because she can already tell the answer is not very.

Inside, the church smells the way Lutheran churches smell — wood polish and candle wax and the particular cold of a stone-floored room that never quite warms up no matter how hard the furnace works. The light comes in thin and gray through the plain windows; there is no stained glass here, never was, just clear panes and white walls and a wooden cross at the front, the Finnish Lutheran taste for plainness

that her grandmother used to call honest. She sits in the front pew. The pew is the same hard varnished oak it always was, the seat too shallow and the back too straight, built by people who did not believe comfort was the point. The hymnal in the rack in front of her is the green one, the same green one. Behind her she can hear people settling, the soft percussion of coats and whispers and the cough of an old man two rows back. She is alone in the front pew, which she had not thought about until she is sitting in it — that there is no one to sit beside her, no family left to fill the rest of the bench. She doesn't turn around.

The service is not long. The pastor speaks about her father in the general terms of a man working from notes rather than memory — faithful, hardworking, a member of this community for his entire life. He reads from Psalms. The congregation sings a hymn she knows without having thought about it in twenty years, the words coming back to her the way things come back from somewhere below the place where you stopped looking for them. Her voice comes out thin and she stops after the first verse and just listens to the old people around her sing it the way people sing hymns they have been singing since childhood, with a kind of low, unselfconscious authority.

Her father's casket is closed. This was his preference, per the list he left Gerald. She finds she is glad of it. She is not sure she could have looked at him in there and then stood up and sung a hymn.

She does not cry during the service. She had thought she might, finally, here — that the church and the hymn and the closed casket would be the thing that broke it loose. But she sits through all of it dry-eyed and a little numb and when it's over she stands and shakes the pastor's hand again and

accepts condolences from people whose names she has to read off their expressions rather than actually remember.

Paavo Maki is there, near the back. He catches her eye across the room and nods once and she nods back. He doesn't come over.

—

The reception is in the church basement, the same basement she ate a hundred after-service lunches in as a girl. The stairs down to it are the same stairs, narrow and steep, the handrail worn pale at the turn, and her feet find the spacing of them without consulting her, the way they used to when she came down too fast in patent shoes and her grandmother told her to slow down. The room at the bottom hasn't changed in any way that matters. The long folding tables. The stacking metal chairs that are always slightly cold to sit on. The percolator the size of a small engine on the counter, the same one or its identical twin, breathing its steady industrial gurgle into the room. The low ceiling with the foam tiles and the fluorescent light that makes everyone look like they have been up all night, which some of them have. The smell of coffee and something baked and, under it, the church-basement smell itself, which is its own thing — floor wax and old hymnals and the cool of a foundation that holds the cold the way the percolator in her father's kitchen holds it, the way everything up here seems to hold it.

The women of the congregation have provided, the way they do. There is a sheet cake from the IGA with white frosting and a blue piped border. There are two coffee cakes under foil, and a glass dish of bar cookies, and a crockpot of meatballs plugged in at the end of the table with a hand-lettered card that says SWEDISH propped against it.

And there is a plate of something she doesn't recognize until she gets closer and realizes it is pulla — the Finnish cardamom bread, braided in three strands and brushed with egg and scattered with pearl sugar, golden and split a little along the seams the way it splits when the braid is good. So specific to her grandmother's kitchen, to a particular Sunday smell of it, that she has to look away from it for a moment. When she looks back she takes a piece, because not taking one would be its own kind of statement, and she eats it standing up, and it is exactly right, the cardamom blooming the way it did when she was six, and it undoes her a little more than the hymn did. She doesn't let it show. She wipes the sugar off her fingers with a paper napkin and folds the napkin into a square and keeps it closed in her fist.

She gets coffee in a styrofoam cup and stands near the wall and lets people come to her, which they do, in the patient procession of small-town funerals. The first ones she half-knows. A heavysset man who shakes her hand and says he worked the second shift with Hank at the mine for eleven years, before it closed, and she says thank you and cannot find his name though she's fairly sure she once knew it. A couple her father's age whose faces she has clearly seen at this church a thousand mornings and whose names are simply gone. She has gotten good, over three days, at reading the answer off the face — the way they lead with the name when they know she won't have it, so she can borrow it back from them in the next sentence. She does this several times. She thanks people for coming. She accepts the casseroles that are pressed on her, the foil pans she will not eat and cannot refuse, and stacks them on the end of the table by the meatballs.

Then there are the women. Three or four of them, the old ones, the ones in the good black, who do not so much come to her as gather near her in a loose orbit and watch her with frank, unembarrassed attention. They knew Aili. They say so — *I knew your grandmother*, each of them, like a credential — and they tell her things in the patient declarative way of people who have decided she ought to have them. That Aili made the best pulla in the parish and would never give the recipe straight, always left a step out so yours came out wrong. That she sang alto. That she could clean a fish faster than any man and did it on the back step with a cigarette in her mouth. They tell her she has Aili's eyes. They are kind to her, and they are curious about her, in the way of people who have been watching a situation develop for nineteen years and are finally getting to see how it ends — the daughter who left, come back at last, and only for this. She doesn't begrudge them the curiosity. She's curious herself. She answers their questions about Milwaukee and her work and whether she's staying long with the same short answers she's been giving since she arrived, and they take the shortness for grief, which is generous of them, and not entirely wrong.

She notices the old woman before the old woman comes to her. Has noticed her, in fact, for a while — across the basement, near the coffee table, a small sharp-featured woman in her mid-eighties at least, dressed in the kind of black that suggests she has attended a great many funerals and keeps appropriate clothing ready. She has not joined the orbit of the other women. She has stood a little apart from them with a cup of coffee in one hand and she has been watching Aino steadily, without pretense, the way the others watched but more so, longer, without the courtesy of looking away when Aino's eyes happen across her. The first time their

eyes meet the woman does not nod or smile or do any of the things people do to dissolve a caught look. She simply holds it. Then she lets it go and watches the room and waits, and Aino feels the held look go on sitting on her like a hand laid flat between the shoulder blades, even after it has stopped.

She comes to her last, after most of the others have drifted away in twos and threes, coats on, heading out into the cold. She comes across the basement slowly but without hesitation, the coffee cup steady in her hand, and she is looking at Aino the way people look at something they've been waiting to see for a long time.

She stops in front of her and takes Aino's free hand in both of hers. Her grip is firm.

"Aino," she says.

"Yes," Aino says. "Thank you for coming. I'm sorry, I don't —"

"Helmi Korhonen." The woman says it as though the name should mean something, and it does, distantly — she has a memory of this name, her grandmother saying it, her father saying it once, a long time ago. "I knew your grandmother Aili. We came over the same year, 1956. Different boats." A faint smile. "She was my closest friend for forty years."

"I didn't know that," Aino says. "I'm sorry. She died when I was fifteen."

"I know when she died." Helmi says it without unkindness, just as a fact. She is still holding Aino's hand. "You look like her. Around the eyes."

"People have said that."

Helmi looks at her for a moment with an expression Aino can't quite read — not quite sorrow, not quite relief, something between the two. Then she says, in Finnish: "Sinä tulit takaisin."

Aino understands it without having to translate it. *You came back.*

"Kyllä," she says. *Yes.* The word comes out before she decides to say it, in Finnish before she decides to use Finnish.

Something shifts in Helmi's expression. She glances around the basement — the last few people pulling on coats, the pastor stacking chairs at the far end, nobody within easy earshot. She looks back at Aino and lowers her voice.

"Anna sen mennä," she says. *Let it go.*

Aino waits.

"The sauna. Whatever is in it, whatever he kept in it. Lock the door and leave it. Let it rot. Let the woods take it back in fifty years if they want it." Helmi's grip on her hand tightens slightly. "Your father did enough. His father did enough. It has been enough."

"I don't know what you mean," Aino says, which is not entirely true.

"You will." Helmi releases her hand. She picks up her coffee cup with the deliberateness of a woman who has said what she came to say and is finished. "Your grandmother knew. She never went near it either. That was the right choice." She pauses. "Aili was a smart woman. Smarter than the men she married into."

Aino thinks about the photograph. Her grandfather Toivo on the ice, four months before he drowned. Her grandmother Aili, who knew, who never went near the sauna, who lived another forty years after her husband went into the lake.

"What happened to my grandfather," she says. "Toivo. Was it an accident?"

Helmi looks at her for a long moment.

"He was a good man," she says finally. "He was not a strong one." She sets her coffee cup down on the nearest

table. She picks up her coat from the back of a chair. "Go home, Aino. Sell the house. Leave the sauna locked and let the woods have it eventually. Go back to your life."

She buttons her coat with the careful attention of the very old and walks toward the stairs without looking back.

Aino stands in the emptying basement with her cup of cold coffee and watches her go.

—

She is one of the last to leave. She helps stack the remaining chairs because it gives her something to do with her hands and because the pastor looks tired and grateful when she offers. He asks if she's all right. She says yes. He says her father spoke of her sometimes. She asks what he said. The pastor smiles carefully and says that he was proud of her, that he mentioned her work, that he had a photograph of her on the refrigerator.

She drives home in the blue late-afternoon light. She goes in through the back door and stands in the kitchen and looks at the refrigerator.

There is a photograph on it, held by a magnet from a hardware store in Iron Mountain. A snapshot, slightly faded, the color of photographs from the mid-nineties. A girl of about eight in a swimsuit standing on a dock, squinting into the sun, holding up a fish with both hands and grinning the way children grin when they've done something they're proud of.

The lake is visible behind her. The sauna is at the edge of the frame.

She doesn't remember the day. She doesn't remember the fish. But that's her face, and that's this lake, and her father had this on his refrigerator when he died and apparently for a

long time before that.

She takes it down and sits at the kitchen table and holds it for a while.

Outside the kitchen window the yard is going dark, the pines black against the last light. The snow is still unbroken except for the footprints, which have been there for two days now, and which she has stopped letting herself think about, mostly.

She puts the photograph in her coat pocket.

She makes dinner. She eats it. She washes the dishes and dries them and puts them away. Before she goes to bed she takes the photograph out of her coat pocket and props it against the percolator on the counter, where her father would have seen it every morning.

CHAPTER 5

What He Left Her

The lawyer's office is above the hardware store on the main street, up a narrow staircase that smells like the hardware store below it — machine oil and rubber and something metallic. The nameplate on the door says ERNEST AUTIO, ATTORNEY AT LAW. She knocks and a voice tells her to come in.

Ernest Autio is in his late sixties, compact and careful-looking, with the kind of deliberate stillness that suggests he has spent a long career letting other people fill silences. He has a white mustache and reading glasses pushed up on his forehead and a desk covered in the organized chaos of a man who knows exactly where everything is. He stands when she comes in and shakes her hand and says he is sorry about her father.

"He was a client for thirty years," he says. "And a friend, I think, though he wasn't a man who used that word easily."

"No," she says. "He wasn't."

He gestures to the chair across from his desk and she sits. He opens a folder.

The will is not complicated. The house and land to Aino, free and clear. The savings account — he names a figure, thirty-one thousand and change — to Aino. Personal effects to Aino. A small bequest to the Lutheran church, two hundred dollars, which makes her think of the pastor stacking chairs and feel something she sets aside.

Ernest reads all of this in the measured tone of a man who has read a great many wills and understands that the people

sitting across from him are not really listening to the legal language, they are listening for their name and for the shape of what they're being left. She listens for both.

Then he turns a page.

"There is one additional item," he says. "Your father was specific about how it should be handled, and he asked me to present it separately." He looks at her over his reading glasses. "The sauna and all its contents are left to you, with a condition attached. The estate cannot close — the deed cannot transfer, the accounts cannot be released — until you have, and I'm quoting your father here, *made a decision about the sauna and acted on it*. His language, not mine."

She looks at him. "What does that mean, legally?"

"It means the estate stays open until I'm satisfied the condition has been met. Your father trusted me to use judgment about what constitutes acting on it." Ernest takes his glasses off his forehead and sets them on the desk. "I'll be honest with you, Aino. He came in and revised this will eight months ago. He was very deliberate about this language. I asked him what he meant by it and he said I'd know it when I saw it." A pause. "I've been a lawyer for forty years. I've had stranger instructions."

She thinks about the ledgers in the basement. The forty-six of them, lined up in order.

"There's also an envelope," Ernest says. He opens his desk drawer and produces it — a standard white envelope, sealed, her name written on the front in her father's handwriting. Careful handwriting, the handwriting of a man who did not write often and took it seriously when he did. "He left this with me two years ago. He said to give it to you in person, not to mail it, not to leave it at the house."

She takes the envelope. It's light. Not much inside.

"Do you want a few minutes?" Ernest asks.

"No," she says. "I'll read it at home."

She puts it in her coat pocket, next to the photograph.

Ernest goes through the remaining paperwork — what she needs to sign, what happens next, the timeline for probate. She signs where he indicates. She asks a few questions about the deed and the accounts, the kind of questions her job has taught her to ask, and he answers them precisely and without condescension, which she appreciates.

At the door he shakes her hand again.

"Your father talked about you," he says. "He was proud of you. I want you to know that, since I'm not sure who else would tell you."

She thanks him. She goes down the stairs and out into the February cold.

—

She does not open the envelope right away.

She sits in the Subaru in the parking lot behind the hardware store with the engine running and the heat going and the envelope on the passenger seat where she set it when she got in. The lot is small, gravel and packed snow, a loading dock at the back of the store with a dumpster and a stack of wooden pallets going gray under a tarp. A man in a Carhartt coat carries a length of pipe out to a truck and goes back in. The light is the flat midday light of February up here, no shadows in it, the kind of light that makes everything look like a photograph of itself.

She turns the heat down a notch. She checks the gas gauge, which is fine. She watches the man come out again with another length of pipe and load it and drive away. She tells herself she is letting the car warm up, which is not true;

it is warm. She tells herself she will read it at home, which is what she told Ernest, and then she does not put the car in gear.

Her hands are on the wheel. They are her mother's hands, people used to say, though she has no memory of her mother's hands to check it against. The knuckles are a little chapped from the cold. There is a paper cut on the side of one thumb from the probate forms that she had not noticed until now.

The envelope is light. She knew that already, standing in the office. Light enough that there is almost nothing in it, which is somehow worse than if it had been thick, because a thick envelope is a man explaining himself and a thin one is a man who has decided exactly how much he is going to say.

She picks it up. She holds it for a while longer. Then she works a finger under the flap and opens it.

Inside: a key, small and old, the kind that fits a padlock rather than a door. A folded piece of paper, which is a hand-drawn map of Lake Kivijärvi and the surrounding property, her father's land marked with a simple rectangle for the house and a smaller shape at the shoreline for the sauna. An X on the lake, maybe thirty feet out from the sauna — she can't tell if it marks something on the surface or something below it.

And a note. One page, in his handwriting.

Aino —

I am sorry I did not tell you this myself. I tried several times. I could not find the words and then I ran out of time, which is what happens when you wait too long for the right moment.

The key is for the lockbox under the bench in the sauna. You will need the small crowbar in the basement workshop,

third peg from the left, to get the bench up. Inside the lockbox is what you need to understand what I have been doing and what my father did before me and his father before him.

Sit in the sauna for a while before you open the floor. Light the stove. Let it get warm. I know this sounds strange. It matters.

Watch the water through the opening when you do open it. Do not put your hand in. Do not lean over it. Watch, and wait, and you will understand.

I am sorry about the summer you were nineteen. I was afraid for you and I handled it wrong. I have thought about it many times.

The thing in the water is not evil. I need you to know that. It is something that was wronged a long time ago by people in our family and it has been waiting a long time for someone to do something other than watch it. I did not know what to do. Maybe you will.

I love you. I should have said so more.

Dad

She reads it twice. She folds it carefully and puts it back in the envelope with the key and the map. She sits in the parking lot with the envelope in her lap.

The thing in the water is not evil.

She thinks about the lake at age seven.

She was lying on her stomach on the end of the dock with her arm in the water to the elbow, the way you do at that age, trailing your fingers and watching the light come apart around them. The water was cold the way it is even in July up here, cold a few inches down. She remembers the boards warm against her belly and the cold of the water and the smell of the lake, which is its own smell, weed and stone and something underneath that. And she remembers the hand.

Coming up through the green toward hers. Pale, and slower than a hand should move, and reaching, the fingers spread.

She did not have time to be afraid of it. That came later. What came first was her father.

She did not hear him on the hill. She heard him when he was already most of the way down it, the heavy fast crash of a grown man running on uneven ground, and then he had her — not gently, not the way he picked her up other times, but by the back of the swimsuit and one arm, hard enough that it left marks, hauling her up and back off the dock so fast her chin caught the board and her teeth came together on her tongue and she tasted blood. He held her against him with his heart going like something trying to get out. She could feel it through his shirt. He was looking at the water. Not at her, at the water, at the exact place her hand had been, and his face was a face she had never seen on him, before or after, the face of a man looking at a thing he already knew was there.

Just a reflection, he said, after. *Just the light. There's nothing in the lake, Aino.* And his voice was steady when he said it, which is how she knew, even at seven, that it was not true, because his voice was steady and his hands were not.

She believed him anyway. For thirty years she believed him.

She starts the Subaru. She drives back to the house.

She does not go to the sauna that afternoon. She makes coffee and sits at the kitchen table and looks at the photograph of herself on the dock, eight years old and squinting and holding up the fish, the lake behind her and the sauna at the edge of the frame, and she thinks about how fast he came down that hill.

He had not gone looking. He had known where to look.

CHAPTER 6

Night Two

She doesn't go to the sauna that day, or the next.

She tells herself she is being practical. There are things to do — the house to go through, decisions to make about furniture and clothes and the accumulated objects of a life lived in one place for forty years. She fills three garbage bags with things that are simply garbage, worn-out things, expired things, things with no use and no meaning. She fills two boxes with things she thinks might matter — old photographs, her father's watch, a hand-carved wooden box she finds in the bedroom closet that she can't bring herself to open yet.

She calls her office. She extends her leave through the end of the month. Her supervisor says of course, take the time you need, and she can hear in his voice both genuine sympathy and the faint stress of a man recalculating his caseload.

She calls her mother in Phoenix. Lila answers on the second ring, which means she was expecting the call or dreading it, probably both. They talk for twenty minutes in the way they always talk — on the surface of things, in the register of logistics and weather and how are you doing, fine. Lila says she's sorry about Hank. She says it the way she says most things about Aino's father, with a care that suggests she is aware of how many ways she could say it wrong. Aino tells her the funeral was small but good. Tells her about the church, the pulla in the basement, the pastor who didn't know him well. She does not tell her about Helmi Korhonen or the envelope or the note.

At the end of the call Lila says: "Are you all right up there? Alone?"

"I'm fine," Aino says. "It's quiet."

"It was always quiet," her mother says, and something in her voice when she says it makes Aino want to ask a question she doesn't know how to form yet. But Lila has already moved on, asking about the drive back, when she's thinking of leaving, and the moment closes.

She cooks. She reads one of the paperback westerns from her father's shelf, which is not very good but requires nothing from her. She goes to bed at a reasonable hour and lies in the dark and listens.

The sound comes back on the third night.

—

She's been asleep — actually asleep, deeper than she's managed since she arrived — when it pulls her up. The same sound as before, rhythmic and faint, coming from the direction of the lake. She lies still and listens and it goes on longer this time, five minutes maybe, before it stops.

She does not get up. She tells herself there is nothing to get up for. The quilt is warm. The room is cold the way the room is always cold, the furnace cycling on and off below her, and she lies under her grandmother's stitching and stares at the ceiling she stared at as a child and waits for sleep to come back.

It does, a little. She surfaces again sometime later — she doesn't reach for her phone to check, doesn't want the number — and lies there listening to nothing, to the house, to the small settling sounds it makes that mean nothing, that she has spent a week learning to tell from the sounds that mean something. There is a difference. She knows that now in

a way she didn't a week ago, and she is not sure when she learned it.

The third time she comes up the sound is going again. She lies still through all of it this time. She counts the way she counted in the car, the count starting on its own the way it did on the highway, except that this time it does not resolve — she loses it somewhere past a hundred, and it is still going when she gives up, and then it stops between one breath and the next, the way it stopped before, like a thing that has decided it is done rather than a thing that has run out.

She gets up. She gets up the way you get up when you have already lost the argument with yourself, knowing she will not sleep until she has looked, knowing also that looking has not once made anything better. She crosses the cold floor in her socks. She does not turn on a light.

She goes to the kitchen window.

The yard is darker tonight — clouds over the moon, the snow a flat gray rather than the bright blue-white of the first night. The footprints are still there, the original ones, more than a week old now and softened by a light snowfall two days ago, the edges gone blurry. Around them, fresh ones.

She leans closer to the glass.

The fresh prints don't follow the same path as the old ones. These come from a different direction — not from the tree line at the back of the property but from the side, from the slope that leads down toward the lake. Single file, same size as before. They cross the yard at an angle and go to the back porch and stop. Or they almost stop. She follows them with her eyes and sees that one more print continues past the porch — just one, pressed into the snow right at the edge of the porch steps, pointed toward the back door.

Pointed toward where she is standing.

She steps back from the window. She is aware of her own breathing.

She stands in the dark kitchen for a long time. The house is completely still. Whatever made those prints is not on the porch now — there's no sound, no movement, the door is locked. She checked the locks before bed. She checks them every night.

After a while she turns on the kitchen light. The yard looks ordinary under the artificial light, just snow and trees and the dark beyond. She fills a glass of water at the sink and drinks it standing up and tells herself to think clearly.

The prints are small. No animal she can think of makes prints that shape and that size. She'd gotten her phone and looked it up two nights ago — she'd spent an hour going through every animal in the U.P., comparing paw prints and hoof prints and claw marks, and nothing matched. She had put the phone away and not looked it up again.

She goes back to bed. She does not sleep.

In the morning she gets up early and goes outside before she loses her nerve. She does not bother with coffee first. She pulls on her coat and her boots over bare feet and opens the back door and the cold comes in at her like a hand on the chest.

She has forgotten her gloves. She is halfway across the porch before she registers it, her hands already aching at the knuckles, and she does not go back for them. Going back is its own kind of admitting.

She crouches beside the fresh prints. The snow gives under her knee, slow and then all at once, the crust breaking and her knee sinking until the cold of it soaks through the denim and into the bone. She doesn't shift off it. The early light is flat and gray across the yard, no shadows in it, the

kind of light that comes at every hour up here in winter, and it does the prints no favors and tells her no lies.

She looks at them closely. She has looked at them from the window, from above, from inside, and it is not the same as this, down at their level with her bare hand a few inches from the nearest one and the cold coming up off the snow into her face. There is no claw at the front. No splay, no dewclaw, no drag of a tail or a heel. No fur has touched the edges. The print is small and the print is deliberate and it presses straight down and lifts straight up, the way a thing steps when it has somewhere to be and means to get there. She holds her hand over it, not into it, the way her father wrote *do not put your hand in* about a thing he meant something else by entirely, and her hand is bigger than the print and that is somehow the worst of it.

They are not an animal's. She knew this but she needed to see it again in daylight, down close, with the cold in her knee and her hands going stiff, where she could not tell herself it was the window or the dark or the angle.

She straightens up. Her knee is wet and her hands won't quite close. She looks at the slope down toward the lake, the direction the prints came from. The birches along the slope are bare. The pines beyond are still. Nothing moves, and nothing has moved, and the not-moving is exactly what it was the first night and the night her father came down that same slope at a dead run.

She goes back inside and makes coffee and stands at the counter next to the percolator and looks at the photograph of herself at eight years old. She drinks the coffee with both hands around the mug because her hands are still cold, the warmth of it going into her palms before it goes anywhere else.

The envelope is on the kitchen table. It has been on the kitchen table for the better part of a week, since the parking lot behind the hardware store, since she read the note twice and folded it and told herself she would deal with it. She has eaten three meals a day at that table with the envelope a foot from her plate. She has moved it once, to wipe the table, and set it back. She has not opened it again.

She sits down across from it. She does not pick it up yet.

She could leave. That is the thing she lets herself think, sitting there with the coffee going cold. She could fill the rest of the boxes and load the Subaru and lock the house and drive south, and the estate would stay open and Ernest Autio would wait, and her father's condition would go unmet, and some lawyer years from now would do whatever lawyers do with a house no one came back for. She could be in Tamarack by noon and out of the U.P. by dark and home — the apartment, the radiator, the dog commercials — by the time the sound started again tonight for someone who was no longer here to hear it. No one would make her stay. The prints would go on being made in a yard no one was standing at the window of.

She thinks about how fast he came down that hill.

That is the weight, the one that has been settling in low in her chest since the parking lot, beside the older one she carried up here, the small cold one that is not grief and is not fear and is the thing that comes when you understand that a door has been left open specifically for you and that closing it is also a choice you will have to live with. He left it open on purpose. He waited two years to hand her the envelope and eight months to write the condition into the will and forty-six ledgers' worth of his life arranging the matter so that she would have to decide, and the cruelty of it and the trust of it are the same thing and she cannot get them apart.

She reaches across the table and picks up the envelope. It is still light. She works a finger under the flap, though the flap is already open, and takes out the key — small and old, for a padlock and not a door — and leaves the map and the note inside. She does not need the map. She knows where the sauna is. She has known where the sauna is her whole life.

She puts on her coat.

She goes to the sauna.

CHAPTER 7

The Sauna

The path down to the lake is through the birches first and then the pines, a slope of maybe a hundred feet, and someone — her father, presumably, over many years — has kept it clear enough to walk. The snow is packed down in a rough trail between the trees. She follows it.

The sauna comes into view before the lake does. She'd seen it from the tree line over a week ago and turned back. Up close it's different. Larger than she'd registered from a distance, the structure extending out over the frozen surface of the lake on heavy timber pilings, the lower walls dark with age and moisture, the upper walls newer, the cedar her father put in the last summer she was home, weathered now but still holding its color. Three distinct sections visible from outside — the changing room, the washing room, the sauna proper — each addition a slightly different vintage of construction, the roofline stepping up and back like something grown rather than built.

The door to the changing room faces the shore. There is a hasp on it with a padlock.

She fits the key. The padlock opens.

Inside, the changing room is small — bench along one wall, hooks above it, a wooden mat on the floor. A pair of her father's rubber-soled sandals are under the bench, the kind you wear in a sauna, worn down at the heel. She leaves them where they are. On the hooks: a towel that has been there long enough to go stiff, a canvas bag she doesn't look inside, a birch whisk bundle so dry it crumbles when she touches it.

The door to the washing room. The door to the sauna proper.

She opens that one last.

The heat is gone, obviously — hasn't been a fire in the stove since before her father died, two weeks now, and the temperature in here is the same as outside, ten degrees maybe, the cold dense and close in the small space. The stove is in the corner, a cast-iron kiuas packed with stones on top, the firebox below. Beside it a metal bucket and a long-handled ladle for the löyly. On the shelf above the stove: a clay pot, a small glass bottle with something dark in it, a folded piece of cloth. Against the opposite wall the lauteet, the tiered bench platform, two levels, the lower level where you sit at lower heat and the upper where it gets serious.

She looks at it all. She looks at the walls.

The carvings are here too, the same as in the basement — marks cut into the wood of the wall studs, into the frame around the door, into the underside of the upper bench. More of them than in the basement. Some she recognizes from her photographs of the basement walls and some she doesn't. They cover every surface at a certain height, a line of them running around the room like a border, and below that line the walls are plain and above that line they are plain, just that one band of marks all the way around.

Her father's handwriting in the ledger: *Sat until four. Went back to the house.*

She looks at the kiuas.

Her father's note: *Light the stove. Let it get warm. I know this sounds strange. It matters.*

She looks around for wood. There's a box beside the stove, she'd missed it in the dimness — a wooden crate, and in it birch logs split to the right size, dry and ready, as though her

father had prepared them in advance. Which he had, she realizes. He had stocked the wood before he died. He'd known someone would be coming in here after him.

She kneels and opens the firebox. She builds a fire the way her father taught her when she was six — paper at the bottom, kindling crossed over it, the first log on last, not too tight. She has matches in her coat pocket. She lights it.

She sits on the lower bench with her coat on and waits for it to take.

—

It takes a long time for the sauna to warm, as it always does — you can't hurry a kiuas, her father used to say, it heats at its own pace and if you try to rush it you'll crack the stones. She sits on the bench and watches the fire through the small vent in the firebox door and listens to the wood shift and catch. The cold retreats slowly. After half an hour she can feel the heat beginning to build in the stones above the firebox, a dry radiant warmth that is different from any other heat she knows.

She takes her coat off.

She has not been in a sauna in twenty years. She'd forgotten what it does to your body, the particular permission of it — the way the heat insists on your attention, pulls you out of your head and into your skin. She sits on the lower bench and breathes the smell of hot cedar and old wood and something underneath that, something mineral, and she watches the steam begin to rise from the stones when she ladles water over them, the löyly filling the upper half of the room and making the carved marks on the walls briefly visible and then obscuring them.

She moves to the upper bench. It's hot up here. She can feel it on her scalp, the back of her hands, the tops of her ears. She sits with it.

She thinks about her father sitting here. Not once but hundreds of times, thousands maybe, over sixty years of coming down to this sauna and lighting the stove and sitting in exactly this heat. What he thought about. Whether he prayed. Whether it got easier or harder with time.

She thinks about the note. *The thing in the water is not evil.*

She thinks about Helmi Korhonen. *He was a good man. He was not a strong one.*

After a while she climbs down from the upper bench and kneels in front of the lower one. She runs her hand along the underside of the platform. The wood is smooth and dry from decades of heat. She finds the edge — a seam, not obvious, cut with precision so it blends with the plank lines — and follows it with her fingers. A rectangular section, maybe two feet by three, set into the floor of the bench platform.

She goes out to the changing room and digs in the canvas bag she didn't look in earlier. Inside: the small crowbar her father mentioned in his note.

She comes back in. She works the crowbar into the seam. The section lifts.

Below it: the lockbox, a heavy metal box bolted to the framing of the platform, a combination lock on the hasp. She stares at it for a moment. He hadn't mentioned a combination.

She tries his birthday. Nothing. She tries her birthday. Nothing. She tries her grandfather Toivo's, the date she knows the way you know the birthdays of the drowned, and the lock holds. She sits back on her heels. Then she tries her

grandmother Aili's birthday, which she knows because it was two days before her own and they used to share a cake when she was small.

The lock opens.

Inside the lockbox: a notebook, older than the ones on the shelf in the basement, the leather dark and dry. And underneath it, wrapped in cloth, a key she doesn't recognize, larger than the one she used on the padlock, heavy, the kind of key that belongs to something she hasn't found yet.

She takes the notebook. She leaves the key for now.

She replaces the section of bench and stands up and goes to the hatch.

She knows the hatch is there — her father's note had told her, *don't open the floor* — but she doesn't know exactly where until she finds the rope handle set flush into the floor planks near the far wall, directly over the water. She stands over it for a moment.

She opens it.

The cold comes up immediately, a breath of it, the air from below the sauna where it extends over the lake. Through the opening she can see the ice — the sauna sits close enough to the surface that the ice is only a few feet below, pale gray in the dim light filtering through the gaps in the pilings.

She watches it. She waits.

For a long time nothing happens. The fire ticks in the kiuas. The steam drifts. She sits cross-legged on the floor beside the hatch and watches the ice through the opening and thinks about her father doing this same thing, week after week, year after year, and she starts to understand, viscerally, in her body rather than her mind, how long this has gone on. How long the family has been coming down here and sitting in this heat and watching this ice.

Then something moves below the surface.

Not on the ice — below it, in the water under it, a darkening, a shift, the way a cloud shadow moves across a field. She watches it. It is not a fish. It is not a current. It moves with a kind of deliberateness that she can feel rather than see, and she feels it in her chest before she fully processes it with her eyes, a pressure, a presence, something that knows she is here.

She does not put her hand in. She does not lean over.

She watches.

After a moment — she cannot say how long, time moves strangely in the heat — the darkness recedes. The ice is just ice again, pale and still. Nothing moves.

She closes the hatch.

She sits back on the lower bench with the old notebook in her lap and her heart going hard in her chest and the kiuas ticking down around her, and she thinks: *so that is what he was watching*.

She does not get up right away. The fire is past its height now and settling, the logs gone to a low orange seam in the firebox, and the heat in the stones is the long even kind that comes after the flames are done, the kind that will hold for another hour and then let go all at once. She sits in it. She lets the löyly thin out and does not ladle more. The carved marks come back out of the steam as the air clears, the band of them running level around the room, and she does not look at them either.

What she thinks about is small. She does not try to think about the thing in the water, which is past her, which her mind keeps sliding off of the way a hand slides off ice. She thinks instead about the number of times she has been told, by people who meant it kindly, that her father was a private

man. That he kept to himself. That whatever he did down at the lake was his own business and harmed no one. She had let herself believe it the way you believe a thing you have not tested, and the believing had cost her nothing, and now it has cost her everything it was holding back.

She breathes the hot cedar and the mineral smell under it. Her body has changed in the last hour and she can locate the change without naming it: she will not, after this, be able to stand at the kitchen window at night and tell herself the prints are an animal's. The lie is gone the way a tooth is gone, a smooth socket where it was, the tongue going back to it. She is not afraid, exactly, sitting here. Fear would be easier. What she has instead is the flat certainty of someone who has read the bottom line of a page and cannot unread it, and the heat works on her the way it must have worked on him, ten thousand times, holding the body still while the rest of it caught up.

When the seam in the firebox has gone from orange to a dull red she stands. Her legs are unsteady from the heat and she waits for them. Then she banks the stove, closes the firebox vent, puts her coat back on over a body that is still warm and will be cold by the top of the hill, and walks back up to the house with the notebook under her arm.

She almost doesn't look back at the lake.

She does.

CHAPTER 8

The Ledgers

The notebook from the lockbox is not her father's.

She can tell before she opens it — the leather is a different color, a darker brown, and older, dried out in the way of things that have been kept in a cold place for a long time. When she opens the cover she finds the handwriting inside is not her father's either. Smaller, more careful, the handwriting of someone for whom writing in English was a learned rather than a native act. The ink has faded to a pale brown.

At the top of the first page, a date: *October 14, 1919.*

She sits at the kitchen table with a fresh cup of coffee and reads.

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The notebook is Eino's.

It doesn't read the way she expected — she had imagined, if she'd imagined anything, something like confession, something like explanation. But Eino does not explain himself. He records. The same terse daily-entry style as her father's ledgers, the same attention to weather and temperature and what the lake is doing, but underneath that a different kind of entry, one that appears without warning and then disappears again for days or weeks at a time.

October 14. First snow. Ice forming at the inlet. The woman's cabin is gone. I have moved the stones.

She reads that entry three times. The woman's cabin is gone. She thinks about what Helmi told her — or didn't tell her, what Helmi refused to say. She thinks about what Ernest

Autio's folder contained and what it didn't contain.

She keeps reading.

October 29. Ice at four inches on the north end. She has not been still. Risto says the same. I have begun the foundation.

November 3. She came up last night for the first time. I sat with the stove until morning. She did not come through.

November 17. The sauna is framed. I told Aino it is for the family. She looked at me for a long time and did not speak.

The first Aino. Her great-grandmother. She looked at him for a long time and did not speak, and he wrote it down, and kept building.

She closes the notebook. She keeps one hand flat on the cover, the way you keep a hand on a thing you might have to deal with again, and she becomes aware that her hands are cold. The kitchen is not cold. The furnace is running; she can hear it. But her fingers have gone stiff around the leather and there is the coffee, the fresh cup she'd poured to read by, and when she lifts it to drink it is cold too, a skin already forming on it, and she does not remember letting it go that long. She does not know how long she has been sitting here. The light through the window has moved.

In the quiet she can hear the house. The furnace, the tick of the baseboard heat, the refrigerator cycling — and under all of it, faintly, a sound she had not noticed until now, a settling somewhere below, a single small knock of wood against wood that could be the house adjusting to the cold or could be nothing or could be the floor over the basement. She holds still and waits to hear it again. It does not come again. She tells herself it is the house and does not believe herself.

These are not strangers in this book. The careful hand, the stones moved, the woman's cabin gone. The man who built a

sauna over it and told his wife it was for the family. They are hers. She has his jaw, her father had his jaw, it is in the photograph in the hall. The thing the book is recording, page by terrible page in a man's even bookkeeping, is what her family did and went on doing, and she is holding it in two cold hands in her father's kitchen.

She opens it again.

The entries go on through the winter of 1919 and into 1920, the same pattern — weather, ice depth, and then occasionally the other kind of entry, the ones that don't sound like a man talking about ice. *She was restless last night. Three times she came up, three times I sat with it. The names again — she knows them all. And later: Risto's boy saw something at the inlet. We told him it was a beaver. He is seven. He believed us.*

Risto's boy. The Mäkinen line, the male side of it gone by 1947 according to what they knew. A seven-year-old boy in 1920 who saw something at the inlet and was told it was a beaver.

She reads through the winter and into the spring of 1920, and in April there is an entry that stops her:

April 9. The ice is gone. She is more free now. I do not sleep well. Pastor came on Sunday and I wanted to tell him and I did not. There is no telling this to a pastor. There is no telling it to anyone. We have done what we have done and it cannot be undone and the only thing is to watch.

She reads it again. *We have done what we have done.*

He knew. Of course he knew. He had always known exactly what he'd done and he had decided, in the autumn of 1919, that the only available response was to build something over it and watch it for the rest of his life. And his son after him. And his grandson after him.

She goes to the basement and gets the second-oldest ledger from the shelf — her grandfather Toivo's, beginning in 1948, the year her father was born. She takes it upstairs and reads it alongside Eino's notebook, the two of them making a kind of call and response across thirty years: Eino's careful faded entries and Toivo's larger, more hurried handwriting, a man who had grown up knowing about this and had been handed the watch like an inheritance he couldn't refuse.

Toivo's early entries are steadier. He'd learned from his father, she can see it — the same records of ice and weather, the same pattern of the other kind of entry. But as the years go on something changes. The handwriting gets less steady. The entries come less regularly and then in clusters, as though he'd been away and was catching up. And then, in the entries from the spring of 1962:

March 3. She has been loud this week. Every night. I am so tired.

March 19. I told Aili I need to go to the sauna again and she looked at me the way she looks at me now, like she is trying to find the man she married under the one I have become.

Aino has been reading without paying close attention to names. She goes back through the earlier pages. In the entries from 1948, 1949, the early years of Toivo's watch, a different name appears — *Eeva*. She'd missed it on the first read. Toivo's first wife. She'd died in 1953, when her father would have been five. Aili had been the second wife, the war bride from Finland who'd come over in 1956 and never gone near the sauna and who had once told Aino — she'd been about twelve — that the lake was not for swimming, in a tone that brooked no follow-up.

She reads on.

April 14. I have been thinking. There must be another way. The watching is not enough. Eino watched his whole life and it did not change anything. I have watched and it does not change anything. She is there. She is always there. We put her there and watching her does not undo that.

May 20. I have been to see the pastor. I asked him — carefully, without saying what I was asking — whether a wrong done cannot be undone, only watched. He gave me the answer I expected, about forgiveness and grace and the mercy of God. I did not find it useful.

June 1. Hank turned fourteen last month. He is a good boy. He does not know yet. I have been thinking about whether to tell him. I have been thinking that perhaps if I tell him there is another way — if we could find another way — he would not have to carry this.

That is the last entry. The notebook ends there, in the middle of a page, June 1st 1962. The rest of the page is blank. The rest of Toivo's pages are blank.

But Eino's notebook is not finished. She had stopped reading it at the spring of 1920, the entry that stopped her, and gone to the basement for Toivo's; she had read the two of them side by side after that and let Eino's lie open and forgotten under her elbow. She picks it up again now and turns to the back, to see how it ends, because Eino lived a long time — he died old, in his sleep, late that same year, an old man of eighty-two — and the careful faded hand goes on, thinner and shakier in the later pages but the same hand, the same weather and ice and the other kind of entry, all the way to the end.

She finds it near the back. The date is in June. The ink is darker than the pages around it, pressed harder into the paper, the only place in the whole notebook where the old

man's hand is not even.

June 22. They have brought my son up out of the water. He went out two days ago on the morning ice at the inlet, where it had not yet gone. He took no rod. He took the boat to the open water and then he left the boat and walked out onto the ice that was left and it would not hold a man and he knew it would not hold a man, he had walked that ice every spring for thirty years and knew to the inch what it would do. The sheriff has called it an accident. A man checks the ice in June and the ice gives way. I have signed the paper that says so. Aili does not believe it and I do not contradict her and I do not agree with her. He had said to me a week before that the watching was not enough and there must be another way and I told him there is no other way, there is only the watching, and he looked at me the way Aino looked at me in the autumn of 1919 and did not speak. I do not know what was in his mind on the ice. I do not think he knew. A man can walk out onto rotten ice meaning to test it and meaning the other thing both at once and not be able to say which, and then it does not matter what he meant. She was loud the night he died. She is quiet now. The boy is fourteen. He does not know yet. I am too old for this and there is no one else.

She reads it twice. She sets the notebook down very flat on the table.

She sits at the kitchen table for a long time with both notebooks in front of her. Outside the window the light is changing — late afternoon, the sky going gold and orange through the pines, the snow on the yard turning pink.

Her grandfather had been trying to find another way. He'd gone to a pastor who hadn't understood the question. He'd gone to his own father and been told there was no other way.

And then on a June morning he had taken the boat out and left it and walked out onto ice he knew to the inch, and whatever was in his mind out there, his father had not been able to name it and neither could she.

She picks up her father's newest ledger, the one she'd read in the basement the first day. She finds the entry from the summer she was nineteen. She'd known it would be there. She reads it now knowing what she knows:

July 12. A. [Aino] found one of the early books today. I took it from her. I handled it badly. She left. I don't know if she will come back.

July 13. She didn't come back.

July 14. She is gone. I sat in the sauna all night. She was very loud.

She. Her father had gone to the sauna the night Aino left. Had sat there alone. Had done his watching in the worst night of his life.

Aino closes the notebooks. She stacks them carefully on the table. She gets up and goes to the window and stands there for a while watching the light go out of the sky.

Then she picks up her phone.

It is an absurd object to be holding in this kitchen. The notebooks on the table go back to 1919, leather and faded ink and a hand that learned English the hard way, and she is standing over them with a slab of glass that connects, when it feels like it, to everything. The bars in the corner of the screen come and go. She has to stand by the window to keep them.

She doesn't know how to search for what she wants. There is no clean way to type it. She tries the name of the lake, the county, the word *Ojibwe*, the word *removed*, and reads her way down through real estate listings and a historical society page and a PDF of a county plat map until she has, slowly, the

outline of it — the band, the dates, the ground that this lake sits on the edge of and used to sit deeper inside of. She finds the name of the band itself and writes it on the back of her father's envelope: Tamarack Lake Band of Lake Superior Ojibwe. Then she finds the tribal offices, and a phone number, and a page of names and titles, and she reads the names until one of them is a person whose work might plausibly have anything to do with a wrong done on this lake in 1919, and she writes that name down too.

It feels like nothing. It feels like the strangest thing she has done since she got here, stranger than the cold wood, stranger than the sauna — this, standing in her dead father's kitchen at dusk with a phone in her hand, looking up the people her great-grandfather wrote about as *she* and the names and *the stones*, as though the answer to a hundred years of it were a number she could call during business hours.

She doesn't call tonight. It is too late in the day and she is not ready. But she has the name, and tomorrow she will be.

She makes dinner. She sits at the table with the notebooks and her father's ledgers spread around her like a flood. She eats without tasting much.

After dinner she carries the ledgers back down to the basement — Toivo's four, her father's forty-two — and sets them on the shelf in order, exactly as she found them. Eino's notebook she does not put with them. It never lived on that shelf; it lived in the locked box under the sauna bench, behind a combination that only the dead knew until last week, and that is where it belongs, and where — when she can make herself go back down to the cold and the dark of that room — she will return it. For tonight she leaves it on the kitchen table, squared to the edge, under the lamp.

She goes back upstairs. She washes her hands at the kitchen sink.

She looks at the photograph on the counter, herself at eight with the fish and the lake behind her.

She had been happy that day. She is almost certain of it.

CHAPTER 9

Old Boyfriend

She goes to the gas station in the morning for coffee because the percolator is doing something wrong — not broken, just off, the coffee coming out thin and pale, which might be the grind or the water or something she's doing differently from her father — and she is standing at the counter waiting for the attendant to ring her up when someone says her name.

She turns. A man about her age, maybe a year or two older, coming in from outside with the cold still on him. Tall, broad through the shoulders, wearing a canvas work jacket and boots that have actually been worked in. Dark blond hair going gray at the sides, a face she knows.

"Mikko," she says.

Mikko Aaltonen. She has not thought about him in years. She has thought about him occasionally, in the way you think about people who were important to you at seventeen and whom you've reduced, over time, to a single representative image: in his case the front seat of a truck, winter, the heater running, a conversation she can no longer reconstruct but remembers the feeling of. Important, at the time. She'd left and he hadn't and that had been that.

"I heard you were in town," he says. He looks at her with the careful expression of a man who has rehearsed this moment. "I'm sorry about your dad."

"Thank you. He was — " she stops. "He was good to you, I think? You two stayed close?"

"He hired my crew a few times over the years. Siding, a few years back. Roof repairs." He takes a cup from the coffee

station, fills it. He doesn't look at her while he does this. "He talked about you."

"Everyone keeps saying that."

"Then it's probably true." He looks at her now. Something in his face that she can't read, or isn't trying hard enough to read. "I was going to head over to the diner for breakfast if you want to —"

"Yeah," she says. "I do."

—

The diner is warm and smells like bacon and the particular coffee of a place that has been making it the same way since 1974. They take a booth by the window. The waitress knows Mikko and looks at Aino with the frank curiosity of someone who has been briefed. Aino orders eggs and toast and is aware that this will be talked about before she reaches the end of the block.

They talk about easy things first, the way people do who have history and are being careful with it. She asks about his business. He runs a small construction outfit, he and two other guys, mostly residential work around the range. He asks about Milwaukee. She tells him about the job, the apartment, the outline of a life that sounds, as she describes it, more provisional than she'd thought of it.

The waitress brings the eggs and Mikko's coffee gets refilled without his asking. There is a silence then, not uncomfortable, that goes on a beat longer than a silence between strangers would. He turns his cup a quarter turn on the table.

"You look good," he says. "I'd have known you anywhere."

"You too." It's true. He has weathered the way the men up here weather, into something that looks like the country they

live in. "You married a Niemi girl. Somebody told me. Years ago."

"Laura. We're divorced." He says it plainly, no weight on it. "Eight years now. She's in Marquette. It was — " He stops, and she watches him decide not to finish the sentence, watches him fold it back up. "What about you."

"Divorced too. No kids." She drinks her coffee. "We're a pair."

He smiles at that, briefly. Then the smile goes and something more careful comes in behind it, and she knows, the way you know weather coming, that they are both standing at the edge of the same thing. The truck. The winter. The year she was nineteen and got in her car and he didn't ask her not to and she didn't ask him to come.

"I always figured," he starts, and the sentence has the shape of something he's said to himself before, in the cab of his truck, alone. *I always figured you'd write. I always figured I'd hear.* He doesn't say either one. He looks out the window a moment, then back. "It was a long time ago," he says instead, which is not what he meant, and they both let it be what he said.

She could tell him why she left. She has the words for it now in a way she did not have them at nineteen — about the house and the lake and the thing under it she didn't have a name for then, about a father who took a book out of her hands and made her understand, without saying anything, that there were rooms in him she would never be let into. She could say all of that. She doesn't. It isn't his to carry, and anyway the leaving had only ever been half about him, and the half it was about him she doesn't trust herself to get right across a diner table at eight in the morning.

"It was," she agrees. A long time ago.

"You ever think about coming back?" he asks.

"No," she says, without hesitation, and then immediately thinks of the notebooks spread across the kitchen table last night, her grandfather's last entry, *she would not have to carry this*. "I don't know," she says. "Maybe."

He looks at her. "How long are you staying?"

"I'm not sure anymore."

He nods like this is the answer he expected. He wraps both hands around his coffee cup. Outside the window the main street of Kivijärvi is quiet, a pickup truck going past, a woman walking a dog. The ordinary world.

"The sauna," he says, and her attention sharpens.

She waits.

"I saw the smoke yesterday," he says. "From the road. I wasn't going to say anything." He is looking at his coffee. "I knew your dad. Not the way you knew him, but — enough. And I know what the sauna meant."

"What do you know about it?" She keeps her voice even.

He is quiet for a moment. "My grandfather knew your great-grandfather. Did you know that?"

"No."

"Eino and my grandfather were friends. They came over around the same time, same region. Worked the mine together." He pauses. "There are things my grandfather told my father and my father told me. Things you don't — " He stops. He looks out the window. "My grandfather said that what Eino did, that winter, was the worst thing he'd ever seen a man do. And that Eino spent the rest of his life trying to make it right by watching, and that watching wasn't making it right, and that by the time my grandfather understood that it was too late to do anything about it."

She stares at him. "Your grandfather was there."

"No," Mikko says. "He wasn't. But he knew the men who were. He knew what happened." He finally looks at her. "I've known my whole life. Everyone whose grandfather was around in 1919 knows, on some level, though most of them have worked very hard not to. It's a small town. It has always been a small town."

She thinks about Helmi Korhonen in the church basement, glancing around to see who was in earshot before she spoke.

"What happened when you went in?" he asks.

"I saw something in the water." She says it plainly, as a fact, the same way she would report something at work. This is what I observed. "Under the ice. I don't know what it was."

He lets out a breath. "Your father went every week. For thirty years."

"I know. I read the ledgers."

He nods. He looks out the window again. The pickup is long gone. The street is empty.

"What do you want to do?" he asks.

It's the right question, she thinks. Not what should she do, not what does she have to do. What does she want to do. She has not been asked that question since she got here. She has not asked it of herself.

"I don't know yet," she says. That's the honest part, so she starts there. "I keep — " She turns her fork over on the plate. "Three days ago I didn't know any of this existed. Now there are these books in the basement going back a hundred years and a thing in the water and a town full of people who all knew before I did, and I keep waiting to feel like it isn't mine to deal with. And it doesn't go away. It isn't going away. So." She hears herself trailing into nothing and makes herself stop, and sits with it a moment, the diner warm around them,

the smell of bacon, a fork clinking somewhere behind her. What she wants is underneath all of that and she has to go down and get it. "I want to know what they did," she says, slower. "What was actually done. Not the version where it's a sauna and a family that keeps to itself. The real one." She looks at him. "I want to understand what happened in 1919. And I want to talk to someone who knows."

"Someone from the band," he says. Not a question.

"I have a name."

He nods slowly. "They may not want to talk to you."

"I know."

"But if they do — if they're willing —" He picks up his coffee cup. Sets it down again. "Whatever you decide to do about it, I'll help. If you want. That's all I wanted to say."

She looks at him across the table, this man she knew when she was seventeen, who has lived his whole life in the long shadow of something his grandfather knew and never spoke of properly, who is offering now, carefully and without drama, to help.

"Okay," she says.

They finish their breakfast. The conversation finds its way to easier things after that, old names, what became of people, who is still around. She laughs once, genuinely, about something she can't remember the moment after, and it surprises her — the laugh itself, the ease of it. It has been a long week.

Outside on the sidewalk they stand in the cold for a moment.

"Call me," he says. "When you know what you want to do."

She says she will. She watches him walk to his truck. She stands on the sidewalk in the February cold with her hands in her pockets and thinks that she has, without quite deciding

to, found someone in this town who is not trying to talk her into leaving.

She drives back to the house. She finds the name she wrote on the back of her father's envelope.

She calls.

CHAPTER 10

What Comes Up

She goes back to the sauna that evening.

She knows she shouldn't, or knows that every person who has spoken to her since she arrived would say she shouldn't — Paavo at the bar, Helmi in the church basement, Mikko over eggs this morning. Don't go out on the lake. Leave it locked. Don't go to the sauna again. A chorus of it, all saying the same thing in different registers.

But she's read the ledgers now. She knows what her father was doing and she knows what his father was doing before him, and she has started to understand that the watching — the hundred-year watch the Hietala men kept — was not a solution. It was a containment. And containments are not permanent. They require someone to maintain them, and her father is dead, and she is the last Hietala, and the thing in the water has been coming up to the surface every night for two weeks now and making prints in the snow outside the back door.

The watching won't stop it. But she needs to understand it before she can do anything else.

She brings wood down from the porch stack. She lights the kiuas. She sits on the lower bench in her coat while it heats and reads more of Eino's notebook by the light of a headlamp, the early entries, the ones from before the first winter — the way he describes arriving, the land, the lake. He had thought it was beautiful. He had written that word, *kaunis*, beautiful, and underlined it.

She moves to the upper bench when the heat is real.

She has brought a ladle of water and she pours it over the stones and the steam rises and the carved marks on the walls emerge and disappear in the vapor. She sits in the heat and lets it do what it does — pulls her out of her head, insists on her body, makes thought slow and simple. She understands why her father came here. Even with everything she knows about this sauna and what it sits over, there is something about the heat that makes sense, that feels like the right place to think about hard things.

After a while she climbs down from the upper bench. She stands in front of the hatch.

She opens it.

The cold air comes up as before. She settles cross-legged on the floor and looks down through the opening at the ice, pale and still in the dim light.

She waits longer this time. Ten minutes. Twenty. The fire ticks in the stove. The steam thins as the heat from the last löyly dissipates. She is aware of the cold coming up from the hatch in contrast to the heat still radiating from the stones, two temperatures at once, and she understands in some bodily way why her father always stoked the fire before he sat here — the heat above and the cold below, the threshold between them, the hatch as the seam.

Then it comes.

Slower this time, or she is more prepared for it — the darkening below the surface, the movement that is not current and not a fish and not anything she has a name for. She watches it. It moves toward the opening from somewhere she can't see, gathering, becoming more itself as it approaches, and she realizes that what she is seeing is not one thing but many — not a shape exactly but a presence, the way you can sense a person in a dark room before you see them.

It stops below the opening.

She does not put her hand in. She does not lean over.

But she leans closer than she did the first time — close enough to see, in the pale gray ice below, something that resolves slowly out of the pattern of frozen water. A face. Or the suggestion of a face. Or her own mind, pattern-seeking in the way minds do, finding a face in the random structure of ice the way you find shapes in clouds.

She doesn't know which. She doesn't look away.

The temperature in the sauna has dropped. She realizes it gradually — the kiuas is still hot, the stones still radiating, but the cold coming up through the hatch has intensified, spreading out across the floor and climbing, and her breath is visible now in a way it wasn't five minutes ago. She can feel it on her feet, on her hands.

And then the knocking.

Three knocks, from below. Not on the ice — through it, or from under it, a sound that comes up through the floor of the sauna itself, through the pilings, three distinct knocks with a pause between each one that is exactly the same length.

She goes very still.

She does not move. She does not breathe in a way she would call breathing. The fire ticks. The stones tick as they give up their heat. She counts the seconds without meaning to — she counts everything now, she has started to notice, the silences most of all — and it goes on longer than she expects, long enough that she begins to think it was the only set, that it was over.

The cold comes up through the hatch.

Three knocks. Said the names. Her father's ledger. Quiet by morning.

After a long silence there are three more.

The same three. The same pause between them, measured out to the same length, as though something below were keeping the time exactly and would keep it exactly as long as it took. She does not say anything yet. She lets the sound finish and lets the room go quiet around where it had been, and she stays where she is, kneeling, until the quiet has held long enough that she trusts it.

She becomes aware that she is holding her breath. She lets it out slowly. Her hands on her knees are trembling — not from cold, or not only from cold.

She thinks of what her father wrote. *It is not evil.*

She thinks of what Eino wrote. *She was restless last night.*

She thinks of her grandfather Toivo. *Perhaps if I tell him there is another way.*

She does not know the names. She doesn't know what names her father said, what Toivo said, what Eino said — the ledgers record the saying of names but not what names, as though that part were too private to write down, or too dangerous. She doesn't know the name of the woman in the water. She only knows she is there.

She kneels at the edge of the hatch and looks down at the ice, at the suggestion of a face, and she says, because it is the only true thing she knows to say:

"I'm sorry. I don't know your name yet. But I know what my family did. And I'm going to find out how to make it right."

Nothing happens. The ice is ice. The sauna is warm and dim. The kiuas ticks.

She closes the hatch.

She sits on the lower bench for a long time afterward, until the fire burns low and the heat begins to fade and the cold starts to reclaim the room. Then she puts on her coat and

banks the stove and walks back up the hill to the house in the dark.

Inside, she washes her hands and face at the kitchen sink and makes tea and sits at the table. She is not shaking anymore. She feels — she doesn't have a word for it. Not calm exactly. Something older than calm. The feeling of having looked at a thing directly that you have been looking away from for a long time.

Her phone shows a missed call. The number she doesn't recognize and then does — she'd written it on the envelope this afternoon, the tribal offices, a woman named Sandra who'd said she would pass along the message. The missed call is from a different number. There is a voicemail.

She listens to it.

A woman's voice, older, unhurried: *This is Louise Swifthawk. I understand you've been trying to reach someone about the lake property in Kivijärvi. I knew your father. I think it's time we talked. Call me back when you're ready.*

She looks at the timestamp under the message. The call came in at 8:47. She does the arithmetic without deciding to. She was down at the sauna at 8:47 — on the lower bench, or kneeling at the edge of the open hatch, or walking back up the hill in the dark, the phone in her coat pocket where she never felt it, never heard it. It means nothing. People call in the evening. She looks at the number again, and then at the time again.

Aino sets the phone down on the table, face down. She wraps both hands around her mug of tea.

She will call back tomorrow. Tonight she sits in her father's kitchen with the photograph of herself at eight on the counter and the sound of three knocks still present

somewhere in her body, below thought, below language, and she does not feel afraid.

She feels, for the first time since she drove north on a February Tuesday with bags of peanut butter and apples on the passenger seat, like she is in the right place.

CHAPTER 11

Helmi Korhonen

She calls Louise Swifthawk in the morning and they talk for twenty minutes. Louise's voice is measured and careful, a woman who has thought about this conversation before having it. She asks Aino a few questions — how long she's been in Kivijärvi, what she knows about the property, whether she's been to the sauna. When Aino says yes, she's been to the sauna, there is a pause.

"What happened?" Louise asks.

Aino tells her, plainly, the way she would report something at work. The darkness under the ice. The knocking. What she said into the hatch.

Another pause, longer this time.

"I'd like to meet with you in person," Louise says. "Not on the phone. Can you come to Tamarack?"

They agree on a day, two days from now. Louise gives her an address. She says: "Come alone," which Aino had intended to do anyway, and then: "Don't go back to the sauna until after we talk." A pause. "Please."

Aino says she won't. She means it.

She puts the phone down and sits for a moment with the strangeness of it — that she has just made an appointment to discuss what is in the lake under her family's sauna with a woman whose family was put there by her great-grandfather. That this phone call was ordinary in its logistics, a time and an address, and impossible in every other way.

She needs to do something with her hands. She decides to go see Helmi.

Helmi Korhonen lives on the north end of town in a small white house with a covered porch and a birch tree in the front yard that is, in Aino's estimation, approximately the age of the town. She'd gotten the address from the Lutheran church directory, which was in a kitchen drawer at her father's house, which tells her something about the kind of man her father was — he kept a church directory in a kitchen drawer even though he never, as far as she could tell, used it for anything.

She knocks. Helmi answers after a minute, dressed for the day despite it being nine-thirty in the morning, a small woman in a cardigan and wool pants with reading glasses pushed up on her forehead and an expression that is not quite surprised to see her.

"I thought you might come," she says. She steps back to let her in.

The house is warm and orderly and smells like coffee and something baked. The front room is full of photographs — family, she assumes, and among them, on the shelf beside the window, a photograph she recognizes: two women, young, on a ship's deck, squinting into sun. One of them is a younger Helmi. The other one she doesn't know for a moment and then does. Her grandmother Aili.

"Sit down," Helmi says. "I'll get coffee."

They sit across from each other at the kitchen table with coffee and a plate of cookies that Helmi produces without being asked. Helmi waits. She is, Aino has noticed, a woman who is very comfortable with silence, who uses it the way

some people use small talk, to let the air settle.

"I went to the sauna," Aino says.

"I know," Helmi says.

"Mikko Aaltonen told you?"

"Mikko's grandmother told me forty years ago that when the time came, someone would go into that sauna who wasn't going to just sit and watch. I have been waiting to see who it was." She picks up her coffee. "I hoped it would be your father. He wasn't able."

"He wrote, at the end. That he thought there might be another way. That he didn't know what it was."

Helmi nods. "Toivo thought the same. He went looking for it in the wrong places." She sets her cup down. "The church," she says, with a flatness close to contempt. "As though the church had anything useful to say about this."

Aino thinks about Toivo's ledger entry. *The pastor gave me the answer I expected. I did not find it useful.*

"What do you know?" Aino asks. "What did my grandmother tell you?"

Helmi is quiet for a moment. "Aili knew from the beginning. Eino told her — not what he'd done, not exactly, but enough. She understood the sauna. She understood what the watching was and what it wasn't."

"How could she stay?"

"Where would she go." Helmi says it without a question mark, the way you state a fact you've already turned over for fifty years. "She was twenty-four. She had two children by then and a third coming and no English and a husband who had done a thing she could not undo by leaving. She was furious with him for the rest of his life and for the long years after. She kept it quiet because she had children and a life and because what else do you do." A pause. "Aili was a smart

woman. Smarter than the men she married into. Smart enough to know that knowing a thing and being able to fix it are not the same. She told me, when we were old enough to be telling each other the truth. She told me what she knew."

"Which was?"

"That a woman was killed. That her husband and three other men did it. That they buried it — her, and what they'd done — under the sauna, and that it hadn't stayed buried." Helmi's voice is even, the voice of someone reciting a history they have long since moved past grief about and arrived at something colder. "She told me the woman's name. Mindemoyen. She had heard Eino say it in his sleep."

Aino is quiet. Then: "But what is it. What's down there. You said you understood what the watching was. So tell me what it's watching."

Helmi looks at her with something that is almost amusement and is not amusement.

"You think because I am old and I am Finnish I have a word for it." She turns her cup a quarter-turn on the table. "We had words. That was the trouble. We came over with a whole language for it."

"What words?"

Helmi is quiet long enough that Aino thinks she isn't going to answer. The coffee maker on the counter clicks off. Outside a car goes by and is gone.

"In the old country," Helmi says, "everything had its *väki*. You know this word? No. Your father wouldn't have taught you." She says it without reproach. "It is hard to put in English. A force. A power that lives in a place, in a thing. The forest has its *väki*. Fire has its *väki* — you don't whistle near the stove, you don't speak ill of it, because it is awake and it has a temper. Water has the most of all. *Veden väki*." She

turns the word over carefully, an object she hasn't held in some time. "Where there was deep water, a lake like this one, the old people said there was a *vetehinen*. A water-being. It lived under the surface. It could be angry, it could pull a man down, it could be — paid off, almost. You gave the first fish back to it. You did not foul the water. You were polite to it, the way you are polite to a neighbor with a long memory and a short fuse."

"And that's what's in the lake."

"No." Helmi says it flatly, and then, more quietly, "That is the whole mistake. That is what I am trying to tell you." She sets the cup down. "They came here, Eino and the others, with these words in their mouths. *Väki. Vetehinen*. When the lake started — doing what it does — they reached for what they had. A man understands a thing he has a name for. So they told themselves: it is the water-spirit, it is angry, we will manage it the way our grandfathers managed the lakes at home. Watch it. Keep it fed. Keep it quiet." She shakes her head, once. "But a *vetehinen* is a Finnish thing. It belongs to Finnish water. The men brought the word across the ocean in a trunk like a coffee grinder and tried to set it down on a lake that already had — " she stops.

Aino waits.

"That already had whatever it had," Helmi finishes. "Which was not theirs. Which was not a *vetehinen* and never was. It was a woman, first of all, a real woman with a name, and what she became after they did what they did — that is not a thing I have a word for. The Finnish word was always too small. It was a borrowed coat that didn't fit and they kept trying to button it." She looks at the window. "*Vetehinen* is what they could say. It is not what was true."

"Then what's true."

"I don't know." Helmi says it without apology. "And the part I do know is not mine to hand out. There are people across the lake whose grandmothers knew what this water was before any Finn ever saw it, and they did not call it by my words, and they did not understand it the way four frightened men with a thing to hide understood it. If there is a true name for it, it is theirs, and you will not hear it from me, because I would only get it wrong the way Eino got it wrong, and getting it wrong is the entire history of this place." She picks up her coffee again. "That is why you are going to Tamarack. That is the only sensible thing anyone in your family has thought of in a hundred years."

Aino turns this over. "But Aili understood it. You said that. She knew what the watching was and wasn't, when Eino didn't."

"She understood it could not be named and managed. That is most of what there was to know, and it was more than the men ever learned." A pause. "What none of us knew — Aili, me, your father — is what to *do* about it. The women always knew more than the men but the men were the ones going into the sauna and we were not." A pause. "I told you to leave it. I meant it. I still mean it. But I also knew when I said it that you probably wouldn't."

"I called the tribal offices," Aino says. "I'm going to Tamarack in two days."

Helmi looks at her for a long moment.

"Good," she says. "That is the right thing." She picks up her coffee. "Whatever they tell you, whatever they ask of you — listen. Don't argue. Don't explain. Listen."

Aino nods.

"And take Mikko with you," Helmi says.

"She said to come alone."

"She said that because she doesn't know Mikko." Helmi sets her cup down with a small decisive click. "His grandmother was a good woman. She spent her whole life trying to make up for what her husband knew and didn't stop. If you tell Louise Swifthawk whose grandson he is, she will know his grandmother's name, and that will matter." She pauses. "This is not only a Hietala problem. It was never only a Hietala problem. Take Mikko."

Aino thinks about Mikko at the diner. *Whatever you decide to do, I'll help.*

"All right," she says.

They drink their coffee. Helmi refills both cups without asking. Outside the kitchen window the birch tree in the front yard is very still in the cold air, the white bark bright against the gray sky.

"My grandmother," Aino says. "Did she ever forgive him? Eino?"

Helmi thinks about this for a longer time than Aino expects.

"She loved him," she says finally. "That's not the same thing. She loved him and she knew what he was and she lived with both of those things for forty years and I don't think she resolved them, no. I don't think she was able to." A pause. "She told me once that the hardest part wasn't forgiving him. The hardest part was that she understood how it had happened. She could follow the chain of it — the land pressure, the mining company, the Indian agent, the other men, the drinking, the dark, the fear. She could follow every link of that chain and still arrive at the same place. And understanding it didn't make it right. It just made it more terrible."

Aino thinks about Eino's notebook. *Kaunis*. Beautiful. The man who thought the lake was beautiful and then did what he did in it.

She does not have anything to say to that. Helmi doesn't seem to expect anything. The clock on the wall above the stove moves its minute hand with a small dry sound. Aino lets the question be over and finds that it isn't, quite — that it has left something in the room that wants a little more air.

"Did you forgive her?" she asks. "For staying. For keeping it quiet."

Helmi looks at her, and for the first time the stillness in her face is not the comfortable kind.

"There was nothing to forgive," she says. "She did what a woman with three children does. She survived it and she did not let it eat her." She turns her cup again. "I used to think — when we were younger, before I understood anything — that she should have done more. Said something. To someone. I had ideas about what a person ought to do." A small breath that is not quite a laugh. "Then I got old enough to understand what would have happened to her, and to the children, and to nothing else. She was not the one who needed to be forgiven. She spent forty years carrying a thing she didn't put down there. That is its own kind of penance, carrying what isn't yours."

She is quiet for a moment.

"She made me promise I would tell whoever came after. That is all she could do, at the end. Hand it forward to someone with fewer reasons to be afraid." Helmi looks at her steadily. "So now I have told you. And you have fewer reasons than she did. Don't waste them."

Aino nods. She finds she can't say anything. Helmi doesn't ask her to.

They sit in the kitchen and drink their coffee and outside the birch tree stands in the cold without moving, white and bare and patient.

CHAPTER 12

The Drive to Tamarack

She calls Mikko that afternoon. She tells him what Helmi said. He is quiet for a moment and then says: "My grandmother's name was Rauha. Louise Swifthawk may know it."

"Will you come?"

"Yes," he says, without hesitation.

She calls Louise Swifthawk and tells her she'd like to bring someone, explains who, explains whose grandson. There is a pause on the line.

"Rauha Aaltonen," Louise says. "Yes. I know that name." Another pause. "Bring him."

—

They drive to Tamarack on a Thursday morning, Mikko's truck because the roads are better with the higher clearance. The sky is low and white. The heater works on one setting, which is too hot, so they run it in bursts and then crack the windows, and the cab fills with the smell of exhaust and cold pine and the coffee in the two travel mugs in the console, going lukewarm.

The landscape between Kivijärvi and Tamarack is forty miles of the same country. Pines and birch and the occasional glimpse of a frozen lake through the trees, a gas station, a shuttered bait shop, a church with a plowed lot and no cars in it. The road runs straight for long stretches and then bends for no reason she can see, around some property line drawn a century ago by men who are all dead now. Mikko drives the

way he does everything, without hurry, both hands on the wheel, easing off well before the curves.

They drive most of it without talking. Earlier in their acquaintance she had read his silences as the comfortable kind, a U.P. quality, or maybe just his — a man who does not feel the need to fill the air. This silence is not that. This one has a shape. There is a conversation they are not having and it sits between them on the bench seat like a third passenger, and she is aware of it the way you are aware of a sound that has stopped: the absence of it is louder than the thing would be.

She could ask him what his grandmother told him. Whether Rauha ever said the name out loud, in the kitchen, the way Aili said it in her sleep. Whether he has known, all the years he ran his crew and married a Niemi girl and divorced her, that the road they are on now was always going to be in front of him. She does not ask. He could ask her what she is going to say to Louise Swifthawk, whether she has it rehearsed, what she imagines comes after. He does not ask either. They carry their separate halves of it down the straight white road and the not-asking is its own kind of weather in the cab, pressing.

Past a county-line sign the trees open onto a long frozen bay and she looks at it without meaning to, the flat gray ice with the snow scoured off it in places, and then makes herself look back at the road. Forty miles. Every lake between here and there is the same lake, in a way she would not have understood a week ago.

"Are you nervous?" he asks, somewhere around the halfway point.

"Yes," she says.

"Me too." He says it to the windshield. His hands do not move on the wheel. After a while he reaches over and turns the heater off entirely, and they drive the rest of the way cold, which is better.

The address Louise gave her is a house on a side road off the main highway, a small ranch house with a satellite dish and a stack of firewood on the porch and a late-model truck in the driveway. There is a mat outside the front door that says WELCOME in plain letters, no embellishment.

She knocks. Mikko stands slightly behind her.

The woman who answers is in her late sixties, compact and solid, with close-cropped gray hair and eyes that assess them both in a single efficient look. She is wearing jeans and a flannel shirt and reading glasses on a cord around her neck. She looks like what she is, which is a person who has a great deal to do and has set some of it aside for this conversation.

"Come in," she says.

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The living room is warm and ordinary — a couch, chairs, a television, a bookshelf, family photographs on the walls. She offers coffee and they both say yes and she goes to the kitchen and comes back with three mugs and a plate of fry bread and sits across from them in the armchair.

She looks at them both for a moment.

"I'll tell you what I'm going to tell you and what I'm not," she says. "There are things about Mindemoyen that belong to us and I won't be sharing them with you. Her name you already know. What she was to us, what we believe about what happened to her, what we call what she has become — that's not for this conversation." She looks at Aino specifically. "I want to be clear about that before we start."

"I understand," Aino says.

"What I'll tell you is the history, because the history is yours too and you should know it. And I'll tell you what I think you can do, which is not much, but it's something." She picks up her coffee. "Your great-grandfather acquired that land through a federal homestead claim in 1913. The land had been used by my family for generations before that. The Indian agent had been telling us for years that our claims were not recognized. Mindemoyen was the last one living on the property your great-grandfather claimed. She was elderly and alone and she refused to leave." She says all of this with the flatness of someone reading from a document they have read many times. "In the fall of 1919, four men — your great-grandfather and three others — came to her cabin. She died. Whatever exactly happened, she died, and her remains were put in the lake."

Aino has the mug in both hands and she keeps it there. She has come prepared, she had thought, to receive this. She has read the ledgers. She has read Eino's notebook in his careful learned-English hand, *the woman's cabin is gone, I have moved the stones*, and she had believed, sitting at the kitchen table with the leather cover under her palm, that she had already taken in the worst of it. She had filed it. That was the work she does, the work she is good at, taking a hard fact and setting it where it goes.

It does not go anywhere now. Louise says *four men* and *she was elderly and alone* and *she refused to leave* in the same even voice she used for the homestead claim and the date, and Aino feels each one land somewhere below the level she does her thinking on. An elderly woman, alone, who would not leave. The cabin gone. The stones moved. Her great-grandfather's jaw, which is her father's jaw, which is in

the photograph in the hall, which is, when she looks down at the backs of her own hands around the mug, partly hers.

Her face holds. She is aware of holding it the way you are aware of bracing against a cold she had thought she'd dressed for. But the heat has gone out of her hands. The mug is warm and her hands are not taking it, and there is a pressure low in her chest, under the breastbone, dense and specific, that has nothing to do with the warm ordinary room. *She died.* The plainness of it is the worst part. Louise will not dress it up and Aino understands, dimly, that the refusal to dress it up is a courtesy and also a kind of judgment, and that both are correct. The fry bread sits on the plate between them. Somewhere in the house a clock or a heater makes a small sound. Outside, nothing.

She wants, for one bad moment, to say that she didn't do it. That she was born in 1987, in Milwaukee, that she never met the man. The wanting embarrasses her even as it rises and she does not say it, because it is beside the point, and it would only be Aino asking to be let off something no one has tried to put on her. She keeps the mug in her hands. She makes herself stay in the chair and in the fact. *Her remains were put in the lake.* Put there by men whose name she carries on the other side, the Hietala side, the side that built the sauna and kept the watch and called it for a hundred years a family that keeps to itself.

When she finds she can move again she does the only thing there is to do, which is small and inadequate and the whole of what is asked of her in this moment. She looks up. She holds the older woman's eyes. She nods, once — not agreement, there is nothing to agree to, only that she has heard it and is not going to look away from it.

Louise looks at her steadily. Aino meets her eyes.

"We knew," Louise says. "We knew within weeks. We had no recourse — no legal recourse, nothing that would have been heard. We grieved her. We have grieved her for a hundred years." A pause. "We also knew, within a few years, that something remained. That she had not — moved on, let's say. We could feel it in the lake. We left it alone. It was not ours to interfere with."

"Because of the sauna," Aino says.

"Because of the sauna," Louise agrees. "Your family put themselves between us and her. Every generation. We could not reach her, and honestly —" she pauses, something shifting in her expression, "we were not certain what reaching her would mean. She was changed by what happened to her. What she wanted, what she needed — we don't know. We don't presume to know."

The room is quiet. Outside, a car passes on the road.

"What my father wrote," Aino says carefully. "In his note to me. He said she's not evil. That she was wronged and has been waiting for someone to do something other than watch."

Louise looks at her for a long moment. "Your father was more perceptive than his father and his grandfather. I think he was right, as far as he understood it." She sets her coffee down. "The watching — what your family has been doing — it was containment. It kept things from getting worse. It also kept things from getting better. She has been held in place for a hundred years by your family's attention. Watched but not acknowledged. Known but not named. That is its own kind of wrong, added to the original."

Mikko speaks for the first time. His voice is careful and quiet. "What would acknowledgment look like?"

Louise looks at him. "Your grandmother was Rauha Mäkinen before she married?"

"Aaltonen," he says. "Her family was Mäkinen."

Something moves through Louise's expression — not quite surprise, not quite its absence. "The Mäkelä line," she says.

"Yes."

She is quiet for a moment. She is looking at Mikko now the way she looked at Aino when she said *four men*, placing him, fitting the man in the flannel shirt on her couch into a history that had a slot for him before he was born.

"Your great-grandfather was there that night."

She does not say it as small talk and Aino, beside him, feels the difference. It is not new information to anyone in the room. Mikko has known his whole life; he said so at the diner, *everyone whose grandfather was around in 1919 knows*. But knowing a thing in your own head and hearing it said across a coffee table by the granddaughter of the woman it was done to are not the same knowing, and she watches it reach him.

"I know," he says.

His voice is level but something has gone out of it. He sets his mug down on the side table with the deliberate care of a man who has just noticed his hands. He does not look at Aino. He looks at the middle distance, at the family photographs on Louise Swifthawk's wall — other people's grandmothers, other people's children — and his jaw works once and is still.

The word *there* sits in the room. Not by the lake, not in the town, not in the long careful margin where Eino kept his ledgers and Toivo kept his after him. *There*. At the cabin. In the fall, in 1919, one of the four. Louise does not elaborate and Mikko does not ask her to, and Aino understands that the not-asking is the only thing he can offer it — that to ask for detail would be to ask Louise to hand over what is hers, and that Mikko, who has carried the shape of this for fifty years

without the words, has decided in the space of a breath not to do that.

The silence holds a moment longer than is comfortable. Outside the car has long since passed. Then Louise lets it go, and turns, and continues.

"What would acknowledgment look like," she repeats, as though returning to a question from a different angle. "It would look like stopping. The watching, the sitting, the containing. It would look like your family removing itself from between us and her. And it would look like giving back — not the land, that's done and it would take courts and years and that's a different conversation. But what your family took from us in terms of — being able to grieve properly. Being able to say her name without your family's guilt standing in the way of it." She looks at Aino. "The things your father kept in that sauna. The notebooks, the tools, the records. Those belong with us. Not because they're ours legally, but because they're her history, and that is ours."

Aino thinks about the forty-two ledgers. The notebooks. The carved marks on the walls that she'd photographed and couldn't read.

"I'll bring them," she says.

"Not today," Louise says. "I need to talk to my family about what we want and how we want to receive it. This is not something I can decide alone." She looks at both of them. "I'll call you. It may take a week, may take two. When we're ready, we'll tell you what we want."

Aino nods. "And the sauna itself?"

Louise is quiet for a moment. "What were you thinking?"

"I don't know exactly. Taking it down, maybe. Or — I thought about fire. It's a sauna. They burn."

Louise's expression doesn't change. "That's your decision to make," she says. "Not mine. What happens to your family's structure on your family's land is not something I can tell you." A pause. "What I will say is that whatever you do with it, do it after we've had a chance to — prepare. There are things we may want to do first. On our side. Our own way." She picks up her coffee. "Can you give us two weeks?"

"Yes," Aino says.

Louise nods. She looks at them both again, that efficient assessing look. "You did the right thing coming here," she says. It is not a warm statement but it is a genuine one. "Most people wouldn't have."

"My father wanted to," Aino says. "He just didn't know how to start."

Louise considers this. "He kept watch for thirty years," she says. "That's something. It's not enough, but it's something." She stands, which is the signal that the conversation is done. They stand too. At the door she shakes both their hands.

Outside, in the cold, walking to the truck, Mikko doesn't say anything for a moment. He unlocks her door first, the way he was raised to, and goes around, and gets in, and sits for a second with the key in the ignition not turned, both hands on the bottom of the wheel, looking at the WELCOME mat and the firewood on Louise Swifthawk's porch.

Then: "Mäkelä," he says quietly. Not to her, exactly. To himself, or to his grandfather, or to the name in the air.

"Yeah," she says.

He starts the truck. He does not turn the heater on.

They drive back to Kivijärvi through the white pines with the low sky pressing down on everything. The light has not changed all day; it is the same flat white at two in the afternoon as it was at nine. The same gas station, the same

shuttered bait shop, the same churches and the same long frozen bay sliding past on the passenger side, and Aino watches it go and does not look away from it this time.

The silence in the truck is different from the silence on the way there. That one had a conversation buried in it, the things they were each not saying held separate, his half and her half. This one is the same silence on both sides. It is heavier, and it is more honest, because there is nothing in it that wants to be said and isn't — only the thing itself, which neither of them has words equal to, which they are both now carrying in the same direction.

Mikko drives the way he did this morning, without hurry, but his shoulders have come down from where they were on Louise's couch and his face has the stillness of a man doing arithmetic he already knows the answer to. *There. At the cabin. One of the four.* He keeps both hands on the wheel and at one point he lets out a long breath through his nose, slowly, the way you do when you are deciding not to say something, and she lets him not say it.

She has her hands in her lap. She is aware of them — that she does not know what to do with them, that they have been cold since the living room and have not warmed up — and she finds, somewhere past the county line, that she has been turning her father's house key over and over between her fingers without deciding to, the small repetitive motion of a woman with nowhere to put what she is holding. She makes herself stop. She presses both palms flat against the tops of her thighs and leaves them there, and watches the road, and the cab is cold, and the quiet between them is exactly the right amount of quiet for what they are both carrying, and she finds that she can sit in it without difficulty, which is not the same as comfort.

CHAPTER 13

Going Home

She rides back from Tamarack in Mikko's passenger seat, watching the pines go by in the fading light. He drops her at the house and she stands in the cold driveway a moment watching his taillights disappear down the gravel road before going inside.

The sky outside the kitchen window is the dull pewter of a day that never quite found the sun. She puts the kettle on and stands at the counter thinking about what Louise said.

The watching — it was containment. It also kept things from getting better.

She has been thinking about her father's life, since she got here, in terms of what he failed to do. What he didn't tell her, what he didn't fix, what he couldn't bring himself to start. But there is another way to look at it, she thinks now. He sat in that sauna for thirty years. Every week, sometimes more. He went down the hill in the dark, in the cold, in every season, and he lit the stove and he opened the hatch and he watched. That is thirty years of keeping a promise he never made, inherited from a man who made the wrong one.

It is not enough. Louise said so and she already knew it. But it is not nothing, either.

She thinks about the first Aino. Her great-grandmother, who looked at Eino for a long time and did not speak, and then lived in that house for forty-three years with the thing he'd done and the thing he'd built over it and never went near the sauna. She wonders what the first Aino thought about in the night. Whether she talked to anyone. Whether there was a

Helmi Korhonen for her, someone to tell the true version to.

She thinks there probably wasn't. 1919 was a different kind of alone.

The kettle starts to go and she takes it off before it whistles. She does not make the tea. She stands holding the kettle with the steam coming off the spout and finds that she does not want to be in the house.

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She puts her coat on over the sweater and her father's chore gloves from the hook by the door, the leather ones gone stiff with cold, and goes out the back.

The light is nearly gone. The snow on the slope down to the water holds it longer than the sky does, a flat blue-white going gray, and her boots break the crust at every step. She has not been down to the shore since the second day. She told herself then it was the rotten ice, the city boots, the better sense. She does not tell herself anything now. She just goes down, past the woodpile, past the dark shape of the sauna at the waterline, and stops at the tree line where the snow ends, where she stopped before.

The lake is the same flat white it was three weeks ago. The fish houses are still out there, small and dark in the last of the light. Nothing has changed and everything has. She knows the history now. She knows what is in the water and how it came to be there and the name of the woman whose remains her great-grandfather moved with his own hands, and she stands at the edge of it in the cold and waits to feel something large.

What she feels instead is small and exact. The lake takes her in. There is no other word she can put to it that is honest. The cold off the ice comes up the slope and finds her face the

way cold does, but underneath the cold there is a second thing, slower, that has nothing to do with weather — a settling of the whole white plain toward the place where she is standing, a leaning-in she feels along the front of her body and not her back. It is not the wind. The wind is at her back, going nowhere, dying at the shoreline the way it did before. This is the lake itself, gathered and aware, taking the measure of her the way you take the measure of a debt.

She does not look away from it. That is the only thing she has to offer, and she offers it. She stands until the cold has worked all the way through the chore gloves and her feet have gone numb in the city boots and the light is fully gone and the fish houses are only a darker dark on the dark, and the lake holds its attention on her the whole time, patient, and she lets it.

Then she goes back up the hill. Her own prints going down are already softening at the edges. She knocks the snow off her boots on the step and goes in and the house is warm and ordinary and she stands in it for a moment getting the feeling back in her hands.

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She makes soup from what's in the refrigerator — there's not much, she needs to go back to the grocery store — and eats standing at the counter, which she does sometimes in Milwaukee and which in her father's kitchen feels different, feels like something he would have done, and she lets herself stand there and eat his soup and be his daughter for a few minutes without that being complicated.

Then she washes the bowl and sits at the kitchen table with a cup of tea and thinks clearly, as clearly as she has since she got here.

The ledgers need to go to Louise. All of them, or at least the ones from before her father — Eino's notebook, Toivo's ledgers. Her father's forty-two she is less certain about. They are his handwriting, his life, his thirty years of watching. She doesn't know if they belong with Louise or with her or nowhere, buried with her father. That question can wait.

The sauna itself. She has been avoiding thinking about this directly, but she makes herself think about it now. The structure has been there since 1919 in one form or another. Her father put new cedar in it the last summer she was home. He kept wood stacked and ready for the stove. He maintained it the way you maintain something important, something that has a function you cannot abandon.

Now she is the one deciding its function.

The things in the lockbox — the key she hasn't tried yet, whatever door it opens. The carvings on the walls. The tools in the basement whose purpose she still doesn't fully understand. All of this is information she doesn't have yet, and she needs it before she decides anything.

She gets out a piece of paper and makes a list, because she is a paralegal and lists are how she thinks:

What Louise's family wants and when.

What the key in the lockbox opens.

What the carvings mean and who to ask.

What to do with father's ledgers.

What to do with the sauna.

What to do with the house.

What to do after.

She looks at the last item. *What to do after*. It is the kind of line item she writes a dozen times a week, the catchall at the bottom of a matter, the placeholder for the part you cannot scope yet. At work it means the closing, the

distribution, the file sent to storage. Here she does not know what it means and she has been letting the not-knowing pass for the same kind of clean professional deferral, a thing to be handled when the upstream items resolve.

It is not that. She makes herself see that it is not that.

The list is honest about the lake and dishonest about her. Every item above the line is a thing she does and then leaves. Give Louise the ledgers and drive away. Open the lockbox, learn the carvings, decide the sauna, list the house with a realtor in Marquette, and drive away. The whole document is built on the assumption that there is an after she returns to, that Kivijärvi is a matter she closes and Milwaukee is where she lives, and she is not sure anymore that the assumption is true, and that is the thing she has not written down because she does not have the handwriting for it.

Because here is the part under the part. She is not afraid of the lake. She has been afraid of the lake and the fear has changed into something she does not have a word for, down there at the tree line in the dark. What she is afraid of, sitting at her father's table with the tea going cold, is that she could stay. That the pull she feels is not grief and not duty and not the percolator. That her father went down that hill in the dark every week for thirty years because something in this place had hold of him, and that the same thing — older than her father, older than the homestead claim, set in the water in 1919 — has been quietly fitting her into the slot it kept for him since the night she drove up Highway 51 with the radio cutting out. That she would not be choosing it. That it would feel like choosing.

She does not write that down either. There is no clean line for it. But she stops pretending the last item is logistics.

She thinks about Mikko saying: *Are you ever thinking about coming back?*

She thinks about the way the cold hit her when she got out of the car that first night, the quality of it, the specific U.P. dryness she'd forgotten. She thinks about the percolator. The photograph. The pines outside the window making the light different from any light in Milwaukee.

She thinks about the drive north on Highway 51, the trees closing in, the radio cutting out on that stretch of highway where it always cuts out, the silence in the car that wasn't just silence.

She has been here for nearly three weeks. She has not thought about Milwaukee in several of them.

She folds the list and puts it in her coat pocket with the envelope and the photograph of herself at eight. She goes to bed at a reasonable hour and lies in the dark and listens to the house, which is quiet tonight — no sound from the lake, no knocking, just the furnace and the pines.

She said something into the hatch and the knocking stopped.

She doesn't know what that means. She doesn't know if it means anything. But she is aware, lying in the dark of her childhood bedroom under her grandmother's quilt, that the house feels different than it did when she arrived. Not less strange. But differently strange. Her father watched the lake for thirty years and the lake stayed where it was put; that was the whole of what the watching did, she understands now — it held the door, it did not open it, and a held door is still a closed one with a person standing guard. What she felt at the tree line tonight was not a thing held down. It was a thing turned, the way a head turns toward a sound, toward the slope and the house and the lit kitchen window and her, the

only one left who carries the name and has gone down the hill and stood at the edge and not looked away.

She lies under the quilt and the furnace cycles on and off and somewhere below the cold floor and the frozen yard and the dark trees the water keeps its slow attention on the house, and she is the one in the house, and she finds — and this is the part she will not be able to explain to anyone, not Mikko, not Louise, not the version of herself with the apartment in Milwaukee — that she is not afraid, and that lying here in her father's house with a hundred years of it underneath her, she feels something she can only call being in the right place. Which is exactly what she is afraid of.

She sleeps. She dreams of nothing she can remember in the morning.

When she wakes the sun is coming through the bedsheet curtains and the yard outside is empty. No new prints in the snow.

She makes coffee. She looks at her list.

She starts with the key.

CHAPTER 14

Mikko Tells Her

The key from the lockbox is larger and older than the padlock key — iron rather than brass, the kind of key that belongs to something built before the age of standard hardware. She turns it over in her hand at the kitchen table trying to think what in this house would have a lock that old.

Not the house itself — the doors have modern deadbolts, her father's doing at some point. Not the basement — there's no lock on the basement door. She goes through the house methodically, room by room, opening closets and drawers, looking for something she's missed.

She finds it in the basement.

She'd walked past it twice without registering it — a section of the fieldstone foundation wall on the north side, behind the furnace, where the shadows are deep and she'd only glanced. She has to turn sideways to get back there, between the furnace's flank and the cold stone, and the warmth off the metal stops a foot in, the way it does, and then there is the wall. A wooden panel set into the stone, about three feet square, the boards dark and close-grained and older than the framing in the rest of the basement. A keyhole in the middle of it, in a plate of black iron that was not stamped out of a sheet by a machine. Someone forged it. The edges are uneven, hammered, the metal thicker at the corners, and there is a maker's roughness to it that her eye, after twelve years of mortgage paperwork and chain-of-title, has no category for. It is the kind of thing that would be a root cellar door in an older house. Which is exactly what it is.

She fits the key. The iron is heavy enough in her hand that she has to use her wrist. It turns with a single dry sound, no give to it, the bolt a thing the size of her finger sliding out of the stone.

The door swings inward on hinges that have been recently oiled — her father's maintenance, she can tell, the same patient keeping-up that marks everything in this house. He had kept this. Whatever else he had let go of, he had come down here with an oil can.

The cold comes out at her before she has the door all the way open. Not the basement's cold, which is the cold of a room above frozen ground. This is lower than that, and it has a wet edge to it, and a smell rides on it — earth, and the iron of the stone, and under those a sourness that is almost sweet, the smell of things kept a long time in the dark and slowly going to nothing. She stands in it a moment with her breath hanging in front of her. The space beyond is small, maybe six feet deep, the walls bare earth shored with timber, a single shelf of fieldstone running along one side and rough plank shelving along the other. No bulb. She uses her phone for light.

On the plank shelves: mason jars, the oldest she has ever seen outside a museum, the glass gone faintly violet the way old glass goes, the zinc lids dull and pocked. Hand-labeled. She holds the light close and reads the handwriting and knows it before she has read a word of it — Eino's, the same cramped slanted hand from the documents, from the oldest of the ledgers. The labels are in Finnish. Some of the words she has, from a childhood of half-listening: *piharatamo*, plantain. *Siankärsämö*, yarrow. *Mesiangervo*. Others she does not have at all, and a few are not plant names she thinks but something else, shorter, with a date after them. She does

not open anything. The contents have gone dark and settled and she does not want to know how they smell.

On the stone shelf, a tin box that rattles when she lifts it and that she sets back down without opening, because her hands are cold and because some part of her has begun, down here, to ask permission of things before she touches them, and she notices that about herself and lets it stand.

And at the back of the stone shelf, pushed to the wall, a small figure carved from wood. It is wrapped in a piece of cloth, gone gray, tied at what she takes to be the neck with a length of the same cord that ties the oilcloth bundle. She can make out the shape of a head under the cloth, the suggestion of shoulders. It fits in her palm. She picks it up and the wood is colder than the air, colder than the stone, the particular cold she had felt in the carved studs in the workshop on the far side of the furnace, and she sets it back exactly where it stood and does not unwrap it. It is not hers to unwrap. She does not know what it is. She lets it go on being something she does not know.

On the center shelf, taking up most of the space: a bundle wrapped in oilcloth, tied with cord, about the size of a large book. This she takes.

She takes the oilcloth bundle upstairs. She unties it carefully at the kitchen table.

Inside: documents. Old ones, the paper fragile and browned at the edges. The top sheet is a land claim document, her great-grandfather's name in official typescript, the property described in legal language she can parse easily enough after twelve years of reading legal documents. Below it: correspondence, a series of letters between Eino and the county land office, formal and dry. Below that, a folded sheet of paper in Eino's handwriting that is not a letter to anyone

official.

She reads it.

It is a list of names. Four columns — one for each of the four families. Under each family name, a list of people, beginning with the original four men and working forward through the generations, names and dates of birth and, for the ones who had died, dates of death. Her own name is at the bottom of the Hietala column, with her date of birth. Her father's handwriting, not Eino's — he had updated this, adding names as they were born, removing nothing.

She is the last name on the Hietala list.

Under the Mäkinen column, the last of the men reads: *Risto Mäkinen Jr., b. 1912, d. 1947. No sons.* The end of the name, if not the end of the blood.

Under the Lehtinen column, three names below the original Lehtinen man: living descendants, she presumes, still in the area.

Under the fourth column, in Eino's handwriting: the Saari family, four living descendants as of whenever Eino last updated this, and then her father's handwriting continuing the list — a Saari man still in Kivijärvi, she'd seen the name around town.

She sits with this list for a long time.

And while she is sitting with it the basement comes back to her — not the cellar, the workshop, the pegboard of tools she had handled her first morning and couldn't name. The long-handled things with heads she had no words for. The chisels hung in graduated order, smallest to largest, the way a man hangs them when he uses every one of them and knows where each belongs in the hand. The mallet of dark dense wood, worn smooth in the one spot, the handle shaped over time to a grip that was not hers and not her father's only. She

had taken those for the ordinary tools of a man who fixed things, a drawknife and a froe among them, woodworking gone slightly past her. They are not that. They are the tools for the marks. For cutting the band of carved figures into the studs of the sauna and the framing of the basement walls and keeping them cut, deepening them as the wood weathered and the lines went shallow, year on year, the way you keep up a thing that has to hold. The cedar in the vise on the workbench, the half-finished piece her father was shaping when his heart stopped — she does not know what it was going to be and she understands now that this is the wrong question. It was going to be part of the structure. The tools and the marks and the sauna and the watch are one thing, and have been one thing since 1919, and her father spent his evenings down there not in a hobby but in maintenance, keeping the edges sharp on the only work that mattered, the way he oiled the cellar hinges, the way he stocked the firewood before he died.

She lets that settle. It does not frighten her the way the list does. It is almost the opposite. It is the first thing about her father in three weeks that she fully understands.

Before she calls Mikko, she calls her supervisor in Milwaukee. She has been gone nearly three weeks. Her extended leave runs out at the end of the month and she has been not letting herself think about what comes after.

Her supervisor picks up on the second ring. The connection is bad out here and his voice comes through with the underwater quality of a call routed through a tower thirty miles off, and she stands at the counter with the phone to her ear and looks at the kitchen while he talks. The grocery list in her father's hand, still on the counter where she'd set it the first day with the cracked reading glasses. The percolator. The

window over the sink and the yard past it, the snow, the tree line and the slope down to the lake she cannot see from here. The kitchen of a man who has been dead three weeks, holding everything he left exactly where he left it, and her own life on the other end of the line, her caseload, the divorces and custody fights and the orderly grief of people whose dead stay dead. The two do not fit in the same room. She holds the phone and lets them not fit.

She tells him she needs more time — she doesn't know how much, another two to three weeks at minimum. There is a silence on the line that she reads accurately as the sound of a patient man running out of patience.

"Aino," he says. "I've been flexible with you. We have cases backing up."

"I know," she says. "I'm sorry. There are things here I have to finish."

Another silence. Then: "Two more weeks. After that I need to know something definitive."

She thanks him. She means it. She hangs up and stands a moment longer at the window — the job, Milwaukee, the life that has been on hold and going — and then she picks up the phone again.

She calls Mikko.

He comes over that afternoon, driving up the plowed gravel road in his truck, and she has coffee made and the documents spread on the kitchen table and she watches his face as he looks at them.

He stands over the table and reads the list a long time, the way she had read it, top to bottom, column by column, and she lets him. She does not narrate it for him. She has learned, this week, that there is nothing to say while someone reads their own name into a thing like this and that the saying

would only be for her.

He finds his grandmother's name in the Mäkinen column. Rauha Mäkinen, b. 1921 — she'd been nine when they'd updated this, old enough to inherit the knowledge, young enough that it had shaped her whole life. A daughter of the family, married out to a man named Aaltonen, carried clear of the name and not clear of the blood. Mikko's finger rests on her name for a moment. Then it moves up the column, to the original Mäkinen man at the top, one of the four, and back down again, the whole line of them, four generations of his own people set down in Eino's hand and then her father's, and then it stops at the bottom, where the Mäkinen column ends and hers does not.

"She never talked about it directly," he says. "She just — made sure I knew, in pieces. A thing here, a thing there. By the time I was old enough to put it together I already knew the whole shape of it."

"Did your father know?"

"Yes. He moved away when I was twelve. Different response to the same inheritance." He looks up from the document. "How many other people in this town know?"

"I don't know. Helmi knows. Paavo — I'm not sure how much." She pauses. "You said that everyone whose grandfather was around in 1919 knows on some level."

He nods. He sits down across from her and wraps his hands around his coffee mug. "What did Louise say about the Lehtinens? And the Saaris?"

"She didn't. We didn't get that far."

He is quiet. She watches him thinking. The afternoon light is in the kitchen now, the low slanting kind that comes this far north in winter for an hour before it goes, and it lies across the documents on the table and across the backs of his hands.

Neither of them moves the papers. The list sits between them face up. She has the sense, sitting here, that this is the first time in a long while that two people have looked at it together in the same room — that Eino kept it and her father kept it and each of them carried it alone, folded into oilcloth in the cold, and that the simple fact of two coffee cups and two sets of eyes on it is a thing that has not happened, maybe, in a hundred years. It is not much. It does not change what is in the lake. But the paper is less heavy with two of them looking at it and she registers that, the small physical fact of it, the way the weight of a thing changes when a second hand takes a corner.

She does not say any of this. He would understand it and the saying would still be unnecessary. They sit with the list a while in the failing light.

"There's a Saari man on the north end of the lake," he says. "Retired. He's in his seventies. His grandfather was the one — " He stops. "I don't know exactly what his grandfather did. But he was one of the four."

"I know."

"He knows about the sauna. About what it is. I've had — not a conversation, but a moment, a few years ago, when we both understood we were talking around the same thing without saying it." He pauses. "He's not going to want this opened up."

"I know that too."

He looks at her. "What are you going to do?"

She thinks about what she told Louise. *Taking it down. Or fire.* Louise's response: *That's your decision to make.* And then: *Can you give us two weeks.*

"I'm going to wait for Louise to tell me what she wants," she says. "And then I'm going to do it. And I think — " She

pauses. "I think the other families need to know. The Lehtinens and the Saaris. They've been carrying this too. Not the same way the Hietalas have, but — "

"You want to tell them."

"I think they should know what's happening. What I'm going to do." She looks at the list of names on the table. "They can do what they want with it. But I'm not going to make a decision that affects all of them without telling them first."

Mikko is quiet for a long moment. "I can talk to the Saari man," he says. "Erik Saari. I know him better than you do. It might go better coming from me."

"Would you?"

"Yes." He picks up his coffee. Sets it down. "This is going to be — not everyone is going to want this."

"I know."

"Some people are going to be angry."

"I know that too."

He looks at her with an expression she is starting to recognize — not quite admiration, something more complicated than that, something that has to do with having watched this property and this family from a distance his whole life and now watching the last Hietala decide to do what none of the others were able to. "Your father would have wanted this," he says. "I think. From what I knew of him."

She thinks of the last ledger entry. *Tired*. And before it, the entry from the summer she was nineteen: *She is gone. I sat in the sauna all night*.

"He would have," she says. "He just couldn't get there himself."

They sit at the kitchen table with the documents between them and the afternoon light fading outside the window, and she thinks that she has been in this town for nearly three

weeks and has somehow, without planning to, found a person to carry this with her.

That is more than her father had.

That is more than Toivo had.

She gathers the documents carefully and puts them back in the oilcloth and ties the cord. She will return them to the root cellar for now. They are not hers to keep and not hers to throw away.

"Stay for dinner," she says.

CHAPTER 15

Spring Coming

It has been five weeks since her father died in his kitchen making coffee, and in those five weeks nobody has kept the watch.

She has been in the sauna twice — once to understand it, once to speak a name into the dark — but she has not done what her father did. Has not come down the hill every week, lit the stove, opened the hatch, sat in the heat and let whatever is below know that someone was still paying attention. The watch her great-grandfather started in 1919 and her grandfather maintained and her father kept for thirty years ended the morning Hank Hietala didn't show up at Hakala's and Paavo Maki let himself in through the unlocked back door.

She has felt the difference. The footprints in the snow under the kitchen window every morning, coming up from the lake, going nowhere, ending at the foundation. The knocking. The cold in the floor that no furnace explains.

The footprints are the worst of it, she thinks, until she decides the knocking is the worst of it, and then she stops ranking them.

Whatever patience Mindemoyen had, a hundred years of it, is running out.

The forecast comes in on a Saturday — unseasonable warmth pushing up from the south, temperatures climbing into the high thirties by the middle of the week, possibly touching forty by Thursday. The meteorologist on the Iron Mountain station stands in front of a map smeared orange

where it ought to be white and calls it the warmest March stretch on record for the region, the earliest thaw they've seen in forty years. He says it the way a man says a thing he expects people to be glad about. He is wearing a short-sleeved shirt. Behind him, on the wall of the studio, somebody has hung a paper shamrock.

She watches the forecast on her father's television, in her father's chair, with her father's afghan over her knees, and feels something cold move through her that has nothing to do with the temperature outside.

She goes to the basement. The shelf where her father kept the ledgers is at the bottom of the stairs, where it has always been, the spines dated in his hand in grease pencil. She pulls the last five years and carries them up to the kitchen table and reads the March entries across those years by the overhead light, looking for what she already knows she will find.

It's there. Every year, in the entries from the third week of March onward, a note on ice thickness. He augered the same three holes — inlet, midwater, the deep end off the sauna — and wrote the numbers down in inches without comment, the way you record a thing you intend to outlive. The numbers decline across the years. The ice that ran twenty-four, twenty-six inches through early March five years ago is running eighteen, then sixteen, then fourteen. Last March he'd recorded twelve inches at the deep end and noted in the margin, the only year he wrote anything in the margin: *thinner than I have ever seen it this time of year.*

This March, if the forecast holds, there may not be safe ice at all by the end of the week.

She closes the last ledger and squares the stack and keeps her hand flat on the top cover for a while. Then she goes to

the phone.

She calls Mikko first.

"Have you seen the forecast?" she asks when he picks up.

A pause. "Yeah," he says. "I was going to call you."

"The ice is going to go early. Maybe by the weekend."

"I know." She can hear him thinking, the particular quality of his quiet, the breath he takes before he says a hard thing plainly. "You need to call Louise."

She calls Louise. She tells her about the forecast, about the ledger entries, about the pattern she's read across five years of her father's careful records — the numbers dropping, the margin note, the bare orange map on the television. Louise listens without interrupting. When the silence on the line stretches Aino realizes she has stopped talking and that she is gripping the receiver hard enough to feel it in her wrist.

"Wednesday," Louise says at last. "We'll come Wednesday. That's as early as I can arrange it. There are people who have to be asked, and a thing like this is not asked quickly."

"Wednesday," Aino says.

"Wednesday. Hold the days until then."

Four days.

She thinks four days is manageable. She has held harder things than four days. She has held a man's affairs and a man's house and a man's hundred-year list, and four days is a number, and numbers she can do.

She is wrong about this, though not in the way she expects. The days are not the problem. The nights are.

—

It starts at midnight.

She knows it is midnight because she is awake to hear the beginning of it, which she has not been on the other nights —

the other nights it was already going when she surfaced into it, already established, as though it had been there a while before she noticed and her noticing was beside the point. This time she is lying in her childhood bed in the dark with her eyes open, listening to the furnace cycle and the drip starting at the south eave, and the house settling, and she hears the clock in the front room begin its twelve and somewhere under the twelfth stroke the first knock comes up through the floor.

Three knocks. Then nothing.

She lies still. She tells herself it is the furnace, the expansion of a duct, the well pump kicking on against a cold line. She knows the sounds this house makes. She has known them her whole life, has slept through every one of them in this bed, and none of them is this.

Three knocks again.

She counts the gap between the sets in her head, the way you'd count anything you wanted to keep at arm's length, and she gets to a number, and she does not trust the number because she counted it lying down in the dark with her heart going. So she gets up.

She does not turn on the bedside lamp. She crosses to the bedroom door in her socks and her father's old flannel shirt that she has been sleeping in, and the floor is cold, colder near the door, and she stands in the doorway and listens to the next set with her bare logic intact and her feet on the boards.

Three knocks. The boards carry it into the soles of her feet. It is below her. It is below the house, in the floor of the lake, and the floor of the lake is a quarter mile downhill from the bedroom, and there is no way for a sound made in the floor of the lake to arrive in the soles of her feet, and it arrives in the soles of her feet.

She turns on the light.

The bulb is unkind and ordinary and the room is just the room — the dresser, the mirror gone grey at one corner, the water stain on the ceiling shaped like the lower peninsula that she used to find the upper in when she was small. Three knocks. She goes to the kitchen and turns that light on too, and the porch light, and the front room lamp, until the house is lit up like something is wrong, which it is.

She puts the kettle on. Not because she wants tea. Because the gesture is normal and her hands know how to do it and while she is doing it she is a person standing at a stove at midnight and not a person listening to the floor.

Three knocks. The pause. She watches the second hand on the kitchen clock and counts the pause against it.

Seven seconds.

She watches the next pause. Seven seconds. The next. Seven seconds. Not about seven. Not seven, give or take. Seven, on the sweep of the second hand, every time, the way a thing keeps time when it has all the time there is and means to spend it precisely. The precision is worse than randomness. Randomness she could lay at the door of the house, the ice, the cold, her own frayed nerves filling a quiet with pattern. This is a count. Something is counting. Something below the floor of the lake is keeping a beat as exact as the clock on her wall and it knows she is awake and listening, and it is in no hurry, and it is not going to stop.

She thinks: I will not listen to it. I will read.

She gets the ledgers back out and opens the most recent one to the spring she missed and reads her father's hand and after a while she realizes she has read the same line four times and that each time her eye reached the end of the line it went to the clock and counted the next seven and that she has

not taken in a single word. She closes the ledger.

She thinks: I will call Mikko.

The phone is on the wall by the back door. She crosses the kitchen to it and lifts the receiver and gets the dial tone, that flat steady note, and she puts her finger in the dial for the first number of his — and the knocking comes, three, up through the floor at the base of the door not three feet from where she is standing, and she takes her finger out of the dial.

It is past midnight. It is past midnight on a Saturday and Mikko has an early start in the morning and a body that needs sleep, and there is nothing he can do about the floor that she cannot do, which is nothing. She is not going to be a woman who calls a man at midnight because the dark is loud. She hangs up the phone. She stands with her hand on the receiver for a moment longer than that decision required, and then she takes it away.

Three knocks. Seven seconds. Three knocks.

She makes a circuit of the house instead. Front room to hall to bedroom to kitchen and back, slow, the way you'd walk a fence line, checking what there is to check — the locks, all of them, the back door bolt thrown and the knob testing solid, the front door, the basement door at the top of its stairs. The windows latched. There is nothing to find. She finds it all anyway, each lock confirmed, and the confirming does nothing for the knocking and she knows it will do nothing and she does it because the alternative is to sit still, and she cannot sit still.

She gets thirsty. She doesn't notice getting thirsty; she notices that she has filled a glass at the tap and drunk it and filled it again, and that her mouth is dry the way it gets when you have been breathing through it, fast, for a long time. She makes herself slow down on the water. She makes herself

slow down on the walking. She gets her coat off the hook by the door — not to go out, there is no going out, but because the house is cold now in a way the furnace is not catching and the coat is the warmth she has — and she puts it over her shoulders without her arms in the sleeves and sits down at the kitchen table where she can see two doors and the dark window over the sink and she stays there.

The clock says one. The knocking does not change. Three and seven and three. She does not count the sets. She had counted them on other nights, fifty and then a hundred, had written the running total on the back of an envelope as if the number were a thing she could present to someone, evidence, a receipt. Tonight she does not write anything down. The number is not the point and she knows it is not the point. The point is the seven seconds. The point is that something is patient enough to wait exactly seven seconds, a hundred times, a thousand times, and was patient enough to wait a hundred years, and her father sat in the heat once a week for thirty years so that the seven seconds would stay seven seconds and never become six.

The clock says two.

She gets up and turns the radio on, low, the AM station out of Marquette that plays old country all night for the truckers, and a man with a voice like gravel sings about a town he is never going back to, and for three or four songs the knocking is one sound among others and she can almost. She can almost. Then the song ends and there is the dead air the station leaves between cuts and into the dead air comes three knocks and seven seconds and three knocks and she reaches over and turns the radio off because it is worse, somehow, to give it the chance.

The clock says three. She is standing at the sink with both hands flat on the cold steel of it, looking at her own face in the black window, and she thinks of her father standing where she is standing, how many times, three in the morning with the watch broken open in his chest, and no one in the house to know. And something rises in her while she stands there — not a thought, a word, one of her grandmother's, the kind Aili used to say low over a child who couldn't sleep — and she does not let it out. She doesn't know she is keeping it. She only knows that her mouth has closed around it and held. She had thought the watching was vigilance — a man going down a hill to a stove, a chore handed father to son like the woodpile and the well. She understands now, with her hands on the steel and the count coming up through the floor, that it was endurance, and that endurance is a separate thing from courage, slower and lonelier, and that she has no measure for what thirty years of it cost a man who never once said a word about it at a dinner table.

The clock says four. The drip has stopped at the eave; the temperature has fallen back overnight the way it does, the thaw a daytime promise only, and the cold has come up to meet it. Three knocks. Seven seconds. She has stopped flinching at them. This frightens her more than the flinching did — that the body, given enough of a thing, will make room for it, will file it under the ordinary, will let her sit at a table at four in the morning with a count coming up through the floor and think about whether there is enough coffee. There is enough coffee. She does not make it yet. Making it would be conceding the night, and she is not conceding the night; she is outlasting it.

The clock says five. The window over the sink is still black but it is a different black, the flat dead black of deep night

giving over to the grained black that comes before grey. Three knocks. Seven seconds. Three knocks.

She stands at the window and watches the black go grey at the bottom, over the trees, over the lake she cannot see but knows is there, and she counts — not the sets, she has not counted the sets in hours — she counts the lightening, the slow filling of the world back in. The dresser comes back. The fence comes back. The shape of the woodshed comes back. Three knocks. Seven seconds. The grey reaches the top of the trees and the trees separate from the sky and become individual trees, and the snow in the yard goes from a smear to a surface, and somewhere a crow says the one thing crows say, and —

three knocks —

seven seconds —

two knocks.

And nothing.

She waits. She stands at the window and waits for the third knock with the whole front of her body and it does not come. The seven seconds passes, and the next seven, and the next, and the third knock of that set does not come and no new set begins. It has stopped between the second and the third knock, in the middle of its own count, the way a man stops talking when someone calls his name from the next room. Not finished. Interrupted. Cut off mid-stride and gone, leaving the third knock owed and unpaid and hanging in the floor where she can feel the shape of it, the absence of it, the seven seconds it never got to.

Outside the window it is morning. The crow says its thing again.

—

She makes the coffee.

She does it the way she does everything in this kitchen now, by the route her father wore into it — the percolator from the second shelf, the grounds in the basket, the water to the line, the basket seated and the lid down and the knob to the click. The blue flame. The first knock and hiss of the water taking the heat. She stands at the stove and watches it climb to its rhythm and her hands are steady. She holds one out flat over the burner and looks at it and it does not shake.

She is surprised by this. She examines the surprise the way she examines the steadiness, turning it over, and decides it is not nothing — that a hand that does not shake at six in the morning after that night is a hand that has decided something the rest of her has not caught up to yet.

The percolator finds its tempo and holds it. Outside the light comes up grey and then, briefly, gold along the tops of the trees, the sun clearing the ridge across the lake, the snow on the yard going pink and then white and then, in the patches the day will get to first, beginning very faintly to shine. The thaw, coming back. The orange map. Four days down to three sometime in the next hour, when the day turns over into Sunday all the way and the count begins again.

She thinks about the third knock that never came. She does not like what it tells her — that the thing in the floor can stop when it chooses and choose not to finish, that the stopping was a stopping and not an ending, that it will be there again at midnight with its seven seconds intact and the owed knock waiting. Three more nights of this. She does not let her mind run forward past the three. She has learned that much from her father's ledger, from a man who augered three holes and wrote three numbers and did not write a word about how he felt doing it: you keep the watch one night at a

time, and you do not let the size of the whole thing into the room with you, because the whole thing will not fit, and trying to make it fit is how a man breaks.

She pours the coffee. She wraps both hands around the cup and feels the heat come into her palms, real heat, kitchen heat, the ordinary warmth of a thing she made.

She is the last Hietala. Her great-grandfather started the watch and her grandfather kept it and her father kept it for thirty years and died with it broken in his chest, and there is no one left to hand it to, and Louise comes Wednesday, and between now and Wednesday there is a count coming up through the floor of the lake every night, patient and exact and a hundred years angry, and it is going to do everything it can to find the place in her where she gives.

It will not find it tonight. The sun is coming up gold over the trees and the coffee is hot in her hands and her hands are steady. Whatever breaks before Wednesday, it is not going to be her.

She drinks the coffee while it is hot. The day, when it gets going, is going to be warm.

CHAPTER 16

The Families

She and Mikko go to the Lehtinen house Sunday afternoon, while the knocking from the night before is still present in her body, in the specific way that a sound you've heard all night doesn't leave when it stops but settles into you and keeps going at a frequency only you can feel.

The Lehtinens are over toward Crystal Falls, a half hour of two-lane that the thaw has turned dark and wet down the wheel ruts, the snowbanks along the shoulder slumped and grey and pulling away from the asphalt the way old caulk pulls away from a window. Water stands in the low spots. Mikko drives around the worst of it without comment. Aino watches the country go by — the trailers, the woodpiles, the sugar shacks not yet tapped — and thinks it looks like every March she has ever seen here and is not, underneath, anything like them.

Marta Lehtinen answers the door. A woman in her sixties, heavyset, careful eyes, an apron on over a Sunday cardigan as though they have caught her between one task and another. She looks at Aino for a moment before she looks at Mikko, and Aino understands from the look that Marta knows who she is — knows the face, or the name, or the shape of what the name carries — and that the knowing does not make her glad.

"Aino Hietala," Marta says. Not a question.

"Yes."

"You'd better come in, then."

The kitchen is warm and smells of coffee and of something baked earlier in the day, cardamom, the *pulla* gone now but

the smell of it still in the walls. Her brother Juhani is at the table with a cup in front of him and the expression of a man who has been told something he didn't want to know and is still deciding how to hold it. He is older than Marta, thin where she is heavy, with big spotted hands flat on the oilcloth. He does not get up. He nods at Mikko, whom he knows, and at Aino, whom he does not, and goes back to looking at his coffee.

Marta makes coffee for the new arrivals because it is what is done. She does not ask whether they want it. She sets the cups out, and the cream in its glass pitcher, and a plate she does not need to set out but does, and only when everyone has a cup in front of them does she sit, and then there is the small ordinary silence of four people at a table with nothing to do but say the thing.

Aino says it.

She tells them everything. Not the careful version, not the version she'd told before that left out the worst of it — she tells them about the watch her great-grandfather started and her father kept and how it ended the morning her father died in this same kind of kitchen making this same coffee. She tells them about the footprints coming up from the lake to the foundation and going nowhere. She tells them about the knocking, three and then the pause and then three, and about the seven seconds, and she watches Juhani's hand go still on the oilcloth when she says the seven seconds. She tells them about the cold in the floor that no furnace explains, and about the forecast, the orange map, the ice running thinner every March in her father's own numbers, fourteen inches and then twelve and now whatever it is, going. She tells it plainly because there is no time left for careful.

When she finishes the kitchen is very quiet. Out the window over the sink a line of melt runs off the eave in a thin steady rope and ticks into a pail somebody has set there to catch it.

Marta has both hands around her cup. "My father told us some of it," she says. "Not all. Enough that when I was a girl I was afraid of that lake and didn't have a word for why." She looks at her brother. "Juhani had it worse."

Juhani sets his cup down.

"What are you asking us to do," he says.

"Stand at the shore on Wednesday. That's all."

He looks at her, and she can see him deciding something, running calculations she isn't privy to. He is quiet long enough that the pail ticks twice more. When he speaks it comes slow, the words set down one at a time the way his hands are set down on the table.

"My grandfather is dead," he says. "He's been dead for thirty years. He never told me what he did — my father told me, and my father only told me because he was dying and couldn't carry it out the door with him. My grandfather died without ever saying a word about it to anyone. Sat in this family for fifty years like a stone in a coat pocket and never once put it on the table." He pauses. "I've spent thirty years being angry at a dead man. Which is a very particular kind of useless. You can't get anywhere with it. You can't make him answer. You can't even make him sorry, because for all I know he was sorry every day of his life and just never said, and that's the worst of the two, not knowing which it was."

"Juhani," Marta says quietly.

"I'm not refusing." He says it to his sister first and then to Aino, turning the cup a quarter-turn on its saucer as he does, an old man's small habit. "I'm just saying. A man waits thirty

years to be asked to do a thing, he's allowed a minute to say what it was like, waiting." He picks up the coffee again. "Wednesday. We'll be there. Both of us. What time."

"First light."

He nods. "First light. We'll be there before the sun's up. I've been up before the sun every day of my life; one more won't hurt me." Something moves at the corner of his mouth that on a less tired man might have been the start of a smile and is not, quite. "Tell the Saaris, did you?"

"Tomorrow," Aino says. "We're going tomorrow."

Marta and Juhani look at each other across the table, and Aino sees the look and does not understand it yet, and lets it go by.

"Mm," Juhani says, and that is all he says about the Saaris.

—

The Saari property she leaves until Monday, because there is an order to these things and because some part of her wanted the easier visit first, the way you take the smaller of two hard calls first to learn how to make the larger one. Mikko comes by in the morning. He drives. The Saaris are on the north end of the lake, the far end, the end her father's sauna looks at across a quarter mile of ice on the rare days the air is clear enough to see that far.

On the way he tells her what he knows about Erik Saari. Seventies, retired off the mine and then off twenty more years of small engine repair he did out of a shed. Widower — wife died four years ago, cancer, the slow kind, and Erik nursed her through it himself and came out the other side of it quieter than he went in. Keeps mostly to himself. Has a way of looking at the lake, Mikko says, that Mikko has always understood without having the words for it, and now that he's

older he thinks he has a few of the words and wishes he didn't.

"And there's a brother," Mikko says, after a stretch of road.

"A brother."

"Reino. Younger. Five, six years younger." Mikko's mouth does a thing. "He's a different animal. You'll see if he's around. Hope he's not."

The Saari place comes up on the left, set back off the road behind a stand of bare birch — a low house, a barn gone to a lean, a yard kept the way Erik keeps things, which is to say kept. A dog comes off the porch and stops at the edge of the yard and barks twice without much in it and then just watches.

Erik is outside splitting wood. He works in the methodical way of a man who has split a great many cords, the maul up and the maul down and the round falling open in two clean halves and the next round set up on the block without a wasted motion, and he watches the truck come in with the same stillness, the maul resting head-down on the block and his hand on the haft. But when he sees Aino get out of the truck something changes in his face. Not fear, exactly. More like recognition — the look of a man who has been waiting for a knock at the door and has just heard the car that brings it.

He has felt the cold too. She can see it on him the way she saw it on Juhani.

He sets the maul against the block. "Hietala," he says, the same way Marta said it. Then, after a beat, to Mikko: "Mikko." And then he opens the porch door and holds it, which is the whole of his invitation, and they go inside.

The house is clean and spare and a little too quiet, a house run by one person who used to be two. He puts coffee on without asking, the way Marta did, and while it heats he sits

down across from her at the table with his hands flat on his knees and his eyes on a point past her shoulder, and she tells it again. The full version. The watch, the footprints, the knocking, the count. He listens without moving. When she gets to the seven seconds he closes his eyes briefly, just for a moment, the way a man does when a doctor names the thing he already knew the name of, and she understands that he has heard it too, that it has come up to him across the ice from wherever he sleeps on the north end of this lake, three knocks and seven seconds, faint maybe but his.

When she finishes he is quiet for a long time. The coffee comes to its boil behind him and he gets up and pours it and sets the cups down and sits again before he says anything.

"No," he says.

She waits.

"I'm not going to stand on that shore," he says. "I'm not going to stand there and — perform something. My grandfather is dead. What he did is done. Standing on a shore doesn't undo it."

"Nobody said it undoes it," Mikko says carefully.

"Then what does it do?"

The room is very quiet. Out the window the bare birches are still. Beyond them the lake, and on the lake, faint, the first dark lines she has been watching come and go on her own end — cracks opening in the white where the thaw is getting down into the ice and working it, thin as pencil yet, nothing like the webbing she half expects to see by the end of the week, but there, and not where March cracks belong. She makes herself not look at them too long.

"What does it *do*," Erik says again, lower.

And before anyone can answer there is a truck in the yard.

The dog does not bark at it. Erik's shoulders set. A door slams, and boots come up the porch, and a man lets himself in without knocking — younger than Erik but not young, hard through the shoulders, a face that is Erik's face with the patience taken out of it and something else put in its place. He stops in the kitchen doorway and takes in the table, the cups, the strangers, and his eyes land on Aino and stay there.

"Reino," Erik says. "We've got company."

"I see that." Reino does not sit. He leans on the doorframe with his arms crossed and looks at Aino the way you look at a thing somebody's trying to sell you. "Hietala. Sure. Come up here to tell us about the lake." He says *the lake* the way another man might say a curse. "Heard the speech yet?" he asks Erik, not taking his eyes off her. "The standing-on-the-shore speech?"

"We were getting to it," Mikko says.

"I'll save you the time." Reino comes off the doorframe. "Wednesday. First light. Everybody lines up on the ice and holds hands and the Indians do a thing and we all feel better and the lake's our friend again. That about it?"

"That's not it," Aino says.

"It's close enough." He is not loud. That is the thing she notices, the thing that makes him worse than loud — there is no heat in it, or there is heat under it but he has it banked, controlled, the way Erik has the wood under control. "My grandfather drowned a woman in that lake. So they tell it. I never met him. I never met her. And I'm supposed to go stand on a shore at dawn and *acknowledge* it." The word comes out with the bark off. "You know what that does? Nothing. You want to know what stops a thing? You stop it. You don't ask it nice. You don't wait till Wednesday because somebody downstate has to be *asked* first, and asked on their own

schedule. Three days. We sit on our hands for three more days because that's the polite thing. You've had it in your floor every night. How many more nights you want."

"None," Aino says.

"None." He nods like she's proved his point. "Me neither. So why are we waiting."

"Because there's a way it's done," Mikko says. "And the way it's done is theirs to lead, not ours."

"The way it's *done*." Reino looks at his brother. "Erik. Tell me you're not buying this. Standing on a shore. You've been hearing it all week, same as me, worse than me, you're closer. You going to fix it by standing still?"

Erik does not answer right away. His hands are flat on the table. "I haven't decided what I'm doing," he says.

"That's a no with a hat on." Reino reaches over and takes a heel of bread off the counter as if he owns the place, which in some old way he half does, and turns it over in his hand and doesn't eat it. "I'll tell you what's getting done. That ice is going by Wednesday or Thursday, your own forecast says so. When it goes, the water opens up. And a thing that lives in the water under the ice, you've got a window, right there, while it's between. You don't stand on the shore and watch the window close. You go to the water and you end it." He sets the bread down. "I'm not going to a funeral for a hundred-year-old crime and calling it fixed. I'm done waiting. I've been done waiting a while."

"Reino," Erik says.

"Don't." He is already moving toward the door. "You do your Wednesday. Stand there with the woman and the Lehtinens and whoever else. I'll handle the part that handles itself." At the door he stops and looks back at Aino, and for one moment there is something under the contempt that is

not contempt at all, that is closer to what she saw in Juhani — thirty years of it, fifty, grief gone hard from having nowhere to go. "You think it wants to be acknowledged," he says. "It doesn't want to be acknowledged. It wants what it wants. The difference is going to cost you."

The door bangs. The truck starts. The dog, outside, does not bark at it leaving either.

In the quiet after, the pencil-lines on the lake are exactly where they were, and the coffee has stopped steaming, and Erik Saari sits with his hands flat on the table and his eyes on the place where his brother was standing.

"He lost his boy to that lake," Erik says, to no one in particular. "Long time ago. Through the ice, December, before any of us knew what the ice was doing or why. Reino's never said the two things in the same breath — the boy and the woman. But he carries them in the same pocket. He's been carrying them a long time."

Nobody says anything.

"He won't wait," Erik says. It is not a question and it is not a warning, exactly; it is a man stating a fact about his brother that he has known longer than he has known these strangers. "He never has."

Then he is quiet for a very long time. Long enough that Aino thinks he is going to come back to his *no*, going to stand up and indicate the meeting is over. The melt ticks somewhere outside. The dog comes up onto the porch and lies down against the door with a thump she can feel through the floor, and the floor here is just a floor, just wood and a dog's weight on it, and she is grateful for that out of all proportion to what it is.

"What does it do," Erik says. Back to his question, but the heat gone out of it; he is asking now, not pushing. "Standing

there. I want a real answer. Not the speech my brother thinks you've got. The real one."

"It means not looking away," Mikko says. "It means your family was there and you're the one who's left and you show up. That's all. Whatever Louise Swifthawk's family does — that's theirs. We just stand there and we don't look away."

Erik looks at his hands. He is a big man, still solid despite his age, the kind who has dealt with hard things by dealing with them physically — the wood, the kept yard, the wife nursed through to the end, the life lived in deliberate order. She can see him trying to set this thing down in that order and finding that it will not lie flat.

"My grandfather wouldn't stand there," he says slowly. "If he were alive. He'd do what Reino's going to do. Or he'd do nothing, which is what he did, all his life. Stand there or stand away — that's the choice in this family. There's never been a middle of it." He presses his hands flat against the table and looks at them a moment, the spread fingers, as if making sure of something under them. "I haven't slept well in a week."

"Neither have I," she says.

"No," he says. "I expect not." He looks up at her then, full on, for the first time since she came in. "What time."

"First light," she says. "Wednesday."

He nods once. It is not a warm nod. It is the nod of a man who has looked at something he has been avoiding for fifty years and decided, with great difficulty, to stop avoiding it — and underneath it, she thinks, a second decision he does not say out loud, which is to be the brother who stands and not the brother who goes to the water.

"I'll be there," he says. Then, after a moment, looking at the window, at the truck-shaped absence in the yard: "I don't know that I can answer for Reino."

"Nobody's asking you to," Mikko says.

"I know." Erik keeps looking at the window. "I'm telling you anyway."

—

In the truck driving back the relief she expected doesn't come. She had thought that getting all four families to yes would feel like setting something down. It does not. It feels like she has spent two days carrying the same weight up to two more doors and that the weight is now larger, because she is carrying Reino in it too — the truck banging out of the yard, *the difference is going to cost you*, a man who will not wait three days for a thing that has waited a hundred years.

"That went about how I figured," Mikko says.

"Erik said yes."

"Erik said yes." He drives a while. "Reino's the one to watch. The families are going to have to sit down before Wednesday and get straight with each other — who's doing what, who's standing where. There's two minds about it now and there can't be two minds about it on Wednesday." He glances at her. "Tonight, maybe. Get everybody in one room while Erik's still got the warm of saying yes on him. Before Reino gets to him again."

"Tonight," she says.

The lake goes by on the left, between the trees, then open along the western shore. The melt is running off every roof they pass and standing in every ditch, and the sky has come down low and grey and close, and the snowbanks are dark and slumping, and the whole country has the wet heavy smell of a thing thawing that does not yet know whether it is the smell of spring or of something opening that should have stayed shut. Out on the white she can see the lines from the

road, faint, here and there, the thaw getting its fingers into the ice.

She thinks about her father. All the nights he drove this road in the dark, down to the sauna, to sit in the heat above the water and keep the thing below aware of his presence, his name, his attendance. Thirty years of it. Alone. And it occurs to her, watching the cracks come and go between the trees, that her father was the only one of all of them who chose the middle of it — not standing on the shore and not going to the water, but sitting in the heat, week after week, holding the line where it was. She does not know yet whether that was the brave thing or only the longest way of doing nothing. She thinks her father did not know either. She thinks that is why he never said a word.

"One more night," Mikko says.

"One more night," she says, and does not say what she is thinking, which is that one more night assumes that everyone waits for Wednesday, and that she has just met a man who will not.

One more night, if they are lucky. She is no longer sure they are going to be lucky.

CHAPTER 17

The Convening

They come after dark, the way these things are done up here — not at a set hour, no one having said one, but in the loose window between supper and bed when a person can leave the house without it meaning anything to the neighbors. The Lehtinens first, Marta's car with Juhani in the passenger seat, the headlights swinging across the kitchen wall as they turn in off the road. Then Erik's truck, ten minutes behind, and behind that, before Aino has the door shut on Erik, a second set of lights that slows at the mailbox and sits there a moment in the dark with the engine running, deciding, and then turns in too.

Reino. Erik glances back at it on the porch and says nothing. Aino does not ask. She holds the door.

It is the first time in her life she has had four people in this house who were not family, and it occurs to her, taking coats, that it may be the first time in the house's life. Eino built it to keep to itself. Her father kept it that way. She hangs Marta's coat on a peg that has held one coat, her father's brown wool, since November, and she thinks: a hundred years of the door shut, and tonight it stands open and the cold comes in on five people who all know why.

She makes coffee because it is what is done. Mikko gets the chairs — the two from the bedrooms, the stool from the workshop — and they crowd them around the kitchen table that was built for two. There are not enough cups that match. Nobody remarks on it. Reino does not sit. He stands by the door with his back to the counter and his arms crossed, the

way he stood in Erik's kitchen, and he keeps his coat on.

"All right," Juhani says, when the cups are down. "Let's have it. What is it we're agreeing to."

So she lays it out. Plainly, the way Louise laid it out for her, the way she has learned this week is the only way that holds. First light Wednesday, all of them at the shore — her shore, below the sauna, where the footprints come up. They stand. That is the whole of their part. What Louise's people do, Louise's people lead, and the families defer to it; that is theirs, not ours, and no one asks past that line. Aino gives back the records — the ledgers, the notebooks, the things her father kept in the cold — because those are the woman's history and the woman's history belongs with her people. And the sauna comes down after, when Louise tells her it is time, by fire most likely, because it is a sauna and saunas burn.

"Stand where," Marta says.

"On the shore. Wherever there's room. It's not a — there's no arrangement to it." She hears how thin that sounds. "We just don't look away."

Marta nods slowly, both hands around her cup. Juhani turns his a quarter-turn on the table, the old habit, and says, "And that's it. We stand on the ice in the dark in March and we don't look away."

"Not the ice," Erik says. "The shore. You don't want to be on that ice Wednesday." He says it flatly, a man who has been watching his own end of the lake. "It won't hold by then."

"The shore," Aino says.

Reino makes a sound by the counter. Not a word. Just air, pushed out through the nose, the sound of a man who has heard enough to confirm what he came knowing.

It is Marta who breaks it open. Aino would not have guessed it would be her — would have put money on Juhani, who had thirty years of it banked. But it is Marta, setting her cup down, who says into the small kitchen, not loud:

"My father told me it was four men."

The room goes still in a way the room has not been still all evening.

"He never named the fourth," Marta says. "Said three and then stopped, and I always thought he didn't know it, and then I got older and understood he knew it and wouldn't say it because the fourth was nobody. The fourth line died out. Risto Mäkelä's boy, no sons." She glances at Mikko, who carries that blood from the side that lived. "I'm sorry. I don't mean nobody."

"No," Mikko says. "I know what you mean."

"Four men," Juhani says. He has both spotted hands flat on the oilcloth now. "Eino Hietala. The Lehtinen — that's my grandfather. Saari." He does not look at Erik when he says it. "And the Mäkelä. In the fall. Nineteen and nineteen. They went out to a cabin." He stops. The melt is not ticking tonight; the night has gone cold again and the eaves have stopped running, and the quiet where that sound should be is its own thing in the room. "That's as far as my father ever got. They went out to a cabin and after that there was a watch on the lake and a sauna that wasn't a sauna, and the Hietalas kept it, and the rest of us kept our mouths shut and let them."

"My father said the same," Erik says. Low. "Almost word for word. They went out to a cabin." He keeps both hands flat on the table and does not touch the cup. "Fifty years I've had that sentence and never the end of it. A man learns not to

want the end of a sentence like that."

And there it is — the thing she did not expect, the strange heavy ease of it once the first plain words are out. Not relief, exactly; relief is too clean a word for what moves through the kitchen. It is more like the give in a frozen door when the second person leans on it: a hundred years of weight against the inside of it, four families each with a shoulder to it alone in the dark, and now all the shoulders at once and the thing finally moving. Nobody is comforted. Everybody is, somehow, lighter, and ashamed of the lightness, and saying it anyway because there is no one left to keep it from.

"A woman," Marta says quietly. "It was a woman they — " She does not finish that one either.

"Elderly," Aino says. "She lived alone on the land my great-grandfather claimed. She wouldn't leave. They went out there in the fall, four of them, and she died, and they put her in the lake." She says it the way Louise said it to her, the flat way that is the only honest way, and she watches it go around the table and land on each of them in turn — Juhani's jaw, Marta's hands, Erik's gone-still face. They knew. Every one of them knew the shape of it. But the shape said aloud in one room, by all of them together, is not the shape carried alone, and she sees it reach them as a new thing even though it is the oldest thing any of them owns.

"They never told us her name," Marta says. It is half a question, the closest these people will come to asking.

Aino sets her cup down. She has carried the name since Louise gave it to her across a coffee table in Tamarack — has held it in her mouth a hundred times alone in this house and never let it out, the way her father and his father held the whole of it, the way the door stayed shut.

"Her name was Mindemoyen," she says.

It is not loud. She does not make it loud. She says it the way you set something down that you have carried a long way, carefully, on a flat surface, so that it will not tip.

The kitchen takes it in. No one repeats it. Marta's eyes are wet and she does not wipe them. Juhani looks at his hands. It is, Aino knows — the certainty arriving plainly, the way the cold arrives — the first time the woman's name has been spoken in this house in a hundred years, or in any of their houses, or among these families, who had her death between them all that time and never the one word that would have made her a person. Eino did not write it. Her father did not say it. And now it is in the room, four syllables in a cold kitchen, and the room is not the same room it was.

"Mindemoyen," Marta says, finally, very low. Saying it once, the way you say a name at a graveside.

"Yes."

—

Then the floor knocks.

Three times. Even, spaced, hard — coming up through the boards under the table from somewhere below the foundation, somewhere below the basement, somewhere there is nothing to knock. The cups go quiet. Aino feels it more than hears it, in her feet, in the legs of her chair.

A pause.

She knows the pause. She has lived inside it for a week. She counts it without deciding to, the way she always does now — one, two, three — and across the table she sees Juhani counting it too, his lips not moving, his eyes on the middle of the table, and she watches him reach seven the same instant she does —

— three more. The same three, the same weight, up through the floor.

Nobody moves. Marta's hand has stopped on her cup. Erik has gone the stillness of the man splitting wood with the maul resting, the stillness of a body waiting to know which way to break. The cold comes up off the boards in the held quiet, a flat lake-cold pushing out across the floor and finding their ankles one by one, and Aino sees them feel it — sees Marta's feet draw back under her chair, sees Juhani's hand close.

"That's it," Aino says, into the silence. Her own voice is steady and she is glad of it. "That's what's been in my floor every night."

"Lord God," Marta says, almost without breath.

Three knocks. The pause. The count. Three more. It is not the siege — she does not have the word for it yet but she knows this is the smaller version, the evening version, the thing announcing itself rather than the thing throwing its whole weight, and even so it has emptied the kitchen of everything but itself. Juhani has the look of a man who has spent thirty years angry at a dead grandfather and has just understood, finally, in his feet, that the grandfather was real and so is the rest of it. Erik's eyes are closed. He is listening to it the way he listened in his own kitchen when she said the seven seconds — the way a man listens to a thing he was hoping he had invented.

It goes a while. Then it thins, and stops, the way it stops in the morning, between one knock and the one that does not come.

The kitchen sits in what is left.

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It is Reino who speaks first, and his voice is wrong for the room — ordinary, level, loud only by being normal in a place that has gone past normal.

"And that," he says, "is the thing you're going to stand on a shore and *nod at*."

Erik says, "Reino."

"No." He comes off the counter. He has heard it now too — she watched him hear it, watched even Reino go still while the floor counted — and where it has cracked the others open, it has closed him like a fist. "You all felt that. That's not grief looking to be acknowledged. You acknowledge a thing that's *done*. That" — he points down, at the floor, at the boards — "is not done. That is beating on the underside of this woman's house at" — he checks nothing, he does not need to — "nine at night on a Monday. And the plan is sunrise Wednesday we go down to the water and *witness* it." He says the word the way he said *the lake* in his brother's kitchen, with the bark off. "Two more nights of that. Because somebody downstate hasn't finished getting ready."

"That's theirs to lead," Mikko says. "We've been over it."

"I heard you the first time." He looks around the table, at the wet-eyed woman and the old men and the spread hands, and what is on his face is not heat. That is still the worst of it. It is contempt gone cold and certain, a man who has made up his mind so long ago that the meeting was only ever going to confirm it. "You want to know what I think you are. I think you're four people who've spent your whole lives being ashamed and you finally found a way to feel ashamed *together*, in a kitchen, with coffee, and you've mistaken that for doing something." He picks his cap up off the counter. "Standing on a shore at dawn with your hat in your hand is not doing something. It's the same nothing your grandfathers

did, with better manners on it."

"Reino," Erik says again, and there is something under it now, his voice come down low. "Don't."

Reino looks at his brother a long moment. Erik lost his wife slow and came out quiet; Reino lost a boy fast, through ice, before any of them knew what the ice was, and never put the boy and the woman in the same sentence and has carried them in the same pocket ever since. None of that is said. It does not need to be. It is in the two faces, the same face with the patience taken out of one of them.

"You stand there and nod, then," Reino says. Quiet. Final. "I'll be doing the other thing." He puts the cap on. "Somebody's got to."

He goes. The door, when he opens it, lets the real cold in, the March cold, ordinary and clean, and then he is on the porch and down the steps and the truck door opens and shuts and the engine turns over and the headlights swing back across the kitchen wall and away.

Erik does not go after him. He sits with his cup and his eyes on the door, and he does not get up, and that is the thing Aino will remember — that the brother who could have gone after him chose, in front of all of them, not to. Because there was no point. Because they all knew it. Because the man who left is not going to be argued back across a threshold by anybody, least of all the brother who has spent a lifetime failing to.

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The door is shut. The kitchen holds five people where a minute ago it held six, and the missing one is louder than the rest of them.

"He's going to do something," Marta says. Not to anyone. The way Erik said it in his own kitchen. *He won't wait.*

"Yes," Erik says.

Nobody says what. Nobody knows what, exactly, and Aino understands that the not-knowing is part of it now — that they will all of them, tonight and tomorrow, be living inside the gap where Reino's plan is, listening for it the way she has learned to listen for the floor.

The coffee has gone cold in the unmatched cups. The eaves are not running. Out the window over the sink the night is hard and still and starless, and somewhere across the dark of it the ice is taking the day's thaw back into itself, knitting shut for one more night the cracks that will not knit much longer.

"Wednesday," Juhani says, at last, the word set down one at a time. "First light. We'll be there. All of us that are coming." He looks at the door Reino went out of, and then away from it. "It'll have to be enough."

Aino does not say whether it will. She does not know. She gathers the cold cups, because it is what is done, and stands at the sink with the cold water running over her hands, and counts, without meaning to, the nights that are left.

Two. If they are lucky.

She is no longer sure they are going to be lucky.

CHAPTER 18

The Snowmobiler

Mikko is at the door before eight, which is not when he comes. He comes at nine, with coffee, after his crew is set for the day; he is a man who puts the work in motion first and then attends to the rest. So when she hears the truck on the gravel before eight and looks out and sees him already out of it, not bringing anything in his hands, she knows it is something and goes to the door without her coat.

The morning is warm. That is the first wrong thing, though it is not new: the eave is running, the gravel is dark and wet where the snow has pulled back from it overnight, and the air coming off the lake has the soft rotten smell of March, of water working under ice. She has stopped being able to enjoy a warm morning. The warmth is a clock.

"Dale Numminen," Mikko says. He says the name the way you say a name you have just learned and already can't put down. "From over in Tioga. Went out on his sled last night and didn't come home. His wife called it in around five this morning." He looks at her. "They found the machine at the inlet."

She does not ask the next thing. She knows it the way she has come to know things this past week, below the level where questions live.

"Engine running," Mikko says anyway. "No sign of him."

She stands in the doorway with the warm wet air on her face and her hands going cold in it.

"I want to go down there," she says.

He doesn't tell her she shouldn't. That is one of the things about Mikko she has stopped being surprised by. He just looks at her for a second, deciding nothing she can see, and says, "Get your coat."

The inlet is on the north end, where the creek comes in, and even in deep winter it is the soft spot — her father augered it every year and wrote the smallest number there, always, because moving water never lets the ice get honest. She knows this the way she knows the lake's other facts now, from the ledgers, from a man's grease-pencil hand. A local would know it without the ledgers. A local would not cross there.

There are vehicles along the shoulder when they come up the inlet road. The county sheriff's truck, a township fire truck, two pickups she doesn't know and one she does, and an ambulance backed up to the turnaround with its rear doors open and nobody in any hurry around it, which tells her more than the open doors would. People who hurry around an ambulance are people who think there is a reason to. These men are moving at the speed of a thing already decided.

Mikko parks behind the fire truck and they walk down. Nobody stops them. A few of the men nod at Mikko, who knows everyone, who has poured foundations and pulled stumps for half the township and has the standing of a man you don't question at a shoreline. One of them, a big kid in fire department coveralls, says, "Mikko," and Mikko says, "Cal," and that is the whole of the permission they need.

The recovery is out maybe sixty feet. They have laid a ladder flat on the ice and run a line out past it, and two men in dry suits are working at the edge of a hole, and the hole is the thing she cannot look away from.

It is black. That is what gets into her. The ice around it is the gray-white of rotten March ice, soft-looking, sun-cupped, and the water in the hole is not gray and is not white; it is black, flat black, the black of the lake's own depth come up to the surface where it has no business being, and it does not move. The creek runs into the lake somewhere under there and you would think the water would show it, would carry some current at the surface, and it lies in the hole as still as something poured.

The snowmobile is already up. They have it on the ice off to the side, on its track, water sheeting off it and going to slush where it pools. She had thought — she doesn't know what she had thought. That it would be wrecked, somehow. It isn't. It is just a snowmobile, a red one, a few years old, sitting on the ice tilted slightly with meltwater running out of every seam of it, and a man at the back of it is bent down doing something with the cowl, and as she watches, the engine, which had been running when they found it, idling out here for hours over black water with no one on it, ticks and cools and is silent. Somebody had finally reached in and killed it. She had not known it was still running until it stopped.

She stands on the rotten ice in the warm air and looks at the red machine that ran all night with no one on it, and the cold goes up through the soles of her boots.

—

There is a glove on the ice.

It is by the hole, at the lip, where one of the dry-suit men has set the things they bring up out of the water before they go back down — a procedure, an order to it, items laid in a row on a tarp the way you'd lay out anything you meant to account for. A glove. Just the one. A good winter glove,

leather and insulation, the kind a careful man buys, and it is lying palm-down on the tarp with the water leaching out of it dark, and the fingers of it are slightly curled the way a glove curls when it has held a grip and been pulled off the hand still curled, and she looks at it and her stomach does a slow thing and she makes herself look at the water instead.

The dry-suit men go back down. One and then the other, into the black, and the line tender pays out the rope hand over hand, and the surface closes over them and lies flat again. Nobody on the shore says anything. The sheriff is up by the trucks talking to a man who must be a deputy, writing on a clipboard, and his voice carries down across the ice in pieces. *Spring ice. Inlet's always bad. Out-of-towner, wife says he didn't know the lake. Cut across to save the long way around the bay.* The deputy says something and the sheriff says, flat, not unkind, the verdict of a man who has stood at a lot of shorelines, "Accident. Plain accident. Happens every year somewhere."

It does happen every year somewhere. She knows that. Thin spring ice and a man in a hurry who didn't know which water to trust. It is the most ordinary death there is up here, ordinary as the warm wet wind, and the sheriff is right, and he is not right, and there is no version of the truth she could hand him that he could do anything with.

She looks at the black water where the two men went down to bring up a man who crossed the wrong water, and she does the thing she came down here to do, which she had not known was the thing until she is doing it.

She stops telling herself it is aimed.

For a week she has thought of it as aimed — at her, at the house, at the last name on a list. She had needed it to be aimed, because a thing that is aimed has a logic and a logic

has an end and the end is Wednesday. Standing on the inlet ice she understands that she had that wrong, or only half right, and the half she had wrong is the half that matters. Dale Numminen was not on the list. Dale Numminen was a man from the next township who took a shortcut across a bay on a warm night because the long way around is the long way around. There is no version of the hundred years that has his name in it. He crossed the wrong water at the worst place in the warmest March in forty years, and the wrong water took him, and it was not because of who he was. It was because of where he was, and when.

A hundred years of it, she thinks. A hundred years held down under a man in a sauna once a week, and now no man, and the warmth coming up out of the south, and the ice going honest all over the lake at once. It is not aiming anymore. It has stopped being able to aim, if it ever could, the way a thing that has been compressed for a century is not aiming when it finally comes apart — it is only coming apart, in every direction, into whatever happens to be there. And what happened to be there, last night, at the softest spot on the whole lake, was Dale Numminen.

She thinks: *she is in pain*. She thinks it plainly, standing in the wind, and lets it sit, the way her father let things sit in the ledger without a word in the margin. A hundred years in cold water with the wrong done and never undone, and the only ones who knew built a man's life around keeping her quiet and called it a watch. That is not patience. She had thought it was patience. It is pain that has been still for so long it learned to look like patience, and the stillness has broken, and pain that breaks does not aim. It just comes up. And anything in the water when it comes up is in the water when it comes up.

They bring him up while she is standing there. She does not see it, and she is glad, after, that she does not see it. The dry-suit men surface and there is a change in the men on the ice, a closing-in, the line tender and the kid named Cal and another man going to the hole and crouching, their backs to the shore, their bodies making a wall the way men's bodies do at a thing like this without anyone telling them to, and she understands from the wall what is happening on the other side of it and she turns and looks at the trees on the far shore instead.

Mikko's hand comes onto her shoulder. He doesn't say anything. His hand is warm and it stays.

Behind her there is the sound of the ambulance crew coming down at last, unhurried, with the long basket, and the careful low voices of men doing a thing they have done before and hate, and the creak of the rotten ice taking the weight, and she keeps her eyes on the far trees and does not turn around until the basket goes by behind her, and even then she only sees the shape of it under the blanket going up the bank, four men carrying, watching their feet on the soft ice, and that is all. That is all she lets herself have of it, and it is enough. It is more than enough. It will be in her for the rest of her life, the shape going up the bank under the blanket and the men watching their feet.

Dale Numminen. She has the name now. She will carry it. She thinks of the Hietalas carrying a name for a hundred years without ever once saying it out loud at a table, her great-grandfather and her grandfather and her father each in turn folding a dead woman's name into the marrow of an ordinary life and going down to a stove once a week and never

telling a soul, and she understands that this is how the name gets carried — not in a ledger, not in a margin, but like this, a shape under a blanket on a March morning that you were there to see and cannot put down. She is a carrier now. She joined them this morning, on the inlet ice, in the warm wrong wind.

The knocking, all week, had frightened her. The footprints, the cold in the floor, the count coming up at midnight seven seconds apart. She had been afraid the way you are afraid of a thing that wants to scare you. She is done being afraid that way. This is a different country and she has crossed into it standing on the ice. It is not trying to scare her. Being scared, it turns out, was the safe version, the version where the worst that happens is a bad night and a steady hand at dawn. The worst that happens is a red snowmobile idling all night over black water with the glove pulled off the hand, and a man from Tioga who never heard the name Mindemoyen going up a bank under a blanket. It can do that. It did that. It will do it again, to whoever is on the water, until Wednesday, and Wednesday is not soon enough, and there is nothing between now and Wednesday but the days, and the nights, and the count.

—

They drive back the long way, around the bay, the way Dale Numminen did not.

She does not go in when Mikko drops her. She tells him she will be fine, which is not a thing she believes, and he looks at her like he does not believe it either, and then he says he'll be back before dark and that she is not to be alone tonight, and she does not argue, because she does not want to be alone tonight and there is no use pretending otherwise to a

man who has had his hand on her shoulder at a recovery.

When the truck is gone she does not go in. She walks down across the yard to the sauna, in the warm air, with the snow gone slick and gray under her boots, and she stands outside the door of it with her hand flat on the cedar wall the way she has done before. The wood is cold. The day is warm and the wood is cold, and under her feet, down through the slumping snow and the frozen ground and the soft going-honest ice, there is the thing she has no word for except that it knows she is standing there. It counts her. She is on the list and Dale Numminen never was, and it took Dale Numminen anyway, and she stands with her cold hand on the cold wood and does not take it away.

"One more day," she says to the wall. She says it the way you say a number you mean to outlast, not the way you say a thing for comfort. "Hold on until tomorrow."

The wood does not warm under her hand. She did not expect it to.

CHAPTER 19

The Lid Comes Off

It is past three when Erik calls, and she knows from the first word it has come due.

She has been at the kitchen table since they got back from the inlet, not doing anything, the cold cup of coffee in front of her that she made hours ago and did not drink. The afternoon is the warmest it has been. The eave runs steady now, no ticking to it, a thin continuous string of water off the corner of the porch, and the yard between the house and the sauna has gone from snow to a gray slush that holds the shape of her boots when she walks it. She has not walked it. She has sat at the table and waited for the dark to come, because Mikko said he would be back before dark, and the dark is the thing she is counting toward.

The phone is loud in the still house.

"Aino." It is Erik. His voice is wrong. Not loud. Pressed flat, the way a man's voice goes when he is holding it level with both hands. "Is Mikko there."

"He's on his way back. He's at the job."

"Reino's truck is gone." A breath. "I went by his place. Truck's gone and the saw's gone off the bench. The good saw, the big one." Another breath, and she can hear, under the level voice, the thing he is keeping out of it. "He's not answering. I been calling since noon."

She is standing. She does not remember standing.

"The lake," she says.

"Our spot." It comes out of him like something pulled. "The Saari spot, the point on the north end. It's where we

always — it's where the boy went in, Aino. It's where we keep. He's gone down to the spot."

"With the saw."

"With the saw."

She is already reaching for her coat.

—

Mikko's truck comes up the road as she is on the porch, and she does not have to flag him; he sees her standing in the slush with her coat half on and he stops in the yard with the door open before she reaches him.

"Reino," she says. "Erik can't find him. The truck's gone, the chainsaw's gone. Erik thinks he's gone to the Saari spot to do it himself."

Mikko does not ask what *it* is. He has been in the gap with the rest of them since Monday night. His face does the thing she has watched it do all week, the practical man arriving fast at the end of his explanations, and then he says, "Get in," and she is in, and the truck is already turning before her door is shut.

The north end is twenty minutes by the road around the bay. Mikko does it in less. Neither of them talks. The lake runs along on their left between the trees, white still, but a wrong white, a flat dull white with no shine to it, the white of ice that has stopped being ice on the inside and has not yet admitted it on the top. Where the road comes near the shore she can see the dark seams in it, the long gray lines standing out from the point, and the open black where the creek mouths come in.

The cold is in her chest the whole way. Not the room cold of the house at night. A live one, climbing.

She thinks: *let his truck not be there*. She thinks it, and she already knows the answer.

His truck is there. Pulled off at the end of the spur where the Saaris put in, nosed up against the snowbank, the door hanging open and the dome light burning weak in the daylight.

He is out on the ice.

She sees him the moment they come over the bank, and the seeing of him is the worst thing yet, worse than the black hole at the inlet, worse than the glove, because the glove was after and this is during. He is a long way out. Two hundred feet, more, out past where any man with sense would stand on the best ice of January, out at the family's spot where the point reaches and the water goes deep fast, a small dark figure on a white field gone the color of a dead tooth, and the sound reaches them a half second behind the sight — the saw, the high tearing whine of it, carrying flat across the open ice the way sound carries over water.

Erik is on the shore. His truck is below them on the spur and he is down at the edge of the ice, not on it, at the very lip of it, and he is shouting his brother's name. It does not carry. The saw eats it. *Reino*. The word goes out across the ice and the saw takes it and Reino does not turn.

They come down the bank fast, the slush giving under them, and Erik hears them and turns and his face is the face of a man at the end of something.

"He won't —" Erik can't finish it. He points. "He cut. He's already cut."

She looks where he points and she sees it. Out at the spot there is a line in the ice, dark, an arc of it, a curve cut into the

white, and Reino is bent over the far end of it with the saw, finishing the circle. Cutting himself a circle on the worst ice on the lake in the warmest March in forty years. Doing the lake's own work for it, with a tool from his own bench.

And he is shouting. Between the cuts, when the saw drops to an idle, she can hear it — his voice coming back across the ice in pieces, the way the sheriff's voice came back across the inlet, broken into syllables that do not make words. He is shouting down at the cut. Down at the water coming up dark in the cut. She catches a piece of it, a hard guttural piece that might be Finnish, a word his grandmother might have had, and then the saw climbs again and takes the rest.

She does not understand it. She is not meant to. There is no one out there to understand it but him, and he does not understand it either. He has gone out onto the ice with a chainsaw and some words he half-remembers and a lifetime of rage at the thing that took his boy, and he is going to make it stop by cutting it open and standing over it and saying the words at it, the way you would face down a dog, the way you would face down a man. He has decided it is a thing you can face. He has decided it is a thing you can beat if you only stop being afraid of it.

He has it exactly wrong, and there is no way to tell him, and he is two hundred feet out.

—

Erik goes for the ice.

He is past her before she knows it, down the last of the bank and out onto the white, two steps, three, his boots breaking through the rotten skin of it at the shore where the inch of meltwater stands, and Mikko has him.

Mikko has him from behind, both arms locked around Erik's chest, hauling backward, and Erik fights it. Erik is a big man and grief has made him stronger and he fights, drives back with his heels, gets a hand on the ice and Mikko drags him off it by main force, the two of them going down together in the slush at the shoreline, Mikko underneath and not letting go.

"It won't hold you," Mikko says into the back of Erik's neck. He is not shouting. He says it flat and hard and close. "Erik. It won't hold him and it won't hold you. You go out there you go in too. You hear me. You go in too and there's two of you."

"That's my brother." Erik's voice breaks on it. "That's my *brother*, that's all that's —"

"I know it is." Mikko does not loosen his arms. "I know. You can't reach him. There's no reaching him. You go out there and Aino watches both of you go down."

And Erik stops fighting.

That is the thing she will carry out of this, the way she carries the shape under the blanket: the moment Erik stops fighting. Not because he agrees. Because he knows it is true. He goes slack in Mikko's arms in the meltwater at the edge of the lake, a big man gone boneless with the truth of it, and Mikko holds him anyway, holds him so he cannot change his mind, and over his brother's shoulder Erik looks out at the ice at the small dark figure of the man he cannot reach, and he watches.

They all watch. That is what the holding costs them. They cannot do anything but the one thing, which is watch, and they do it.

The saw stops.

Not the way it stopped before, dropping to an idle for the shouting. It stops all the way, the whine falling out of the air, and in the place where it was there is the enormous quiet of the open lake in the afternoon, the eave-drip quiet, the March quiet, a crow somewhere back in the trees, and Reino standing at the spot with the circle cut and the saw gone silent in his hands.

He stands over it. From the shore he is very small and very clear. He has the saw down at his side and he is looking into the cut, into the dark coming up, and he says one more thing to it — she sees his head go back, sees the shape of him draw up to say it — and she does not hear any of this one. Whatever it was. The last of his words, gone out over the water with no one to receive them.

Then the ice lets go under him.

There is no drama to it. That is the horror of it, that there is no drama. The white around the cut simply ceases to be a surface. It does not crack and pitch and throw him; it gives, all at once, a circle of the world going from solid to not, and he drops. Straight down. The way a man drops through a trapdoor. There and then a darkness where he was and the saw gone with him and a low flat sound coming across the ice a half second late, a sound like a heavy door closing in a far room, and water standing up black in the place where a man was standing.

Erik makes a sound she will not describe to anyone, ever.

She does not look away. She had thought she would. At the inlet she turned and looked at the far trees and was glad of it after. She does not turn now. She makes herself hold it, the black place out at the spot where the white closed and reopened, because someone should, because Erik is held

face-down in the slush in Mikko's arms with his eyes shut and his mouth open and no sound coming now, and Mikko has his face in Erik's coat, and somebody on this shore has to be the one who saw it, and it is going to be her.

The water does not move. It stands in the cut, black and flat, the lake's own depth come up where it has no business being, and it does not give him back. The saw does not float. Nothing floats. There is the cut, and the dark in it, and the white all around going gray in the late light, and the cold goes through the soles of her boots and up through her and out the top of her head, and she stands in the slush at the edge of the lake and she does not look away.

—

Then the lake goes.

She feels it before she hears it, up through her feet, through the rotten shore ice and the slush and the ground — a long shudder, a deep give, the whole white field out in front of her shifting its weight like an animal that has been lying still too long. And then the sound. It comes from the spot, from the place where he went down, and it runs out from there across the whole lake at once, a cracking that is not one crack but ten thousand, a tearing that goes out to every shore, north and south and the far trees and back, the cracks running out from the point the way a windshield runs from the stone, fast, faster than a thing that size should be able to move, and under it a deeper sound, a groan that comes up through the ground and into her teeth, the sound of a hundred square miles of ice letting go of itself in one breath.

It runs the length of the lake toward the south end. Toward her end. She can see it go — a line of dark opening seams racing down the white toward the Hietala shore,

toward the point she was told never to swim past, toward the slope below her father's sauna.

And she knows, standing on the north shore with her boots full of meltwater and Erik on his knees in front of her, exactly what is happening at her own shore. She knows it the way she has come to know things this week, below the place where questions live. Down at the Hietala end the seams are reaching the shallows under the sauna. The lake is pushing up against the pilings her great-grandfather drove into the bottom a hundred years ago, the pilings that have held the little building down at the water's edge through a hundred breakups, and the ice is shoving against them now all at once with the weight of the whole lake behind it, and the old wood is taking it, and the old wood is groaning, out there in the empty yard with no one to hear it, the way a thing groans that has been holding and is asked, suddenly, to hold more.

The lid. She thinks the word once, flat, the way her father wrote a number in a ledger. The lid that her great-grandfather and her grandfather and her father each sat on once a week for a hundred years with the heat going up around them and the weight going down. The watch that was not a watch. The man in the sauna keeping the weight of it down.

There is no man in the sauna. There has not been, since October.

And now there is no ice either.

—

It is dusk before they get Erik up the bank.

He walks between them, finally, when there is nothing else to do — when it is plain even to him that there is no part of the afternoon he can change by staying at the water — and

they put him in the cab of his own truck and Mikko calls it in on the truck radio, the township channel, the flat low voices starting up that she heard at the inlet, *north end, the Saari spot, no, there's no recovering anybody off that ice tonight or tomorrow either*, and a man's voice answering, careful, that they'll send what they can in the morning if the lake will let them, and everybody on the channel knowing it will not.

There will be no shape under a blanket for Reino. There is no ice left to walk out on and no honest water under it. He is in the lake now, with her, at the spot, and that is where he will stay.

She stands by the open door of his truck while Mikko sees to Erik, and she looks back out at the lake one more time before the light is gone. It is open in long black channels now, north to south, the white broken into floes already starting to move on the slow current, and the cold coming off it is no longer the soft rotten warmth of the afternoon. It is the cold off open water. The cold of the thing with nothing over it.

She thinks of the south shore, dark now, the sauna standing at the edge of the moving ice with its pilings groaning in the dusk and no one there. She thinks of the house above it, the cold already coming up through the floor, waiting for her.

She has to go back to that tonight.

"One more night," she says. Not to Mikko, not to Erik. To the lake, or to the woman in it, or to no one. She says it the way she said it to the cedar wall yesterday, the way you set down a number you intend to outlast, except that yesterday it was one more day and a thing held down, and now it is one more night and nothing holding it.

The eave is not running anymore. The day's warmth has gone with the light, and the cold has come down hard and

clean, and out on the black water the broken ice grinds
against itself and moves.

CHAPTER 20

The Last Night

Tuesday into Wednesday. The worst night.

There are two dead today. Dale Numminen at the inlet in the morning, found by his own headlight, the snowmobile idling against a drift. And in the afternoon a Saari — one of Erik's people, the one who'd said the only mercy left was to end it now — had taken a chainsaw down to his family's spot and cut a circle in the ice and let it take him. After that the ice began to go. Not in one place. Everywhere. The whole lake, all at once, the cracks running out from the point the way a windshield runs when the stone has already hit.

So Wednesday cannot come fast enough, and Wednesday is still a whole night away.

Mikko is staying. He'd told her that yesterday, before any of this, before either man was dead — *I'll be back before dark and you are not going to be alone for this*. He came back before dark with his duffel and his own coat and a second thermometer in his pocket, and he has not left her side since the sun went down.

It is the kind of cold that has nothing to do with weather. The thermometer on the porch reads twenty-six, an ordinary March night that has taken back the day's thaw the way these nights do. That is not the cold she means. The cold she means is the other one, the one that comes up through the boards.

—

Nine o'clock.

It comes before she is even thinking about bed, before the dark is fully settled, before she has decided whether she is going to try to sleep at all. It comes through the floor the way it has the past two nights, but stronger now, and it comes through the walls too, from the direction of the lake, a flat cold with weight behind it, and she feels it move across her feet like water finding the low place in a room.

She and Mikko are in the kitchen when it starts. She watches him notice it — the slight stiffening, the look of a man registering something his body knows before his mind has caught up to it. He looks at her. She looks at him.

"It knows tomorrow is Wednesday," she says.

She goes and gets the small thermometer from the bathroom, the cheap white plastic one with the red line and the little curl of metal hook for hanging it on a nail. She is going to walk the house. She tells herself it is so she will know. The truth is closer to the way a person counts stairs in the dark — to have something to do with the part of the mind that would otherwise be screaming.

Front room, sixty-eight. The furnace running, the register ticking warm air out across her shins. Hallway, sixty-four. Her bedroom, sixty-one. She holds the thermometer a foot off the floor and then a foot below the ceiling and the difference is real; the cold is coming up, not down, here. The back bedroom. She stands in the doorway with the thermometer out in front of her like a candle and watches the red line settle, and it settles at fifty-two, and the room is the same room it was that afternoon — the iron bed, the wardrobe, the window facing the lake — except that it is twelve degrees colder than the front room with nothing in between to explain it.

Kitchen, fifty-eight and dropping. She holds it there a full minute and watches it drop.

She crouches and sets the thermometer on the floor at the base of the back door, in the seam where the cold comes in, and the line slides down to forty-seven, and then, while she is watching it, to forty-four.

Mikko has his own. He's taken it out of his pocket and he's walking the same circuit a step behind her, not talking, and when they meet back in the kitchen they hold the two thermometers side by side under the light and the readings are within a degree of each other. He'd half-thought, she can see, that hers was wrong. That it was a bad thermometer. That there would turn out to be a reasonable seam of warmth somewhere that the numbers had missed.

"Same," he says.

"Same," she says.

—

Nine-fifteen.

The knocking begins.

Not from the floor this time. From every direction. Three knocks in the floor, under the kitchen, hard and even and spaced. Then a pause. Then three from the east wall, the lake wall, at about the height of her shoulder. Then a pause. And then — for the first time — three from above. From the ceiling. Directly over the table, where there is nothing, where there is only the attic and the roof and the cold sky.

She has not told anyone about the ceiling. Not Louise, not Mikko, not the night two nights ago when she first heard it and stood in the dark telling herself it was the house settling, knowing it was not. She does not tell anyone now.

Floor. Wall. Ceiling. Floor. Wall. Ceiling. Rotating, even, patient, so that the house itself becomes a drum being played from inside, struck in sequence by something that knows exactly where the next blow goes. She turns on another light. She fills the kettle and sets it on the burner. She stands in the kitchen with her hands flat on the counter and breathes, and counts without meaning to, three and three and three, because the count is already in her now and there is no turning it off.

—

Ten o'clock.

She calls Louise.

"Tonight is bad," she says. "It's in the walls. The ceiling."

Louise is quiet for a long moment. Aino can hear something on the other end — a radio, low, or wind.

"She knows we're coming," Louise says finally. "This is the last time she can —" She stops. Starts again. "She has been waiting a hundred years. What she's doing now is what she has always been doing. It's just that there's no one sitting in the sauna anymore keeping the weight of it down."

"I know," Aino says.

"You need to stay in the house. Don't go outside. Don't go near the water. Whatever you hear — whatever you think you hear from outside — you stay inside. Both of you."

"Okay."

"First light," Louise says. "We'll be there."

The line clicks. Aino stands holding the phone after the dial tone has come back, until the dial tone gives way to that flat warning tone they use to tell you the receiver is off the hook, and then she hangs it up. The knocking has not paused for the call. Floor, wall, ceiling. It does not care that she was

on the phone. It was never talking to her.

Midnight.

The kitchen reads forty-six. They are wearing their coats inside the house. She has on the brown wool one of her father's that still smells faintly of him, of pipe tobacco he gave up decades ago and a closet in a house by a lake, and Mikko has on his own.

The knocking has been going for nearly three hours without a break. She has stopped counting it on purpose — has made herself stop, the way you make yourself stop probing a sore tooth — but the count keeps starting again on its own at the edge of her attention, three and three and three, like a faucet she cannot get to seat.

She does the thermometer walk again, because it is something to do. The back bedroom is forty-one now. She stands in the doorway and her breath shows, a little ghost of it in the light from the hall. There is a rim of ice forming on the inside of the window glass. Not frost on the outside, where frost belongs. Ice on the inside, a thin bright lip of it growing up from the bottom of the pane, the way ice grows at the edge of open water.

She can hear the furnace running. It has not stopped running all night. It runs and runs and makes no difference at all, the way a man can shout into a wind.

She closes the door of the back bedroom. It does not help. She had not really thought it would.

One o'clock.

Something hits the back door.

Not a knock. A blow. A single flat impact that shakes the door in its frame and rattles the window above it and sends her two steps back before she knows she has moved. Mikko is on his feet. They stand in the kitchen and look at the door, at the four panes of it gone black with night, at the deadbolt she threw at sundown.

Silence. A real silence, the first in four hours.

Then the knocking resumes — the measured three-and-pause — as though the blow had been a thing apart, an interruption from somewhere else, and the counting has simply picked back up where it left off.

"She's angry," Aino says. Her voice is steadier than she expects it to be. "She has every right to be angry."

"I know," Mikko says.

"Don't open the door."

"I know."

She stands in her kitchen at one in the morning, in her father's coat, in forty-six-degree air, with the knocking moving around her in the walls, and she thinks about Eino writing *kaunis* in a notebook and underlining the word twice. She mouths it once at the black glass, the one Finnish word she is sure of tonight, *kaunis*, beautiful, for the lake that is the worst thing she knows. She thinks about Toivo's last ledger entry, the careful copperplate gone shaky at the end — *perhaps he will not have to carry this*. She thinks about her father, the year before he died, calling her and not being able to do it. They are still there, those calls, scattered down the log on her own phone — his number a dozen times across those last months, most of them seconds long, a few that reached her voicemail and held nothing in them but the sound of his kitchen and a breath and the small click of him

setting the receiver back down. He would call her up to the edge of speaking and then not speak.

One-fifteen.

"I should have come sooner," she says.

Mikko looks at her.

"Not just after he died. Years ago. I should have —" She stops. The armor she has worn all night, all week, the flat dry voice she keeps the count out with, slips, and underneath it is the thing she has not let herself look at, and she lets herself look at it now because there is no longer any reason not to. "He was waiting for me. He'd been waiting for years, Mikko, he was sitting in this house calling me and hanging up because he couldn't think of how to start, and I was in Milwaukee not answering the questions I wouldn't let myself ask. I knew the area code. I knew it was him. I let it ring."

"You didn't know," Mikko says. "About — any of this. You couldn't have known."

"I knew something was wrong. I have always known something was wrong with this lake and this house and this family. I knew it the way you know a smell in a house you grew up in, the way I knew not to swim past the point and never once asked anyone why. I just decided I was allowed to not know it officially." She looks at the back door. "Nineteen years."

She does the math. She has done it before; she does it again now, here, in the cold, because the count is already running and the count will take any numbers it is given.

She times every phone call. She has always timed them — looks at the clock when she picks up, looks again when she sets the receiver down — the way he did, the way her father

did, a thing she got from him without ever being taught it. So she knows. Four calls a year, maybe. Holidays, his birthday, the one in spring when the ice went out and he'd call to tell her the date so she could write it down somewhere she would never look at again. Ten minutes a call, the long ones. Forty minutes a year. She left at nineteen and she has been gone nineteen years, and nineteen times forty is seven hundred and sixty minutes, and seven hundred and sixty minutes is twelve hours and forty minutes.

Twelve hours. In nineteen years she had given her father twelve hours of her voice, and he had given her twelve hours of his, and that is all there is now, that is the whole sum of it, twelve hours laid end to end would not get a person from here to Milwaukee, and somewhere in those twelve hours, in the long pauses between sentences that she had always been impatient with, he had been trying to tell her this and she had been waiting for him to get to the point so she could go.

Mikko does not say anything. There is nothing useful to say and he knows it, and she is grateful for that, grateful for the specific quality of his silence, which is not absence but presence, a man standing in a cold kitchen at one in the morning being there.

—

Two o'clock.

The blow comes against the door again.

Harder. The whole frame jumps; a fine dust of old paint sifts down from the top of the casing. The window above the door rattles in its glazing and she thinks, distantly, that it is going to break, that they are going to be in here with the cold and whatever the cold is coming in through a broken window, and then it does not break.

She makes herself look at Mikko's face, because she needs to know what is on it, and what is on it is the thing she has been afraid of all night. Not fear, exactly. Worse than fear. The look of a practical man — a man who plows roads and fixes furnaces and knows the weight of snow and the load a roof will take — running, fast and silent, through every reasonable explanation he has, and reaching the end of them, and finding nothing there. His jaw is set. There is a muscle going in his cheek. He is forty-something years old and he has lived on this lake his whole life and he is learning, tonight, in real time, that the thing he has spent that whole life half-knowing and never saying is real, is here, is on the other side of an inch and a half of door, and his face is the face of a man watching the floor of his own life give way.

He catches her looking. He doesn't pretend.

"Yeah," he says.

"Yeah," she says.

—

Two-fifteen.

The blow again. Then the measured knocking resumes, patient, counting, three and three and three, around and around the house. She goes and stands at the back window beside the door, not too close, and looks out.

The yard is blue-black under no moon. The snow holds what light there is. And out past the dooryard, at the edge of where she can see, between the house and the slope down to the sauna, the snow is not still. She cannot say it is anything. That is the thing she will keep coming back to, after, that she cannot say it is anything — only that there is a place in the snow at the limit of the light where the dark seems to gather and shift and stand, a height to it that is roughly the height of

a person, a stillness in it that is the wrong kind of stillness, the stillness of something looking back. She does not lean in to see it better. Louise told her not to go near the water and she understands, suddenly, that this is the same instruction. She steps back from the glass.

"Don't," she says, when Mikko starts toward the window.

He stops. He looks at her instead of out the window, which is right, which is the thing to do.

—

Three o'clock.

The kitchen reads forty-two. She can no longer feel her feet. When she looks down at them she is faintly surprised to find them still there in her boots, doing their job.

They make the decision the way two cold people make a decision, which is mostly without words. She looks at the front room, dark and twenty degrees colder, the cold pouring out of it now like a draft from an open cellar. She looks at the kitchen, the one room with the stove in it, the warmest room in the house at forty-two degrees. She looks at Mikko. He is already standing.

They drag the couch.

It is heavy and the doorway is narrow and they have to tip it on its end and walk it through sideways, the two of them grunting in the cold, their breath hanging, and it is an absurd thing to be doing at three in the morning while a hundred-year-old grief beats on the walls, and they do it anyway because the alternative is to sit and freeze and listen, and at least this is moving. They get it into the kitchen and shove it sideways against the table, under the window, as close to the stove as it will go without catching.

She turns on every burner. Four blue rings of gas, low, hissing. The oven too, door cracked. The lights all blazing, every light in the house she could reach. They sit on the couch with the quilt — the one from the back bedroom, the wedding-ring quilt, gone stiff with cold — pulled up over both of them, shoulder to shoulder, and the heat off the burners is a real thing, a small dome of it, and it is still forty-two degrees in the room and the knocking is in the floor under the couch and in the wall behind their heads and in the ceiling over them, and the four burners hiss and the furnace runs somewhere below and none of it, none of it, makes the line on the thermometer move.

She does not think about the temperature. She thinks about Louise saying *we'll be there*. She thinks about what those two words mean after a hundred years of silence — of watching without acknowledgment, of keeping a woman's body and her name and her right to be properly grieved pinned flat under the weight of a family's guilt and a town's agreement not to discuss it.

She thinks: *tomorrow*.

She thinks: *hold on*.

—

Four o'clock.

The blows against the door stop.

The knocking in the walls goes on, but something in it has changed. The rhythm is the same — three and three and three, around the house — but the quality of it is different now, lower, or slower, or further off, something she cannot name. She thinks of a voice that has been shouting for hours and is starting to go. She thinks that is not the right way to think about it. She thinks there is no right way to think about

it. She thinks that maybe it is exactly right.

Mikko has gone quiet beside her, his head tipped back against the cushion, his eyes shut, not asleep — she can tell from his breathing he is not asleep — but resting, going somewhere inside himself to wait out the last of it. She lets him. She keeps watch on the window and the door for both of them.

Five o'clock.

She gets up, the quilt sliding off her shoulder, and the cold takes the warm place where it was instantly. She makes coffee. The simple acts of it — the grounds, the water, the percolator on the one free burner — are steadying in a way she is grateful for. She stands at the stove with her hands around the first cup and looks out the kitchen window, where, over the black line of the trees across the lake, the sky has begun, very faintly, to change. Not light yet. The idea of light. The gray that comes before the gray.

The knocking goes on. Three and three and three. It has gone on for eight hours. She finds that she is counting it again, openly now, all pretense of not counting gone, counting it down toward the thing Louise promised — *first light* — counting the way you count the last contractions, the way you count a fever breaking, counting because the count is the only clock she has left and it is finally, after eight hours, running toward something.

Five-thirty.

The knocking stops.

Between the second and third knock.

There is the first. There is the second. And there is not the third. The count opens its mouth for the third blow and the third blow does not come, and the house goes into a silence so total and so sudden that she hears her own pulse in her ears, hears the gas hissing in the burners, hears Mikko's breathing change behind her as he comes up out of his rest into the silence and registers it.

Just like every morning. Between the second and the third. She stands in the kitchen in the sudden enormous silence, the coffee cup hot against both her palms, and breathes.

Mikko says: "It's Wednesday."

"It's Wednesday," she says.

CHAPTER 21

The Morning

The silence is the strange part.

Not the knocking. The knocking she had grown used to, the way you grow used to a clock, until the room was the count and the count was the room. It is the absence of it that she cannot find a place to put. She stands in the kitchen with the coffee going cold in her hand and the burners still hissing low and the couch shoved sideways against the table where they had dragged it in the night, and the house around her is just a house. Forty-two degrees and getting no colder. The furnace running. The refrigerator coming on with its small ordinary shudder. She listens to that and it is only itself.

"It's Wednesday," Mikko had said, and now he is asleep, gone all at once the way exhausted men go, sitting up against the arm of the couch with the quilt half off him and his mouth open. She does not wake him. She lets him have it.

She drinks her coffee. It is bad and cold and she drinks it anyway. The light comes up gray in the window over the sink, no sun in it yet, just the thinning of the dark into something she could read a page by, and she watches it the way she has watched it every morning since she came, the slow return of the yard out of the black — the snow, the tree line, the slope she cannot see the bottom of from here.

At six-fifteen she goes to the back door and unlocks it and opens it and looks out at the yard.

The snow has been disturbed in a radius around the entire house — not footprints, not the small deliberate prints she'd grown used to, but something different, the snow pushed

away from the foundation in every direction as though something had been pressing against the house from outside all night. She looks at it for a long time.

She closes the door. She locks it again.

—

She has things to do before Louise comes.

She does them slowly. There is no hurry in her, and she is too tired for hurry anyway, the kind of tired that has gone past wanting sleep and out the other side into a flat clear patience, and she moves through the cold house the way you move through a thing you are doing for the last time and want to do right.

She gets the box first. There is a wooden one in the basement workshop, on the floor under the bench, a crate her father built or her grandfather did — dovetailed at the corners, the joints tight, the wood gone the color of weak tea. It is empty but for a coil of wire and a tin of nails, and she sets those on the bench and takes the box and it is light in her hands, light enough that she knows what she is going to do is mostly fill it. The workshop is the coldest room in the house except the one she has not gone into yet. The pegboard with the tools she finally has names for. The chisels in their graduated order. The mallet worn smooth in the one place. She does not look at them long. She carries the box out.

The root cellar is behind the furnace on the north wall, where the warmth off the metal stops a foot short of the stone, and she turns sideways to get back into the dark there and fits the iron key into the forged plate. It turns with the single dry sound it made the first time. The cold comes out at her before the door is all the way open — lower than the basement's cold, with the wet edge to it, the smell riding out

on it of earth and stone-iron and under those the sourness that is almost sweet. She has been here before. She knows what it costs to stand in it. She stands in it.

She had wrapped the documents back in the oilcloth and tied the cord and set them where they had been, on the center shelf, because they were not hers to keep and not hers to throw away. She had told herself that. She takes them down now. The land claim. The letters to and from the county, formal and dry. The list of names in two hands, Eino's and her father's, four columns, her own name last on the Hietala column with nothing under it. She does not unwrap it here in the cold to look at it. She knows what it says. She sets the bundle in the box and it goes down with a small weight that is more than paper should have.

The jars she leaves. The tin box that rattles she leaves. The small wrapped figure at the back of the stone shelf she leaves where it stands, and she does not touch it, because it is not hers and she does not know what it is and she has decided to let it go on being something she does not know. She backs out and pulls the door to and turns the iron key the other way, the bolt sliding back into the stone, and she stands a moment with her hand flat on the old close-grained boards. Then she takes her hand away.

Toivo's ledgers are on the basement shelf where they have always been, four of them, the cloth covers soft at the corners. She takes them down one at a time and stacks them in the box on top of the oilcloth. *Perhaps he will not have to carry this.* She does not open them. She knows the lines that matter and she does not need to see them in his hand again this morning. The box is heavier now when she lifts it, and she carries it up the basement stairs with both arms and sets it on the kitchen floor by the door and stands a moment getting her

breath.

Mikko sleeps. The light in the window is grayer, nearer to morning.

There is one more.

—

She goes down the hill in the gray pre-dawn with her coat on and her flashlight in her pocket and she does not bring the box, because what she is going for she wants to carry up in her hand.

The path is the same. The birches first and then the pines, the packed trail her father kept clear over sixty years of going down to sit in the dark and watch the water. The cold is different out here than in the house — older, with the lake in it. The sauna comes up out of the trees ahead of her, the dark lower walls and the cedar her father put in the last summer she was home, the whole structure stepping out over the ice on its heavy pilings. She fits the padlock key. The hasp opens.

Inside, the changing room is the temperature of the outdoors and then some, the cold dense and close. Her father's worn sandals under the bench where she left them. The stiff towel on its hook. She goes through to the sauna proper and the stove is dead — no fire in the kiuas since she let the last one go, the stones up top gone to the same gray cold as everything else, the firebox below shut and silent. The band of carved marks runs level around the room at the height it has always run, the same in the steam and out of it, and there is no steam now. There is nothing now. It is the coldest room she has been in this morning and the stillest, and the stillness has the lake under it.

She kneels in front of the lower bench. She finds the seam with her fingers, the rectangular section set into the floor of

the platform, cut so fine it disappears into the plank lines, and she does not need the crowbar this time; she knows where to lift. The section comes up. Below it the lockbox, bolted to the framing, the combination lock cold enough on the hasp that it stings her fingers when she turns the dial. Her grandmother Aili's birthday, two days before her own, the cake they shared when she was small. The lock opens.

Inside: Eino's notebook, older than the ledgers, the leather dark and dry. The key she'd found wrapped beside it the first time is gone — it is in the root cellar door now, it has been since she found what it opened. Only the notebook left. She takes it out and holds it and it is so cold from the box that it is almost wet to the touch, the way iron is in deep winter, and she thinks of Eino writing *kaunis* in it and underlining it, a man putting one true word down where no one would read it for a hundred years.

She closes the lockbox. She spins the dial. She lowers the section of bench back into the floor and presses it flush.

She knows it is the last time she will open that box. She lets herself know it, kneeling on the cold boards with the notebook against her chest. Her father knelt here. His father did. The whole line of them down to her, opening this box in the heat and the dark and closing it again, keeping the one word and the four ledgers and the list of names under the weight of the sauna and the weight of themselves. She is the one who gets to stop.

The hatch is over by the far wall, the rope handle flush in the planks, the floor under it nothing but a few feet of air and then the ice. She does not open it. She has no reason to and one good reason not to, and she has learned, this winter, to leave shut the things that ask to be left shut. She stands with the notebook in her hand and looks at the hatch and then she

turns and goes out and locks the padlock behind her and starts up the hill.

—

Hank's ledgers she leaves in the basement.

Forty-two of them, her father's whole watch set down year on year, the cold even hand and at the very end the entries gone short — *Tired. She is gone. I sat in the sauna all night.* She had stood in front of that shelf with the box already heavy at her feet and her hand on the first of them and she had not been able to do it. The documents are not hers and the ledgers from before her father are not hers, but these are. These are the part of it she has not decided about. She is not sure whether they go in the box and down to the water, or whether they stay, whether there is something in keeping them that is not the same as keeping the secret. She does not know. She is not ready to know, and she has learned not to force a thing she is not ready for, and so she leaves them on the shelf in the order he left them and she goes up the stairs.

She sets Eino's notebook in the box on top of everything else. The box is full now, or full enough. She closes the lid.

She goes to wake Mikko. He is still on the couch in the warm kitchen, the quilt fallen, and she puts her hand on his shoulder. His shoulder is warm through the flannel, the one warm thing she has touched all morning, and she keeps her hand there a second longer than she needs to.

"They'll be here soon," she says. "We need to go down to the shore."

He opens his eyes. He looks at her, surfacing, putting the morning together. He looks at the gray window and the box by the door. He sits up.

"Wednesday," he says.

"Wednesday."

He pushes the quilt off and finds his boots. She turns the burners off, one by one, the small blue flames going out, and the kitchen is suddenly only as warm as it is going to stay. She picks up the box.

They go out the back, into the radius of pushed snow, and down the path.

—

The lake is wrong in the early light.

The cracks she'd seen the day before have spread overnight — the whole surface of the lake is webbed with them now, lines running in every direction from the point thirty feet out from the sauna, so that the ice looks less like ice than like something that has been keeping its shape under strain and is close to giving it up. The surface is a pale gray-white in the morning and it is moving, subtly, in a way ice does not move — a slow pulse, almost breathing, as though whatever is below it has been pressing up against it all night the way it pressed at the house.

The fish houses are gone. She'd thought their owners had pulled them off for the season. Looking at the ice now she is less certain.

She sets the box down at the edge of the shore, in the snow, where it will be ready when it is needed. She stands beside Mikko at the water's edge and she looks at the lake and she feels the presence of it the way she has felt it since the day she arrived — the weight and the cold and the attention of something very old and very tired and very angry — and she does not look away.

They wait.

CHAPTER 22

The Ceremony

The others come down out of the gray while they are waiting.

The Lehtinens first, down the slope from the road, Marta and Juhani together, picking their way through the disturbed snow with their hands out a little for balance. Marta's face is tight and pale. She does not say good morning. None of them say good morning; there is no morning in it yet, only the thinning dark and the cold off the water and the box in the snow at Aino's feet.

Erik Saari comes down a minute behind them, alone, hands in his coat pockets, and takes a position a few feet from the Lehtinens without a word. His brother is not with him. His brother will not be with him again. Aino looks at him once — at the set of his shoulders, the way a man stands the morning after — and looks away, because there is nothing in her to offer him that would not be an insult, and she has learned this winter to leave shut the things that ask to be left shut.

Then headlights swing across the trees up on the road, two sets, and stop. Doors. The sound of people getting out of vehicles into cold air, careful, unhurried. Louise comes down the slope first, and behind her an older man, and behind him a younger one, the three of them carrying things Aino does not look at directly.

They are eight, now, in the early light on the shore of a lake that is not behaving like a lake, and for a moment none of them speak.

Louise looks at them — at Mikko, at the Lehtinens, at Erik standing apart. Something moves through her expression. "Thank you for being here," she says, quietly.

The wooden box is at Aino's feet, the one she filled in the dark hours, everything her family kept that was never theirs to keep now closed inside it. She had not slept. She does not feel the lack of it; she is past that, out the other side of it into something flat and clear.

Louise looks at the box. She nods once. The younger man steps to it and lifts it and sets it carefully near the vehicles, out of the way, and Aino does not watch where exactly he puts it, only that it is no longer hers to hold.

Then she turns to her family and speaks in her language and they move.

—

What they do Aino watches from twenty feet back, beside Mikko, and she watches it as carefully as she has watched anything in her life. She is not going to look away. She promised herself that in the kitchen at three in the morning while the temperature dropped and the door shook, and she keeps the promise now.

There are words spoken. There are things brought down from the vehicles — she does not look at them directly, that feels like a trespass — and set at the water's edge with care. The older man kneels once at the very edge of the snow and the ice and does something with his hands close to the surface, low, deliberate, and Aino turns her eyes to the middle distance and leaves it to him; it is not hers to see. There is a quality to what Louise's family is doing that she has no language for. It is not performance. It is not ritual in the theatrical sense. It is more like — she searches for it — it is

more like the way her father sat in the sauna. The committed presence of it. The being-there that is its own form of speech.

The lake responds.

Not gradually. Immediately, the moment Louise's uncle begins to speak, the surface of the lake changes. The pulse she had noticed — the slow breathing quality of the ice — intensifies. The cracks spread visibly in the early light, branching outward from the center point, and the sound the ice makes is not the sound ice makes. It is deeper. More intentional. As though the lake itself is answering.

Then the cold comes off the water.

She has felt this cold for the past nights inside the house. Out here at the shore it is a different thing entirely — not temperature, not weather, but the cold of the lake bottom, the cold of deep water in early March, the cold of the place where stones were placed in 1919 and have not moved since. It comes off the surface in a wave and hits her full in the face and she takes an involuntary step back.

Mikko grabs her arm.

She takes the step back and then she takes a step forward. She plants her feet at the shore and she stands there.

The cold intensifies. It is in her chest now, the sensation of breathing underwater, her lungs registering the wrong element, and she knows this is not physical — she is standing on solid ground, she is breathing air, the temperature at the shore is twenty-eight degrees — but knowing this does not make it less real. She can feel the weight of the water above her as though she is thirty feet down, in the dark, with stones.

She is letting me feel it, Aino thinks. She is letting me feel what it was.

She doesn't run. She breathes through it. It is the worst thing she has ever felt and she breathes through it and keeps

her feet at the shore.

Beside her she can hear Mikko breathing deliberately, the way you breathe when you are keeping yourself from reacting to something. She doesn't look at him. She keeps her eyes on the ice.

The ice is moving now in a way she can't explain and won't try to. The surface shifts and settles and the cracks open and close and the light on it does something the light isn't doing on anything else — a depth in it, as though the ice is not two feet thick but two hundred, as though what she is looking at is not the surface but the bottom.

Louise's uncle speaks for a long time. His voice is low and steady and does not waver, and the lake responds to it, she can feel the response, the quality of the presence below the surface shifting incrementally from — she searches for the word — from *focused* to something more diffuse, as though the beam of something very concentrated is slowly widening.

Then it focuses again. On her.

She feels it before she sees anything — a shift in the pressure of the cold, a direction, the sense of something that has been distributed across the whole surface of the lake gathering itself toward the shore. Toward the sauna. Toward her.

She is the last Hietala. She is what is left of the family that did this. She is standing at the edge of the water that held a woman's body for a hundred years and she is the last person whose name is on that debt and the presence below the ice knows her the way it has always known her name and it is done waiting.

The cold hits her like a wall.

She goes to one knee. She doesn't decide to — her legs simply stop supporting her, the weight of the cold and the

pressure and the sensation of water that is not there overwhelming her body's certainty that she is standing on land. Her knee hits the snow at the water's edge. She is eight inches from the ice.

Mikko has her by both arms. She can feel that. She can feel the warmth of his hands through her coat.

"Aino," he says. Quietly. Steadily.

She looks at the ice. Eight inches away. The cracks are open here, the surface no longer smooth, and through the gaps she can see the water below — dark and cold and moving, something moving in it that she can see clearly now without the distance of a hatch between them, closer than she has ever been.

She is looking at the shape of a woman.

Not clearly. Not in the way you see a person standing in a lit room. The way you see a figure through deep water, through a hundred years of cold, the outline of a person who was a person and has become something else but has not forgotten what she was. The shape of arms. The shape of a face turned upward.

Looking at her.

The weight is enormous. The cold is in her lungs, her hands, the back of her eyes. She is being held at the water's edge by Mikko's hands and she is also, she understands, being held at the water's edge by something else — a hundred years of family gravity, the debt that landed on her because she is the last, the weight of Eino and Toivo and her father all arriving simultaneously in her chest like a wave.

She opens her mouth.

"Mindemoyen," she says.

Her voice comes out wrong — thin, strained, the voice of someone who is very cold or very frightened or both. She

doesn't try again from that register. She breathes. She feels Mikko's hands on her arms. She breathes again.

"Mindemoyen," she says again. Her own voice this time.

The pressure does not ease. But it — attends. The sense of something waiting.

She thinks about what she needs to say. Not what she has rehearsed, because she hasn't rehearsed this — she hadn't known this moment was coming in this form, on her knees at the water's edge with her hands going numb and a shape moving in the deep water below her. She thinks about what is true. She thinks about what has not been said in a hundred years.

"What my family did to you was wrong," she says. "What Eino did. What all four of them did. It was wrong and they knew it was wrong and they chose silence instead of — " She stops. She starts again. "My grandfather tried to find another way and didn't know how. My father tried to find another way and didn't know how. I don't know if I know how either. But Louise is here. Her family is here. And I am telling you — out loud, at this lake, so that whatever is left of you that can hear me hears me — that you deserved better than every single one of us."

The cold peaks.

And then she is under.

Not physically. She is on her knees in the snow, her hands going numb, Mikko's grip on her arms — she knows all of that the way you know a fact you cannot feel. But in every sense that her body believes, she is at the bottom of the lake. There is no surface. There is no air, and no part of her remembers what air was. There is the dark and the stones and the cold that is not a temperature but the whole of the place, the entire weight of a hundred years standing on her chest, the deep

water pressing in from all six sides at once, and a slow pull — downward, outward, toward the open cracks and the moving water under them — that is not metaphor and is not in her mind. It is in her arms. It is in the weight of her own body tipping toward the ice.

She is going in.

She understands this without panic, which is its own kind of terror — that there is no edge of fear left to stand on, only the pull and the dark and the cold and the slow certain tilt of her weight toward the water, the way the stones must have gone, the way a body goes when it is weighted and let go. Her hands are flat on the ice. She did not put them there. They are sliding. The cold is everything and there is no surface and there is no surface and there is no —

"*Anna meidän anteeksi*," she says.

She does not decide to say it. She does not know, in the saying, that she still had it — the language her grandmother spoke and her father half-kept and she had let go of the way you let go of a coat you have outgrown. It comes up out of her with the English gone insufficient and the armor gone entirely, the old language surfacing on its own from a place older than her choosing. *Forgive us*. The thing her family never said in a hundred years, surfacing in the tongue Eino wrote his one true word in. She does not translate it. She does not know she has said it until it is said.

And then it is past her teeth and gone into the cold and she is still tipping toward the water.

"*Aino*." Mikko's voice, close, but the cold is between them like fathoms of water. His hands tighten. She feels him take her weight and she feels her weight keep going — past where his grip can hold it, the pull from the lake stronger than a man kneeling in snow, his hands sliding on the slick of her

coat the way her own hands are sliding on the ice. He swears, low, and braces, and she feels the strain of it travel through his arms into hers, and still she is going. The water wants her. It has waited a hundred years and it does not care that she is the one who came to say the words; she is a Hietala and her weight is going toward the ice and his hold is failing by degrees, one numb inch and then another.

Then there are other hands.

She does not see whose. Mikko's grip is suddenly not the only thing — an arm across her back, a fist closing in the collar of her coat, someone's boots crunching down into the snow on her other side and hauling — and the pull from the water meets the pull from the shore and for one long suspended beat the two are even and she hangs between them, half over the ice, the cold in her mouth, and it could go either way and she knows it could go either way.

Then it gives. The shore wins it back an inch, and then a foot, the lake's grip breaking the way ice breaks, all at once after holding, and she comes up and back off her hands and into the bodies behind her, dragged clear of the open cracks, her weight landing on solid ground with the whole strained company of them landing with it.

She is on her knees at the shore, well back from the edge now. She is breathing. Her hands are raw and white and shaking. Mikko has her around the shoulders and he is breathing like a man who has run, his face gray, and it is Juhani Lehtinen who has her collar, she sees now, Juhani's boots churned into the snow beside hers, his jaw set. Neither of them lets go yet.

The pressure eases.

Not gone. She does not think it will ever be entirely gone, not today, not yet, perhaps not ever — these things don't

resolve cleanly, Louise said so, she has always understood that. But it eases. The cold at the shore retreats to something that is merely the cold of a March morning. The sensation in her lungs becomes ordinary breath. The light on the ice returns to the ordinary pale gray of winter.

She is aware that Louise is standing beside her. She doesn't know when Louise moved from the water's edge to here.

"Can you stand up?" Louise asks.

She can. She does, with Mikko on one side and Juhani's hand still at her arm until she is up. She stands at the shore of the lake and her legs are shaking but they are holding and she looks at the ice.

The cracks are still there but they are not moving anymore. The surface of the lake is still. Whatever pulse had animated it is quieter now — not absent, she can still feel the weight of what is in the water, she thinks she will always be able to feel it — but quieter.

In the silence Louise says the words she said last time: "We see you. We have always seen you. We are here."

And then, this time, something Aino has not heard her say before. Quietly, in her own language, brief.

Aino doesn't understand the words. She understands what they mean.

The ice does not crack open. The body does not rise. There is no dramatic resolution, no definitive end. There is a long silence at the shore, eight people standing in the March cold, and the lake, and whatever is in it, and the morning.

Then Louise says to Aino: "The sauna."

"Yes," Aino says. "Now."

CHAPTER 23

Burning

She does not go inside the house first this time.

She goes directly to the sauna. She opens the door. She goes in.

The cold in here is the same cold as outside — the kiuas has been out for days, the cedar walls hold no memory of heat. She stands in the center of the room and looks at the carvings on the walls, the band of marks her great-grandfather began and her grandfather continued and her father maintained, running around the room at the same height, the height a seated man would be at, the height of someone sitting and watching.

She goes to the stove. She opens the firebox.

She thinks about her father at fourteen years old in the photograph, slightly turned, as though he was already leaving. Four months before his father drowned. A boy who did not ask to inherit this and inherited it anyway.

She thinks about the entry in March of last year: *I am running out of time to look.*

She thinks about the entry in May: *I should have told her the summer she found the ledger and I screamed at her and she left. That was the worst thing I ever did.*

She thinks about Father's Day. Eleven minutes; he timed every call. She does not do the math again. She did it once, in the cold kitchen with the count coming up through the floor, and once is enough to carry.

She builds the fire.

Paper, kindling, the first log — the way he taught her when she was six, the way she has done it twice now in this sauna, the way she will never do again after this.

She lights it.

She leaves the firebox door open.

She does not leave.

She has told herself she would build the fire and walk away, and now that she is here she finds she cannot. She stands in the cold sauna and watches the fire catch and she thinks: *I owe him this*. Not sentimentality. Witness. He sat in this room for thirty years and no one watched him do it and she is going to stand here and watch the fire take the room he built until she can't stand there anymore.

The cedar burns fast. She knew it would — the wood is old and dry, forty years of kiuas heat drawn into the walls, and when the fire comes out of the firebox and finds the wall beside it the wall goes up like it has been waiting. She backs toward the door. The heat is immediate and serious, the real heat of a structure fire, nothing like the heat of the sauna in use, and she backs out through the door and stands outside and watches through the open door.

The carvings go first. The band of marks running around the room, her great-grandfather's hand and her grandfather's hand and her father's hand in the wood, three generations of witnessing in a language she never learned to read — the fire finds them and they are gone in under a minute, and she watches them go and she does not look away. She knows now what they were for. Not a record. A lid. The marks Eino first cut and Toivo re-cut and her father kept re-cutting, year over year, to hold the thing below where it lay — the watch and the marks and the sauna all one thing, one long act of keeping it down. She still cannot read a single one of them. She does not

need to. She knows what they were doing, and she knows the men who did it, and that is all the fire is going to leave her with. The lid burns with what it was holding shut.

The lauteet goes. The bench where she sat, the platform above it where she'd lain in the heat, the floor below it where the hatch was — the hatch over the water, the hatch her father had told her not to open, the one she opened anyway. All of it goes, and the fire finds the gap and the cold air from the lake below comes up through the opening and feeds it, and the sauna burns from the inside out and from the bottom up simultaneously and the smoke rising is dense and white against the gray sky.

She is crying.

She doesn't know when she started. She becomes aware of it gradually, the way you become aware of rain — you are dry and then you are wet and you can't say when the transition happened. Her face is wet and the heat from the burning sauna is drying it as fast as it comes and she stands in the snow twelve feet from the fire and cries for her father, for thirty years of coming down this hill alone, for the coffee he made every morning in the same percolator, for the eleven minutes on Father's Day, for the ledger entry that said *I am tired*.

She cries for Toivo, who wanted to find another way and found the lake instead.

She cries for Eino, who wrote *kaunis* and underlined it and built something terrible over something he couldn't face.

She cries for the first Aino, who looked at her husband for a long time and did not speak and carried it for forty-three years.

She cries for Mindemoyen. She cries for a woman she never met and never can meet and whose name she has only

been carrying for a few weeks and whose family has been carrying it for a hundred years.

She does not cry for herself. She thinks maybe that comes later. She thinks she has a great deal of crying for herself still to do and today is not that day.

Mikko comes to stand beside her. He doesn't put his arm around her or say anything. He just stands there, the way he has been standing there through all of this.

The roof goes. The walls come down in stages. The stone foundation holds, the fieldstone that Eino set in 1919 and that is not going anywhere — it will stand at the water's edge after the snow melts and into the spring and beyond, just stones, just a rectangle of old mortared rock that the weather will slowly work on. That is fine. That is what stones do.

By the time the structure is down to coals and stone the sky has lightened fully and the morning is well underway and she has stopped crying and her face is dry and tight from the heat and the cold both.

Louise comes to stand beside her on the other side.

For a long time no one says anything.

Then Louise says: "Your father knew my name."

Aino looks at her. "He found it in the last year. He wrote it in his ledger. He tried to call."

"I know," Louise says. "I had a message. A voicemail, from a number I didn't recognize, no name, no words. Just breathing, for about twenty seconds, and then it hung up." She pauses. "I knew who it was. I didn't know how to call back." A pause. "I should have."

Aino looks at the coals. "He should have stayed on the line."

"Yes," Louise says. "He should have."

They stand together at the water's edge, at the ruined foundation of the thing that was between them, in the March cold, and the smoke rises and the lake is still and somewhere below the ice, in thirty feet of dark water, something has been heard after a hundred years of silence.

It is not over. Louise said so and Aino knows it.

But it has begun.

CHAPTER 24

Coals and Stone

What is left at the water's edge is coals and stone.

The fire is essentially done. It has been done for a while now — the structure came down through the late morning, the roof and then the walls and then the frame, and what remains is the fieldstone foundation Eino set in 1919 and a bed of embers inside it, banked and glowing and throwing heat she can feel from the kitchen window. The smoke is thin now, a slow gray thread off the coals, rising straight in the still air and then bending east where it finds the wind above the trees. By mid-afternoon the temperature has climbed to thirty-four degrees, the warmest it's been since she arrived. Melt runs from the eaves in a steady drip. The snow in the yard has gone heavy and wet, and the path the men beat down to the shore has turned to slush.

She looks at the smoke once, the way you'd look back at something you'd carried a long way and finally set down, and then she stops looking at it.

The others are still down at the shore. They came back through the morning to watch it burn and they have not all left yet. Louise's uncle says something quietly to the younger man and the younger man nods. Marta Lehtinen cries, briefly, and Juhani puts his arm around her and she lets him.

Erik Saari walks down to the foundation and stands at the edge of it, as close to the coals as the heat will allow, his hands at his sides. He stands there a long time. His brother went through the ice yesterday and they have not found him, and Aino thinks of that and then makes herself stop, because it is

not hers to look at, and because she is not sure looking at it is even what he's doing. She doesn't know what he's doing. She thinks maybe he doesn't either. He just stands at the lip of the warm stone with the smoke going up past his face, and the lake behind him holding everything it holds, and after a while he turns and comes back up the hill.

Louise comes to find her at the kitchen window.

"We're going to go," she says. "We'll come back. There are other things we need to do here, at the shore. Not today."

"Whenever you want," Aino says. "I'll leave a key with Mikko for when I'm not here."

Louise looks at her. "You're going back to Milwaukee."

"Eventually. I don't know exactly when."

Louise is quiet for a moment. "What happened today — it's a beginning. Not an ending." She pauses. "I want you to understand that. For your own sake. You did a good thing. It's not finished, because these things don't finish cleanly, but you moved it in the right direction." Another pause. "Your father did too. In his way."

Aino thinks about the ledger entries. March, April, May, September. He called and hung up. He wrote names he couldn't deliver. He sat in the sauna for thirty years.

"He did what he could," she says.

"Yes," Louise says. "That's usually how it goes."

She and her family go. The Lehtinens go. Erik Saari shakes Aino's hand at the door — a real handshake, deliberate, meeting her eyes — and goes. The cars pull out one at a time onto the gravel, slow over the ruts, and then the yard is quiet and the only sound is the drip from the eaves and the faint tick of cooling stone down at the shore.

Mikko stays.

They sit at the kitchen table with the last of the coffee and the remains of the afternoon. The smoke is barely anything now, a haze over the foundation that the wind keeps thinning.

"How do you feel?" Mikko asks.

She thinks about it honestly. "Empty," she says. "Not bad empty. Just — like something that was full isn't anymore."

He nods. He doesn't try to fill it.

"She's still there," Aino says. "In the lake. I don't know what today meant for her. I don't know if it helped." She wraps her hands around her cup. "Louise said it's a beginning."

"Probably the most honest thing anyone can say about it."

She looks out the window at the haze. "A man is dead," she says. "Dale Numminen. He has a family somewhere."

"I know."

"I keep thinking about him. That he had nothing to do with any of this and it happened to him anyway." She pauses. "That's the thing about old wrongs, I think. They don't stay contained to the people who deserve them."

Mikko is quiet for a moment. "No," he says. "They don't."

They sit with that. Outside the drip is steady. After a while he reaches across the small distance between them and puts his hand over hers where it rests on the table, just for a moment — not a holding, not anything that asks to be answered, only the flat warmth of a palm laid over the back of her hand and then lifted again. He goes back to his coffee. Neither of them says anything about it. She finds that she is glad of it in a way she does not examine, the brief weight and then the lifting, a man telling her he is there in the only register he has.

He leaves before dark. He has the dog and the long drive back up the county road and he says he'll come by tomorrow, and she says all right, and she watches his truck take the bend and then she is alone in the house with the light going out of the windows and the foundation cooling down at the water's edge.

She makes herself eat something standing up at the counter. Then she takes her phone off the charger and she sits at the kitchen table in the dark and she calls her mother.

She has not done this in years — initiated it, dialed the number herself, sat and waited for Lila to pick up rather than letting Lila be the one who calls and the one who is owed the calling. It is not lost on her, the shape of it. She let her father's calls ring out for years and now she has spent a week learning what an unanswered call costs and tonight she is the one who picks up the phone. She does the thing she failed to do for him, for the parent who is still here to do it for.

Lila answers on the fourth ring. In Phoenix it is two hours earlier and the evening is warm and ordinary; Aino can hear a television somewhere behind her, the ordinary hum of a warm house a long way from this one.

"Aino," her mother says, and there is surprise in it, and under the surprise something else, quick and braced. "Is everything all right?"

"I'm fine. I'm still up at the house." She turns her cup a quarter turn on the table. "I'm selling it. I wanted you to know."

A pause. "All right," Lila says carefully. "That's — I think that's the right thing. There's no reason to keep it."

"No."

She doesn't tell her about the sauna or the foundation or the men at the shore or the name on the ledger. She tells her a sayable version: that there were things to deal with, things to do with people up here, that they're settled now, mostly, that the house is going to a couple from Marquette. She tells her the lake will be someone else's lake by summer.

Lila is quiet for a long time. Long enough that Aino looks at the screen to be sure the call is still connected.

"It was always quiet up there," her mother says finally, and it is the same thing she said weeks ago, the thing that made Aino want to ask a question she couldn't form. But this time Lila does not move on. This time the quiet on the line keeps going, and Aino does not fill it, and into it her mother says, very plainly, with no weight on any one word:

"I shouldn't have brought you back."

Aino does not say anything.

She had lived her whole life inside a thing she could not name. The summers — the drive north, the trees closing in, the silence that wasn't only silence, the cold off the water she could feel from the driveway before the lake even came into view. The certainty, never spoken to anyone, that something was wrong here, with the lake or the house or the family or all three at once, a wrongness she'd assumed was hers, a flaw in her own way of perceiving, because no one ever once said otherwise. And here, in the dark of her father's kitchen, is the one person who knew, who lived at this lake and felt it and left, and who put her child in the car summer after summer and drove her right back into it anyway. Her mother. Saying it. *I shouldn't have brought you back.*

It does not go through her like grief. It goes through her like a latch finding its catch. Something that had been holding itself at an angle her whole life turns, very slightly, and seats.

She feels it in her chest and then lower, in the long muscles of her back, a loosening she had not known was clenched. She is aware that her eyes have filled but she is not crying, not the way she cried at the fire; this is quieter than that and it is for herself, which the crying at the fire was not.

The thing she has waited her whole life to hear is a single sentence, and it is over in three seconds, and no one is going to say anything to follow it.

"You knew," Aino says. Not an accusation. Almost a question. Almost a thank-you.

"I knew enough," Lila says. "I told myself it was just the place. That you'd want your father." A breath. "I don't know what I knew. I knew I wanted to leave and I did and I kept bringing you back." Another pause, and then, in the old register, the surface coming back over the water: "How are the roads up there? They salting?"

"They're fine," Aino says. "Melt today. It's warming up."

"Good. You drive careful when you come down."

"I will."

They talk a few more minutes about nothing, about the drive south and the timing of it and whether she'll come through Chicago, and there is no reconciliation in it, no scene, nothing that would look like anything from the outside. But the sentence has been said. It is in the room with her now and it will be in the car with her when she drives, and it cannot be unsaid, and Aino understands that this is all she is going to get and that it is, against everything, enough.

"Goodnight, Mom," she says.

"Goodnight," Lila says. "I'm glad you called."

She is, Aino thinks. That much is true.

She sits at the table for a while after the line goes dead, in the dark, the phone face-down in front of her.

Outside the drip from the eaves has slowed as the temperature drops back toward freezing. The foundation at the water's edge is no longer glowing; it is just stone now, fieldstone Eino mortared a hundred years ago, going cold under the heavy snow. In a few weeks the ice will go out and the lake will open and the foundation will stand there in the sunlight, empty, just stones, just a rectangle of old rock the weather will slowly work on. That is fine. That is what stones do.

She thinks of the list she made days ago, the one still in her coat pocket. *What to do after*. She had not answered that item. She is not sure she can answer it tonight either, but it feels less like a wall than it did.

She thinks of Dale Numminen's family, who will have something to bury when the ice goes out. She thinks of her father, forty years in this house, the soup bowls in their place and the percolator on the counter. She thinks of the silence after Louise said *we see you* down at the shore, the quality of the air in that long quiet moment, and she thinks: yes. Something changed. She can't prove it and she won't try to.

She hopes, without knowing if hope is the right word, that whatever is in the lake is freer than it was this morning.

The rest of it — the summers, the cold, the thing she carried her whole life without a name for it, and the name her mother finally gave it tonight in three plain seconds across two thousand miles — the rest of it she will carry. Some things you just carry. She knows that now in a way she didn't a few weeks ago.

She gets up and puts the kettle on for tea and the evening settles down around her and the house is warm and the

smoke is gone and the lake outside is still.

CHAPTER 25

After

She gives herself a week.

The house needs to be gone through properly — not the frantic triage of the first few days but the real work, the kind that requires decision rather than just sorting. What goes with her, what goes to the Lutheran church thrift store, what goes in the dumpster she rents from a place in Iron Mountain that delivers it on a Thursday morning without comment.

The man who drops the dumpster does the work in under five minutes and is gone, and she stands looking at it in the yard, green and dented and far too large for one house, and thinks she will never fill it. She fills it. It takes four days.

The furniture she leaves for the estate sale, which Ernest Autio arranges through a woman in Marquette who does this for a living. The woman comes on a Friday and walks through the house with a clipboard, assigning values to things Aino has been looking at for five weeks without quite seeing. Her father's chair. The bookshelf of westerns. The kitchen table where she has eaten most of her meals since she arrived. The woman says the table is worth something, it's old, good wood. Aino tells her to sell it.

The woman is brisk and kind and treats the contents of the house as inventory, which is exactly what Aino needs. She asks no questions about the family. She mentions, while pricing the dishes, that she's been busy this spring, more estates than usual, the old people going and the children gone downstate with no use for any of it. She says it the way you'd remark on the weather. She prices the percolator at four

dollars and Aino tells her that one stays.

She keeps three things from the main house. The quilt her grandmother made her, which she folds and puts in the back seat of the Subaru. The photograph of herself at eight with the fish, which she wraps in a dish towel. And the percolator, which she wraps in a sweater and nestles into a box of kitchen things and then at the last minute takes out of the box and puts on the passenger seat, where she can see it.

The forty-two ledgers she goes back and forth on for days.

She reads through more of them — not all, she doesn't have time for all, but enough to understand the full shape of what they contain. Thirty years of her father's life in those pages. Thirty years of weather and ice and the other kind of entry, the ones that sound like a man talking to something he can't name. They are, she thinks, the most honest thing he ever wrote. More honest than the phone calls, more honest than the note he left in the envelope, because they were written without an audience, for no one, just a man and a lake and the thing in it and the words he used to describe the watching.

She wraps them carefully in plastic sheeting from the basement and packs them in a box and puts the box in the Subaru. She will figure out later whether they belong with Louise or with her or somewhere else. She's not ready to decide and she's learned, in the past few weeks, to trust that instinct.

The stone foundation at the water's edge she leaves alone. The ash and debris from the fire she leaves for weather and time. In spring, when the ice goes out, Louise and her family will come back. They said so. She has left a key with Mikko.

She goes into town twice that week, both times for things she could have done without — boxes from the hardware store, a roll of packing tape, gas — but the truth is the house gets to be too much by the middle of the afternoon and she needs to be a person in a place where other people are.

The first thing she sees is the sign in the window of Hakala's. FOR SALE, hand-lettered, and a phone number with a Marquette area code, and under it, smaller, BY OWNER. The Leinenkugel's sign is still lit in the other window, red and gold in the gray afternoon, which somehow makes it worse. She stands on the sidewalk and looks at it. Forty years, maybe more. Her father drank there. Paavo Maki drank there. It was where the neighbor figured out something was wrong the morning her father didn't show, because Hank always showed, and the not-showing was the first thing anyone noticed. Now there is a number to call.

The girl at the gas station tells her the rest of it, unasked, the way news moves up here. The diner closed in February — Aino had not known, had not thought to wonder — and now Hakala's, and the Marathon two towns over went to pumps-only with no one inside. The girl is maybe nineteen and says it without much feeling, the way you'd describe a road you don't drive anymore. Seven hundred and some people now, she says, like that's a number everybody carries. Aino remembers fourteen hundred. She remembers a town. She pays for the gas.

It is a hard week to be in Kivijärvi. There is a funeral notice taped inside the door of the gas station, photocopied, a young man's face — Dale Numminen, the snowmobiler, out of Tioga, gone through the ice at the inlet in the thaw. He wasn't from here but the funeral is here, the church up the hill, because the U.P. is small that way and the families know each other

across two counties. The flag at the post office is at half-staff and she doesn't know for whom — Numminen, or the season generally, or for Reino Saari, who went through the ice the same way and is simply gone, no body, nothing to put in the ground when it thaws. You can't bury a man you don't have. The town is doing its slow arithmetic of the dead and she is at the edge of it, a person passing through, and that is the right place for her to be.

She sees Erik Saari once, outside the hardware store, getting into his truck. Reino's brother. He looks like a man who has aged a winter in a month. She doesn't go to him. There is nothing she could say that would not be an intrusion, and she suspects he is grateful, in town, for the people who let him alone. She lifts a hand. He lifts one back. That is the whole of it.

She has a conversation with Ernest about the house. She is selling it below market because she wants it gone quickly and because market in Kivijärvi in early spring is not a number that requires much deliberation. There is a couple from downstate — Marquette, which barely counts as downstate up here, but close enough — who have been looking for a lake property and are willing to move fast. They have not been told anything about the sauna or the foundation or what happened here. Aino has thought about this and decided that what they don't know won't hurt them. The foundation is just stones. The lake is just a lake.

She hopes this is true.

She thinks it probably is, mostly.

—

Mikko comes over the last evening. She makes dinner — the last of what's in the refrigerator, a cobbled-together thing

involving eggs and the end of a loaf of bread and some cheese — and they eat at the kitchen table, which will be someone else's kitchen table by the end of the month. The dog stays in the truck with the window cracked, which he allows because Mikko tells him to, and once or twice during dinner Aino hears it shift and settle out there in the dark.

"You could stay," he says. Not for the first time, but differently this time — quieter, without the expectation of being argued with. He says it and then goes on eating, as if he has set the thing down on the table between them and has no intention of picking it back up.

"I have a job," she says. "An apartment."

"I know."

She looks at him across the table. He is looking at his plate with the expression of a man who has said what he wanted to say and is not going to belabor it. She has come, in these past weeks, to understand this about him — the saying of the thing once, cleanly, and then the letting it be. She finds it, against her expectations, one of the things she likes most about him.

"It's not that I don't —" she starts, and stops, because she doesn't know how that sentence ends and she's not going to fake the end of it. He waits. He's good at that, the waiting. "I don't know what I'm going back to," she says instead. "I mean I know what's there. The work. The people I know. I just don't know if it's — " She turns her fork over. "I've been here six weeks. The worst six weeks of my life, some of them. And I feel more like myself than I have in years. I don't know what to do with that."

"You don't have to do anything with it right now," he says.

"That's what people say."

"It's still true."

She almost smiles. "What about you," she says. "You could come down."

"To Milwaukee." He considers it the way he considers everything, without hurry, giving it real weight before he sets it aside. "I've got the crew. The plowing through April. The dog." He says it without self-pity, a man inventorying the actual shape of his life. "Laura's in Marquette. We don't talk, but she's there. I left once. Came back. I'm not built for leaving twice." He looks up. "That's not a no. It's just where I am."

"I know where you are," she says, and means more by it than the geography, and he hears the more and lets that be too.

They finish dinner. She washes the dishes and he dries them, which is something they've fallen into without discussing it, and she is aware of the specific domesticity of it, two people in a kitchen, the ordinary rhythm of the wash and the hand-off and the wipe and the stacking. The water goes from hot to lukewarm. There is one good knife and they both reach for it and laugh, a little, at nothing. She thinks about the apartment in Bay View. The radiator that will start banging at four in the morning as soon as the temperature drops. The building that looks indifferent when she leaves and indifferent when she comes home, which she had thought, for years, was what she wanted.

She thinks about this house. What it felt like to pull into the driveway that first night, in the dark, her father's truck sitting there. What it felt like to put her hand on the cold percolator. How much has happened in the room they are standing in.

"I'll come back," she says. She says it to the dish she's washing, not to him.

"Okay," he says.

He doesn't ask when. He doesn't say he'll hold her to it. He takes the dish out of her hand and dries it and puts it on the stack with the others, and the not-asking is the kindest thing he could have done, because she does not actually know if it's true. She wants it to be true. She has learned the difference between those two things this spring and she is not going to pretend, tonight, in this kitchen, that she hasn't.

Their hands meet over the next dish, briefly, the way accidental things happen, and then less accidentally, and neither of them says anything about it.

He leaves at nine. The dog is glad to see him. She stands in the doorway and watches the taillights go down the gravel road for what might be the last time and might not be, and she lets it be the second thing for as long as she can.

She goes back inside. The kitchen is clean. The house is nearly empty. The percolator sits on the counter and she looks at it for a moment and then leaves it where it is for tonight.

She goes to bed in her childhood bedroom under her grandmother's quilt and listens to the house — the furnace, the pines, the particular language of an old house settling into cold — and she falls asleep faster than she has since she arrived.

She does not dream.

In the morning she loads the Subaru. The percolator goes on the passenger seat. She locks the house and puts the key in the lockbox Ernest installed on the front porch. She stands in the driveway for a moment.

The lake is not visible from here. She can feel it anyway, the way she always could, the weight of that much cold water at the edge of the property, the particular quality of the air

that comes off it. She has been able to feel it her whole life, she thinks. She just never let herself know what she was feeling.

She gets in the car. She drives down the gravel road. At the end of it she turns south, toward the highway, toward Milwaukee, toward the life that is waiting for her to decide what to do with it.

She passes the cross street that goes down to the lake.

She doesn't stop.

But she slows.

CHAPTER 26

She Does Not Get Far

Highway 2 to 45 to 51. The same road in reverse, the trees opening up as she crosses back into Wisconsin, the right-of-way widening, the towns getting larger and farther apart in a different way — not the emptying-out of the iron range but the filling-in of the lower half of the state, more houses, more traffic, more of everything that means she is going south.

The percolator rides on the passenger seat. She has wrapped it in her fleece jacket and buckled the seatbelt around it, which she did without thinking about it and noticed only after, and left it.

The radio is on. The basketball season is still going — it is only March, there is still basketball to be played — and she finds a game and lets it run. The same big unhurried voice. Something definite happening.

She drives through Ironwood. She drives through Hurley. The body, she finds, leaves more slowly than the car. The car does sixty-five and the towns fall away behind her at sixty-five, and some part of her is paying them out like line off a reel, going with them, staying. She had expected the miles to subtract. To take a little of the house with each one, a little of the lake, until at some town with a stoplight and a Dollar General she would be only herself again, only Aino, going home. That is not what the miles do. They lengthen the thing between her and the place without thinning it. Her shoulders come down from her ears somewhere past Hurley — that much loosens, the watchfulness she'd carried for six weeks,

the held readiness of a person sleeping in a dead man's house. But underneath the watchfulness there is something that does not loosen, that the distance only draws out finer and tighter, a wire run north out of her sternum and anchored to a frozen shore she can no longer see. She is facing south. A part of her is still pointed the other way, the way a compass needle does not care which direction you walk.

She crosses back into Wisconsin and the road straightens and the sky opens up and she has the clear, clean feeling of a highway in front of her for a long distance, and behind her, steady, the weight of everything she is driving away from, not letting go.

She thinks about the six weeks. She lines them up in her mind the way she would line up the facts of a case at work, in order, each one leading to the next. The drive up. Hakala's. The house. The funeral. The will. The sauna. The ledgers. Tamarack. The shore. The fire. She can see the shape of it now from the outside, which she couldn't while she was in it — the way each thing opened the next, the way she kept going one step further than she'd planned, the way the book she'd thought she was reading turned out to be a different book entirely.

She thinks about Mikko. The way he dried dishes without being asked. The way he said *I'll come back* after she said it, quietly, as though he were testing the weight of it.

She thinks about her father's ledger. *I am running out of time to look.*

She is thirty-eight. She has time.

The question is what she wants to do with it.

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She stops for gas at the Kwik Trip off exit 185, Maple Ridge Road, north of Wausau — the same stretch of highway she'd been on the day the lawyer called, when she'd been on hold with Social Security and her whole life had changed direction without her permission. It had started snowing right about here, that first drive up. Now it is bare and brown, the median grass flattened and dead, the white sky pressing down the way it does in March before it has decided whether to be spring.

She fills the tank. The pump handle is cold through her glove. She goes inside for coffee, past the glass case of cheese curds and the cooler of half-gallon milk in the Kwik Trip way, and stands at the counter waiting for her change and becomes aware, gradually, of something she can't immediately name.

Not a sound. Not a feeling exactly. More like — a direction. A pull, faint but specific, the way you can feel a draft in a room without being able to say where it's coming from. It is coming from the northeast. She knows this without turning to check. She knows it the way she knew the lake was there even when she couldn't see it from the driveway, the weight of it sitting in the dark beyond the trees, attending.

She takes her change. She takes her coffee. She stands in the parking lot.

The highway is right there. South. Milwaukee is four hours. Her apartment, her job, the radiator that will start banging at four in the morning, the building that looks indifferent when she leaves it.

She gets in the car.

She pulls back onto the highway. The basketball game comes back on. She drives south and the pull is still there, specific and quiet, from the northeast, and she notes it the way her father would have noted it — in the language of

observation, without interpretation, a fact to be recorded and returned to.

She drives for another twenty minutes.

There is an exit. She has not planned to take it. It goes northeast, toward a part of Wisconsin she has driven through but doesn't know well — lake country, small towns, a different kind of quiet than the iron range. She doesn't know why this exit. She doesn't know what is up that road.

She takes it.

The highway recedes behind her. The trees close in on either side, not the pines of the U.P. but hardwoods, bare-branched, gray and white in the March light. The road narrows. A lake appears through the trees on her right, frozen, the ice still holding at the edges, open water showing dark at the center.

She slows.

The pull is stronger here. Not urgent, not alarming — the same quality as the thing under the hatch in the sauna, something that has been waiting a long time and has the patience of a thing that has been waiting a long time.

She pulls over on the shoulder and shuts the engine off, and the radio dies, and the heat dies, and in the quiet that comes in after them she understands that she is not only looking at the lake. The lake is the colder of the two of them and the cold comes off it the way it comes off an open freezer door, a slow exhalation across the ditch, through the seams of the car, onto the backs of her hands. The air near the water has a different grain than the air at the gas station, denser, older, the way a deep house feels different from a new one. She had thought of it as a pull, a draft, something with a source she was the subject of. Sitting here she revises it. It is not pulling. It is regarding her. Without eyes, without

urgency, with the long even attention of water under ice — it has registered that a person has stopped on its shore, and taken her in, and gone on holding still. Her father had this. She is sure of it now, sure of it in the cold on her hands: this was what he meant by *attending to the lake*, not watching it but being inside the circle of its noticing. She is inside it. It knows the shape of the car and the warmth going out of it and the small live heat of her, and it is in no hurry at all.

She thinks about what Louise said. *It's a beginning. Not an ending.*

She thinks about her father's note. *Maybe you will.*

She thinks about what she said in the sauna the second time, to the cold and the heat and whatever was listening: *I'm going to find out how to make it right.*

She picks up her phone. She searches for the county. She searches for recorded land disputes, for townships, for families. She is a paralegal. She knows how to read a paper trail.

She finds something in ten minutes that takes her another ten to understand fully. A property on this lake, a deed dispute going back four generations, a family name that appears in county records in 1887 and then in different records in 1921 and the gap between those two dates is the shape of something she recognizes.

She puts the phone down.

She looks at the lake.

She will call Louise. She will ask if she knows this lake, this family, this name. She will find out if there is someone else who needs to know what she now knows how to look for.

She doesn't do any of that yet. She just sits in the car on the shoulder of a road she didn't plan to take, the cold steady on the backs of her hands, and looks at a frozen lake she

didn't know existed this morning, and she thinks about her father counting the minutes of phone calls, and her grandfather going to a pastor who didn't understand the question, and her great-grandfather writing *kaunis* in a notebook in 1919, beautiful, underlined.

She thinks: I can hear it now.

She doesn't say it out loud. She doesn't need to.

She puts the car in drive.

She does not go back to the highway.

About the Author

Seven Martin writes quiet, literary folk horror rooted in the cold country of the Upper Midwest—its lakes, its long winters, and the things its families keep to themselves.

Anna Sen Mennä is the first novel.